Ven Anīgha Reddit Archive 2026

Ven Anīgha

2026

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Ven Anīgha Reddit Archive 2026

r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by craveminerals *2026-10-14 10:27:28* ### The difference between calming and avoiding

Sister Medhini wrote in a comment:

"It's not any relief of the pain that should be avoided; it's the attitude and action of resisting, avoiding and hiding from the pain; OR that of actively maintaining it in self-punishment."

She also explained that it makes a difference whether relief comes from hiding from the source of the pain or admitting it, and that how something feels is not a reference for its rightness or wrongness.

I can see how relieving distress by confessing wrongdoing is not an issue, as she mentioned in her example, but I've wondered how one might apply what she said to relaxation.

Let's say the mind is ungrateful and unappreciative in objectively good circumstances, or pessimistic and nihilistic, feeling that everything is pointless and in vain. One might try to shift the perspective to relieve the mind of this state, e.g., think of the good people do, challenge one's underlying assumptions, or take a longer look at things one takes for granted.

It seems that actions such as these need not fuel craving, since one is not necessarily trying to "replace" the mind with something else, but rather skilfully seeing how certain actions might unburden it and lighten it up.

But what about relaxation? Let's say the mind is anxious and tense. One might sit and rest, breathe, and eventually unwind, bringing relief from that unpleasant feeling.

This outward action may be done out of craving, or it might not be, correct? If so, **what distinguishes skilful relaxation from using relaxation or a meditation technique to escape unpleasant feelings?**

Is it that the mind might demand to be calm and undisturbed all the time, and that one might mistake the calm resulting from deliberate relaxation as a goal in itself? That, when struck by anxiety or unease, one is averse to it and tries

to escape it, rather than letting it remain “in front of you” while calming down in the face of it?

From what I’ve gathered, one danger of seeking calm no matter what is that it would spoil and weaken the mind by avoiding all situations, thoughts and contemplations that would make it anxious. One cannot stay in a “safe bubble” indefinitely and expect the mind to grow.

If there is something I’m missing, or probably should be aware of, I would appreciate your feedback.

Thank you in advance!

Sister_Medhini *2026-10-16 05:07:00*

> Let’s say the mind is ungrateful and unappreciative in objectively good circumstances, or pessimistic and nihilistic, feeling that everything is pointless and in vain. One might try to shift the perspective to relieve the mind of this state, e.g., think of the good people do, challenge one’s underlying assumptions, or take a longer look at things one takes for granted.

This would definitely be fueling craving. As would sitting and breathing to try and relax and relieve the anxiety.

> what distinguishes skilful relaxation from using relaxation or a meditation technique to escape unpleasant feelings?

If the starting point is aversion to the state of mind, then whatever you do will be trying to escape unpleasant feelings, no matter how skilfully you try to go about it.

What I was trying to explain in that comment was simply that ‘I must not act out of aversion’ is not the same as ‘I must never experience relief of any kind.’ How you feel is not a measure of what you should do.

So if in the examples you gave, the mind is irrational, ungrateful, pessimistic etc, and you have the idea or impulse do something about it: it’s not like you must not have that impulse, but you must question that as well. “Regardless of whatever ideas I have and theories I have about it, why do I really want to do this right here and now? Why do I assume this is a problem?”

And the same applies to WHATEVER you might be assuming you should do in regard to a state of mind that you assume is an issue for whatever reason. However right you think it is, you should still question your own starting point for it.

Recognising the resistance underlying that very impulse to ‘lighten or unburden’ the state of mind is how you contain it properly without doing anything extra. And that is ironically where the actual ‘relief’ is, but in order to arrive

at that, you have to refrain from automatically seeking relief where you expect it to be.

craveminerals

Thank you Sister!
I'm wondering if you can clarify some things for me and offer your perspective- I hope you don't mind me asking about several things at once.

So would you say that if my mind is stressed out and wants to sit and relax, I should simply be aware of that impulse and refrain from following it, at least for the time being, if the motivation is to gain relief?

I'm having difficulty reconciling this approach with a comment I've found from Bhante Anigha, in response to someone who thought it was safer to avoid acting on even the slightest impulse:

"The things that have to be categorically avoided are not the 'tiny pushes.' They are the big pushes that usurp your perspective, and preventing that is what the precepts are for […] So learn to stay within the tiny pushes and to recognize when a push starts to grow past a certain point. And you'll need to learn for yourself what that 'point' is through repeated practice; it's not something you can recognize through mere reasoning."

How is following the ''tiny push'' to read about Dhamma, for example, different from that of following the tiny push to sit quietly with a broad awareness, including the body and breath? On paper, one could say that reading about Dhamma, contemplating the Buddha's qualities, or going for a walk involves aversion to feeling uninspired or dull.

There are also two Suttas that I was hoping you could comment on.
HH emphasizes the work that must precede proper anapanasati, but hypothetically let's say that's covered. In SN 54.9, it's said that *''it disperses and settles unskillful qualities on the spot whenever they arise."* How should one understand this in relation to the idea that seeking relief from an unpleasant state of mind involves aversion?

And in MN 19, the Bodhisatta evaluated thoughts of renunciation, good will and harmlessness, and he saw no danger in thinking those thoughts even all night and day (but that thinking excessively would be tiresome and stressful). Would you say the key point here is that one must not make relief from pain the purpose or requirement of this thinking and pondering, whatever it may be about? Even if that may come as a natural result.

Sister_Medhini *2026-10-16 17:36:10*

I would need to clarify the question. Correct me if I am wrong:

1. It sounds to you like I am saying one should never act on the slightest impulse, especially those involving seeking relief. Which obviously would

seem to conflict with other advice you've heard.

2. The Bodhisatta practiced actively thinking thoughts of renunciation, ill-will and harmlessness, and you want to know how that is different from the examples you gave in your post.

Is this basically what you are asking?

3. And as for the part about anapanasati:

   In SN 54.9, it's said that ''it disperses and settles unskillful qualities on the spot whenever they arise." How should one understand this in relation to the idea that seeking relief from an unpleasant state of mind involves aversion?

I don't quite understand the issue about it. There's nothing in the sutta about anapanasati getting rid of unpleasant states of mind and providing relief from them. So I don't see how it would conflict in any way with what I said.

craveminerals

Excuse me— I'll try to be more clear.

1. You said it would fuel craving if one were to sit and breathe to try and relax and relieve anxiety, but I wonder how that action would be different, in terms of craving, from other (seemingly) neutral things one may do— out of a 'tiny push'. Couldn't it be equally harmless, even if relief is part of the motivation?
2. How might we distinguish between attempts to "shift the perspective" out of aversion from the active thinking and pondering the Bodhisatta did in MN 19? Examples aside from what I mentioned in the post might be: trying to see "the bigger picture", contemplations of devas, saints or inspiring qualities in others.
3. Let's drop this one, I had a surface-level, vague reading of SN 54.9 but nevertheless thought it was relevant. It says akusala/unwholesome states are dispersed, but that says nothing about whether they are unpleasant, or whether the practice is undertaken to relieve oneself of them.

A better example would be SN 46.53 which says: *"…when the mind becomes excited, it is timely to develop the enlightenment factor of tranquillity, the enlightenment factor of concentration, and the enlightenment factor of equanimity. For what reason? Because the mind is excited, bhikkhus, and it is easy to calm it down with those things."*

At first glance, this can be read as 'countering' the present state of mind, but surely this is done without aversion in this case. The question is, how and when is that possible. (From what I've gathered from HH, a significant familiarity with the citta is required). Ultimately, I'm trying to understand

how there can be ”countering” without aversion- perhaps you can help me with that.

Thank you Sister for taking the time to answer my questions.

Sister_Medhini *2026-10-17 11:55:07*

> You said it would fuel craving if one were to sit and breathe to try and relax and relieve anxiety, but I wonder how that action would be different, in terms of craving, from other (seemingly) neutral things one may do—out of a ‘tiny push’. Couldn’t it be equally harmless, even if relief is part of the motivation?

First, you quite clearly expressed that the relaxation you are referring to is about actively trying to change or remove a state of mind because it is bothering you. That is not an irrelevant thing done out of a ‘tiny push’.

Second, the specific actions you were referring to are not just a plainly mundane thing like going for a walk. They are things that you are explicitly connecting with practice of the dhamma (“isn’t this sutta saying….”).

So the problem, and what I am saying, is not that you must be able from the start to completely abstain from any attempt to manage suffering or ‘relax’. The problem is in taking any such management as an acceptable or even ‘right’ thing to do. Which is what happens when people start confusing the management with practice of the dhamma.

If you are thinking like that, you can’t be maintaining the criteria that *you shouldn’t have to do anything* on account of arisen pain, and that’s the most important criteria that should never be compromised. So:

> I’m trying to understand how there can be ”countering” without aversion

Unless you have first learned to fulfill the criteria above, there can’t. Otherwise, any idea of “countering” you have is bound to be affected with aversion. So first and foremost, you need to keep that criteria in mind and make it a priority to recognise the aversion for yourself.

Said differently, the closest thing to countering an arisen pressuring state of mind that you can at least aim tp practice right from the start, is simply not acting out of it. If you don’t give in to it when the pressure is to give in, and also don’t try to get rid of it when there’s the pressure to get rid of it, that is directly unfueling (i.e. countering) the actual problem and bypassing the symptoms. But it doesn’t necessarily feel right.

> How might we distinguish between attempts to ”shift the perspective” out of aversion from the active thinking and pondering the Bodhisatta did in MN 19? Examples aside from what I mentioned in the

> post might be: trying to see “the bigger picture”, contemplations of devas, saints or inspiring qualities in others.

His thinking and pondering was aimed at what is actually kusala in principle. If you were to want to emulate this practice, you can’t just take up any form of thinking that you assume is good. Reflect on the value of not acting out on the level described above. Think about the criteria of not having to do anything, what it means and what it would feel like. Ask yourself whether your values and day to day actions are really aligned with it. Find places where you see you’re not really ‘on the same page’ as the instruction you’re following, and try and address that by questioning yourself further.

Note that what all these lines of thinking have in common is that they will most probably NOT initially make you feel calmer and happier, but rather the opposite. So again, how you feel is not a measure of what’s good or bad.

gradua1_training

Hello Ayye, so to summarize. Would it be correct to say that the problem isn’t necessarily doing things that provide relief (assuming you’re not breaking the precepts), but it is when that action is being done in order to change/get rid of the state of mind rather than to calm oneself *within* the agitating state of mind.

With the former action being underlined by a view that agitating states of mind should not be there, thus need to be done away with. While the latter might be able to be done without assuming that one is justified in not needing to endure their mind for what it is.

So for example, a meditation technique is more than a ‘tiny push’ since the activity is done with the implicit or explicit goal to achieve a certain state of mind at the expense of one’s current state of mind. Fueling the notions that its the state of mind that is the issue, rather than one’s assumption that they ought to feel good/not feel bad.

Meanwhile, correct endurance differs in that one is learning how to calm down within the pain, by undermining the attitude that something needs to be done with regard to the pain. So one then needs to learn to act, without their actions being underlain by the intention to avoid the need to endure whatever has arisen.

Sister_Medhini *2026-10-17 19:05:35*

That’s basically correct. It’s just quite important to remember that any kind of correct ‘calming down within the pain’ can only happen WITHIN the thoroughly-trained capacity to not-act-out-of-nor-get-rid-of-the-pain. I.e. to be unmoved by it. The best kind of relief is not *needing* to do anything to get relief.

The ‘calming’ is not a different practice to that, it’s an extention and refinement of the same principle, just applied to the citta that is by then even more clearly-seen and understood. You cannot train the two side by side from the start.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Majestic_Junket_8208 *2026-10-12 18:38:27*
Celibacy for a lay person makes sense?

Is it possible for someone who wishes to live a better and more wholesome life (Committing to the 5 precepts) to overcome the sexual pull and the craving towards love/romantic partnership through celibacy even thought they still choose to live a normal life, have worldly goals and delight in the company of family/friends?

The goal being to live a calmer and more peaceful life where one does not rely on having a partner for their own well being, living alone and practicing moderation towards sense desires.

I do question this because the way i understood the teaching so far, as long as one does not renounce the world, craving will always be there, so does that mean that if one does not renounce the whole world he will be always craving towards everything, including things he did actually give up (such as sex and love) no matter his efforts? Or there will be craving towards only the parts where the confinement of the mind is not developed, in this case the delight in company and entertainment.

Does craving diminishes towards specific things or its all or nothing?

Sister_Medhini *2026-10-13 14:51:53*

Fully overcoming sexuality is not possible without renouncing sensuality as a whole. But taming it to a good degree through living a celibate life is not an unreasonable goal.

However, you should take into consideration that this will not work in the long run without committing to sense restraint as well - i.e., you would need to be prepared to abstain, not only from sexual activities and relationships, but engaging with things that would be conducive to sending the mind in the direction of those desires.

It’s this aspect of sense restraint, rather than celibacy per se, which will make it difficult to live a ‘normal life’ at the same time. It means, at the very least, a serious amount of care and limitation regarding the

> delight in the company of family/friends

As well as the content and entertainment you choose to engage with. E ntertainment involving romance and sexuality obviously needs to be avoided, as

well as any personal interaction with members of the opposite sex beyond practical necessity.

Without a proper guard for your senses, it's only a matter of time before your mind changes its mind, and you will be dragged with it.

So practically, all this would have to entail a big change in one's lifestyle as a whole. There will frequently be times when friendships and other values will come into conflict with upholding this goal, and you'll have to ask yourself which you value more. It means being willing to go through quite a lot of internal conflict and withstanding a lot of pressure from inside and out.

But if you're willing to take that on, and you pair it with frequent reflection on the dangers of the desires you want to overcome, it would indeed result in the strength of desires and wildness of the mind diminishing to quite a considerable degree, and being more peaceful and more self-contained to that extent.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Pinglite *2026-09-30 07:07:40* ### Is progress possible while suicidal?

For the benefit of anyone who takes the time to read this, know that I'm not in some temporary depressive state in need of immediate encouragement to stay alive.

It's not my intention for anyone to feel pressured or responsible for my life so please be at ease.

My Current Stage:

I’ve taken on the seven precepts, starting around two months ago.

I have currently limited myself to two mealtimes on the weekdays, eating only once on both days of the weekend. I have had some issues around indulgence in food (it’s still within my allotted meal-time but I feel urged to eat more to extend the duration) which have sprung up and I still sometimes give in to.

Additionally I replaced both my old bed with a lower one with a firm mattress, and my old overly comfortable pillow with a basic one.

I had friends I would spend time with discussing all sorts of unbeneficial topics whom I’ve now limited contact with to being about important life events only.

I am living at home with one family member and monitor my participation in conversation to avoid the 3 types of wrong speech, and I try to minimize talk unrelated to necessary duties otherwise.

The hardest jump for me was with entertainment. While I don’t see the danger in it, I will not be going back, since I’ve recognized that it’s value for me was in forgetting that I exist without ever actually helping me.

Problem:

I've been suicidal most of my life, do not recall a time beforehand. I'll exclude further detail since I don't believe it'd be helpful.

If it's needed I have no issue elaborating.

Basically, I've always viewed suicide as an option, and if it weren't for entertainment I would have taken it by now. Now that I'm going to be avoiding the aforementioned distractions for the rest of my life my only reason to stay alive is to see if this practice works.

I'm familiar enough with the content talks to have heard the point with regard to sensuality that you shouldn't rely on progress first to justify giving it up. I wonder if that applies in this situation?

If I am open to the possibility of committing suicide, does that in and of itself prevent the kind of progress that would encourage me to value continued practice over suicide?

While that last question was in general, more specifically does openness to suicide constitute a fault regarding the precept on abstaining from taking life? Would I be unable to understand what sense-restraint is until I've internally abandoned the possibility of suicide?

Assuming in advance the worst-case where I'm guaranteed to make no progress until suicide is abandoned, how would I go about abandoning it? The uncertainty regarding the outcome is why I became interested in the Dhamma given that supposedly verifiable certainty in this life is possible.

It's a direct upgrade for the goal of ending suffering permanently since if true it provides insurance against any after-life shenanigans.

However, my taking on of this practice is conditioned upon the idea that I'll see for myself that it's worthwhile, without which my response to possibility of future suffering would be suicide.

I'll cease my jabbering there.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-10-02 15:06:55*

> I'm familiar enough with the content talks to have heard the point with regard to sensuality that you shouldn't rely on progress first to justify giving it up. I wonder if that applies in this situation?

Yes, it applies to whatever kind of emotional dependence you start with.

> If I am open to the possibility of committing suicide, does that in and of itself prevent the kind of progress that would encourage me to value continued practice over suicide?

Having a mind that inclines towards suicide is not by itself the obstruction. It's the extent to which you don't feel an acute need to overcome that inclination, i.e., that you justify it or downplay it (and the same applies for sensuality).

> While that last question was in general, more specifically does openness to suicide constitute a fault regarding the precept on abstaining from taking life?

No. It's not a precept breach strictly speaking, but the result is similar. Delighting in suicide is a coping mechanism in regard to suffering which you'll need to give up to be able to realize the true escape from it.

> Assuming in advance the worst-case where I'm guaranteed to make no progress until suicide is abandoned, how would I go about abandoning it?

Same as with sensuality: by enduring the pull of the mind. It's not about forcing the mind to stop wanting it; it's about not letting it have what it wants even as a hypothetical. So if you keep the context that you will never commit suicide no matter what, never welcoming that possibility even in thought, the mind will let go of it eventually.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by boredman_ny *2026-09-15 20:51:34 ###* Question about "The Arrow" vs. "The Abyss" suttas

I've been reading about the interpretation of the Arrow Sutta from HH and I'm having some doubts.

So, the interpretation of the Arrow sutta, as far as I understood reading the notes and comments from HH is that:

1. The Arrow sutta is talking about the difference between Sekha vs. Puthujjana, and not an Arahant vs. Puthujjana.
2. The Sekha is not strucked by the second arrow, which would be not knowing the escape from the unpleasant feeling by way of the body/kayika.
3. The Sekha only feels *one feeling*, kayika vedhana. So, for the sekha, there is suffering only on the account of the body: kayika dukkha vedana. They only feel *one* arrow.

4. The Arahant, however, feels no arrow at all. For them, feelings are not arrows or they don't feel feeling at all? Here, I understand that is something in line of what Nanavira was saying, although, less definitively: "There is, and there is not, contact in the case of the arahat, just as there is, and there is not, consciousness."

If the understanding above is somehow correct, this interpretation is based on two conceptions: kayika vedhana is not physical sensations, although it includes it, kayika dukkha vedana can be even mental suffering, referring to the mano: "The feeling arising from the death of a loved one or from an unpleasant mood would thus also be "bodily", i.e., pertaining to the five aggregates.", from a note to that sutta. And, since there is no contact for the Arahant (Contacts contact dependent on ground / How should contacts contact a groundless one?)

So, a sekha being tortured, although they probably will feel immense pain from the six senses and even get mentally confused by the immense pain, their citta will not look for sensuality as an escape and get desperate because it cannot find escape, which is the second arrow. Am I thinking correctly?

Now, my maing doubt is regarding this:

> In the same way, bhikkhus, an unlearned ordinary person, when struck by unpleasant feeling, sorrows, wails, laments, beats their breast, and becomes disoriented. They feel two feelings: a bodily one as well as one pertaining to the citta.
>
> Struck by that same unpleasant feeling, they resist it. *Thus, the underlying tendency to resistance against unpleasant feeling underlies them.*
>
> Struck by unpleasant feeling, they delight in the pleasure of sensuality. Why is that? Because, bhikkhus, an unlearned ordinary person does not understand any escape from unpleasant feeling apart from the pleasure of sensuality. Since they delight in the pleasure of sensuality, *the underlying tendency to passion for pleasant feeling underlies them.*
>
> They do not understand as they are the origin, ending, gratification, peril, and escape from those feelings. Since they do not understand as they are the origin, ending, gratification, peril, and escape from those feelings, *the underlying tendency to ignorance with regard to neither-pleasant-nor-unpleasant feeling underlies them.*

So, here, the Buddha talks about that the ariya does not have an underlying tendency to patigha towards it (not aversion?), passion for pleasant feeling (greed?) and ignorance with regard to neutral feeling (delusion?) does not underlying them. How can this does not mean not-greed, not-aversion, not-delusion for a sekha? Which cannot be, since they still have it?

Hope someone can help me clarify these. I would appreciate an article on this sutta detailing these, since it goes against basically how everybody else interprets these.

Edit: Ignore the title of the post. I was gonna use that sutta because the Buddha uses saririka vedāna there in an equivalent manner as kayika vedana here, but I thought unnecessary, and forgot to change the title.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-09-17 14:17:13*

> And, since there is no contact for the Arahant (Contacts contact dependent on ground / How should contacts contact a groundless one?)

Yes.

> So, a sekha being tortured, although they probably will feel immense pain from the six senses and even get mentally confused by the immense pain, their citta will not look for sensuality as an escape and get desperate because it cannot find escape, which is the second arrow. Am I thinking correctly?

Yes.

> So, here, the Buddha talks about that the ariya does not have an underlying tendency to patigha towards it (not aversion?), passion for pleasant feeling (greed?) and ignorance with regard to neutral feeling (delusion?) does not underlying them. How can this does not mean not-greed, not-aversion, not-delusion for a sekha? Which cannot be, since they still have it?

It does mean that. As you yourself noted, the Sutta is meant to illustrate the contrast between puthujjana and sekha (and thereby show the former what they have to do to become the latter). The statement “they still have greed, aversion, delusion” takes an Arahant for comparison instead of a puthujjana.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Drevix645 *2026-09-12 17:13:46* ### Training Rightly with Discomforts

How does one distinguish bearing discomforts, on the level of things mentioned as “Influxes to be abandoned by bearing” in Sabbasava Sutta (MN2), enduring discomfort on the right level, even perhaps introducing them, versus doing so mechanically or not on the right level, like someone with no interest in Dhamma practice who can endure extreme conditions?

My answer would be that it comes down to discerning the mind. Rightly bearing discomforts means rightly bearing the mind experiencing discomforts, because abandoning the craving on the level of the mind is the point, not the

discomforts themselves. Anything else is not the right bearing, which anyone can do with enough reason to do so.

I ask this question because I can (seem to) recognize instances where my mind has aversion towards discomforts like being hungry, being cold, etc. On one hand, I can make sense of an idea like “If I intentionally exposed the mind to some more of this (within reason and not exceeding my limits), that would be useful.” But what does it mean from my point of view for it to be useful? So it does not complain, desire against those things does not arise, and this way it can be stronger and more peaceful when adversity comes its way. But then, could this be coming from my own aversion? Do I assume the complaining mind is the problem I need to solve, and not my attitude in regard to the mind with aversion? Do I assume the arising of desire itself is the problem I need to prevent from happening? Maybe that’s not correct, but I still feel somehow this kind of exposure can be useful if one’s intentions are clear.

So I’m curious, what is the correct place from which to do this, if it is correct at all, and not done for obviously wrong reasons like conceit and ego and such?

This question comes from the context of keeping the 8 precepts for the last several months, and wondering if this could be additionally beneficial for my particular challenge, which is being quite concerned about not eating enough food, even at the right time. I’ve had times where whatever mental state felt too overwhelming in tandem with trying to eat a bit less, and would stress eat even though it was in the right time, which isn’t in the spirit of the precept which of course only led to wanting to do that more, though not at the wrong time. So, it made me think about introducing learning to better endure some hunger/not eating as much as I would like to under more stable conditions, but I know these sort of things can become easily taken over by one’s external sense of duty too.

Thank you!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-09-14 15:19:32*

> My answer would be that it comes down to discerning the mind. Rightly bearing discomforts means rightly bearing the mind experiencing discomforts, because abandoning the craving on the level of the mind is the point, not the discomforts themselves. Anything else is not the right bearing, which anyone can do with enough reason to do so.

Correct.

> But then, could this be coming from my own aversion?

It could be. It’s usually aversion to the mind’s dislikes—to it’s nature of experiencing certain things as unpleasant (or pleasant for that matter). Not seeing that this nature is not craving in and of itself, assuming that you’re training

the mind just because something is unpleasant and you're enduring it, is how you fall into self-mortification.

It's not wrong to take on such restraints if you make sure the effort doesn't become linked to a specific object or situation but that, as you said, you always take them on chiefly in relation to the mind. So you're not eating less because you associate that with greater diligence and effort, but because you see that *for you, there and then,* it goes against the grain of *this* craving. There is no inference or hope involved.

Edit: fixed typo

Drevix645

Thank you for your reply Bhante.

It seems to me the main theme is non-blindness. Seeing (and recollecting) the clear connection of why whatever I'm taking on is valuable for strengthening the mind. In my case, I clearly know I find some measure of comfort/safety in eating more, and I know eating less can increase the pressure alongside other things, so it feels to me there's work to be done there, balancing between what I can manage and what would be too much.

It sounds also like you can't make a blanket rule out of such things - I will only eat so much and that will always be what I do, because you said "for you, there and then, it goes against the grain of this craving." So it could very well be on one occasion, eating less goes against the grain. On another occasion, eating more could be against the grain. So I guess one could estimate some general baseline of eating enough just to sustain one through the next day, but beyond that it sounds like something that just demands case-by-case judgement.

On the subject of balancing what one takes on, as far as things one is fairly confident would increase the experience of pressure, do you have any advice on the "pacing" of that so to speak? On the one hand, taking on too much too soon would lead to breaking one's baseline and having to build that back up. On the other hand, one doesn't have forever to pursue this training. I've found it hard to know the right balance of this. I know it must be to some extent trial and error, and I lean on the side of caution due to my previous tendencies of yo-yoing between taking on lots at once and then backsliding, but I'd be curious to hear your perspective too.

Thank you!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-09-17 13:46:54*

> So I guess one could estimate some general baseline of eating enough just to sustain one through the next day, but beyond that it sounds like something that just demands case-by-case judgement.

Yes.

> I've found it hard to know the right balance of this. I know it must be to some extent trial and error, and I lean on the side of caution due to my previous tendencies of yo-yoing between taking on lots at once and then backsliding, but I'd be curious to hear your perspective too.

In this example, see if there is anything in regard to the precepts and sense restraint that you're still stumbling with, and fix that before you start clamping down on food consumption. Do you still find yourself close to breaking precepts and having to hold yourself back? If not, then are your thoughts and intentions fully restrained in regard to coarser forms of sensuality and ill will? If not then leave the food issue for later.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by upasakatrainee *2026-09-03 16:33:25 ###* Question on Recent Video "Is Stream Entry an Event"

u/Bhikkhu_Anigha
Hello Bhante. Could I ask a couple of clarifications on your most recent video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BnQrGm_Lxks)

1. Regarding the memory of the "event of realization" (of the adze-handle having indeed worn out), and the analogy with understanding Calculus:

With the Calculus analogy, is it not correct that one can know with certainty that one *now understands* something which one *previously did not understand*, while nevertheless being unable to identify the *precise point in time* at which the transition from not-understanding to understanding occurred?

If so, is the analogy intended to *apply fully* (as above) to the "event of realization" as well — i.e. that one can subsequently remember having realized, without that memory necessarily identifying a **definite crossover point** in time?

Or, is it the case that there is simply a limitation to the analogy here, such that the "event of realization" **is in fact** a phenomenologically identifiable **precise crossover point**, which one can remember as having occurred **at a particular time**, even though the Calculus analogy would not capture this?

In other words, I am wondering whether the uncertainty about *when* the transition occurred, is part of the phenomenology of realization itself, or merely a limitation of the Calculus analogy.

2. Regarding the Buddha's former teachers and other ascetics having "wrong practice":

I was wondering about the precise sense in which you are using the word "wrong."

Is it meant in the **full and literal sense** that their practice was fundamentally misguided and wayward (to the same extent as the 6 ascetics with wrong views referred to by King Ajātasattu in DN2), despite whatever virtue, restraint, collectedness, etc. they had developed? Or is the point that their practice was "wrong" specifically because it lacked the **decisive element** of Right View, while **nevertheless containing substantial development** in other respects?

I ask because these seem like rather different possibilities which listeners might infer. Also, "ascetic practice" could easily be understood as referring to self-mortification of the sort practised by the Jains, whereas Āḷāra Kālāma and Uddaka Rāmaputta, for example, had developed very refined forms of samādhi (The Buddha's consideration of Āḷāra and Uddaka as having "little dust in their eyes" also seems relevant here).

And relatedly, isn't there a significant distinction here between those who had **not yet heard the Dhamma**, and practitioners today **who have access to it**, but nevertheless pursue practices incompatible with it?

Examples such as Koṇḍañña, Bāhiya, and Uruvelā Kassapa also come to mind, where they **did give up** their former practice once the Buddha pointed out where to look. Is it not reasonable to understand their prior development as having been an important condition for their ability to recognize and follow what the Buddha was pointing out (which would make it possible to say that they weren't **entirely** wrong).

So I was wondering whether you **intentionally meant** that their practice was simply "wrong" without such qualification, or is it again simply a semantic limitation of the word?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-09-04 14:25:25*

> If so, is the analogy intended to apply fully (as above) to the "event of realization" as well — i.e. that one can subsequently remember having realized, without that memory necessarily identifying a definite crossover point in time?

It does apply fully, and that was precisely the point of the analogy.

> the "event of realization" is in fact a phenomenologically identifiable precise crossover point

Certainly not. It's not like there is a "switch" that could have flipped without you noticing it (which is what the "precise crossover point" idea allows for), because the realization itself *is the noticing.* Stream-entry is *knowing that you know.*

Similarly, nothing along the lines of "my experience changed in such and such a way" can ever be a measure of stream-entry. Even "my suffering has uninterruptedly lessened to almost zero for the last X amount of years" is not

understanding, and can certainly happen without it. You would be *inferring* that understanding occurred because of the change, and inference is diametrically opposed to *knowing that you know.*

> So I was wondering whether you intentionally meant that their practice was simply “wrong” without such qualification, or is it again simply a semantic limitation of the word?

If something misleads you regarding freedom from suffering then it is wrong. When you’re comparing practices as an external observer then you can talk about “more wrong” and less “wrong.” But internally, as an authentic individual who is committed to something for the sake of liberation—which was the context of my statement—that something is either correct or not, and you will give it up if you recognize it as the latter. You would not knowingly settle for “less wrong.”

upasakatrainee

> because the realization itself *is the noticing.* Stream-entry is *knowing that you know.*

Thank you Bhante, it seems that what I had in mind is supported by your clarification — but let me restate for any potential correction: It is an “event” in the sense of a *distinctly knowable occurrence*, such that one *can remember* with certainty that “this happened; **before this, I didn’t know it; now I do**,” while the precise temporal coordinates and circumstantial details may later fade away like any other memory. Does that sound right?

> … comparing practices as an external observer then you can talk about “more wrong” and less “wrong.” But internally…

This fully clarifies it. Thank you!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-09-05 14:11:59*

> It is an “event” in the sense of a distinctly knowable occurrence, such that one can remember with certainty that “this happened; before this, I didn’t know it; now I do,” while the precise temporal coordinates and circumstantial details may later fade away like any other memory. Does that sound right?

There is no “this happened.” One realizes that one’s understanding is no longer subject to doubt by directly seeing that it is no longer subject to doubt; that certainty is not inferred from any kind of event or occurrence.

What one can remember is the occasion on which one first confirmed that one’s understanding had overcome doubt: despite arousing a genuine sense of uncertainty by trying to doubt it, that uncertainty poses no threat at all to one’s clarity.

It is not that no uncertainty arises and therefore one is certain. The absence of uncertainty merely means that one has *decided* to hold back on questioning.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by EmptinessInForm *2026-08-30 12:04:30* ### Deconstructing the Non-Technique Fallacy: Why Neuroscience Proves Focused Attention Doesn't "Corrupt" Background Awareness, and why Backround (peripheral) vs foreground attention is a false dichotomy (article)

Hey,

Psychology student here.

First of all I want to say that I highly respect Hillside Hermitage. However, I believe some of their interpretations are based on a false dichotomy in regards to how the mind actually works to create reality, so I decided to write an article. I hope this might contribute to bring the meditation space forward towards higher understanding. Also, I hope I haven't misrepresented HH.

For years, a central dogma of the non-technique meditation movement—most aggressively championed by groups like Hillside Hermitage—has been that intentional focused attention is an artificial distortion that "corrupts" a pristine, unconstructed background awareness. But when scrutinized through modern cognitive neuroscience, this rigid separation between a foreground spotlight and a peripheral background collapses into a complete false dichotomy.

Your "background context" isn't a passive, unmanaged space—it is an actively manufactured product built millisecond-by-millisecond by the exact same sub-attentional machinery that powers focus.

Core Arguments Breakdown:

Visual and bodily neuroscience demonstrates that even during gaze fixation, the brain executes automatic, involuntary microsaccades (1–3 Hz) alongside covert spatial polling to constantly refresh your peripheral baseline. Without this underlying micro-attention, the subjective sense of an "enduring bodily background" completely collapses (as seen in clinical conditions like hemispatial neglect).

Single Computational Resource (Load Theory): Nilli Lavie's Load Theory shows that background awareness is simply spare processing capacity spilling over from your primary target. Foreground and background do not run on two separate engines; they share the same attentional pool.

Effort vs. Direction: What causes "attentional blinks" and cognitive tunneling isn't the *presence* of intentional focus, but the *intensity of cognitive effort*. A high-load vise-like focus blinds you to context, whereas a relaxed, low-effort anchor leaves ample processing capacity open to illuminate the broader background.

Ego-Suppression via Top-Down Control: Goal-directed focus recruits the Dorsal Attention Network (DAN), which actively down-regulates the Default Mode Network (DMN)—the brain's primary hub for self-referential narrative. Far from fabricating an artificial "doer," top-down low-load focus actually quiets the narrative self.

Because the brain relies on continuous, sub-attentional feature-sampling to generate the sensation of a bodily background in the first place, intentional focus does not introduce an artificial intruder into a pristine field. By intentionally holding a light, low-effort anchor, we harness the brain's natural mechanics to achieve both crystal-clear discernment and panoramic, contextual stillness.

https://medium.com/@EmptinessInForm/the-cognitive-mechanics-of-attention-in-meditation-an-attempt-to-reconcile-intentional-focus-with-40339c52fae0?sharedUserId

TL;DR: Background awareness isn't a passive, unconstructed ground—it's actively maintained millisecond-by-millisecond by sub-conscious attentional sampling. Because foreground focus and peripheral context share the exact same cognitive engine, holding a low-effort anchor doesn't corrupt your awareness; it simply stabilizes the mind while leaving spare capacity open to illuminate the background.

Edit:

I definitely would drop words like pristine and unconstructed background if I were to write this up again; that's a mischaracterisation of HH. I think it would be better to say that the background that HH refers to is:

"The unchosen, structural dimension of experience that endures simultaneously alongside whatever is currently being directly attended to."

My article is an attempt to assess the fact that awareness of said background requires attention, thus discriminating it as strictly a "background" is a false dichotomy. Attending thus does not reduce the sight of this background, because attending is a necessary basis for the background to exist in the first place. You cannot separate foreground and background as 1. a place where attention exists, and 2. a place where attention does not exist, unless you make background into siimply a philosophical idea.

I hope this cleared up misunderstandings.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-30 14:41:40*

There are two main issues with this:

1. As even mundane phenomenologists like Husserl and Sartre pointed out, phenomenology requires you to set aside the scientific outlook from the outset. You simply cannot expect science to "prove" anything about our

> phenomenological experience without already having abandoned the ability to understand experience on its own terms.

Understanding experience on their own terms—from the "inside" rather than through an external lens like that of science, or even Buddhist quasi-science like the Abhidhamma—is what the Dhamma is about. That is why no Arahant or noble disciple ever *could* turn to science to support his insights; that very attempt takes those insights outside of the only domain where they apply, and he would be thoroughly aware of that by that point.

2. Whatever "processes" were being observed in the subjects of the studies you refer to are not what we refer to as peripheral awareness (or *yoniso manasikāra,* more accurately). Quite unlike an "automatic proprioceptive sampling" that happens on its own, yoniso manasikāra requires a lot of work to achieve. It does not exist for most practitioners, let alone the completely worldly people that would've participated in those studies. It is possible to achieve only internally—i.e., phenomenologically—for those who have taken on the precepts, withdrawn from sensuality, contemplated the danger in it, abandoned modern wrong views about the practice, etc.

EmptinessInForm

Cogsci is just phenomenology that also actually correlates with behavioural results that confirm said phenomenology. It would we really weird if there is a total disconnect between phenomenology and the physical results, actually, that would make no sense at all.

So while I'm aware of the limitations of science, I think you might be too quick to dismiss it.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-30 15:45:39*

> Cogsci is just phenomenology that also actually correlates with behavioural results that confirm said phenomenology.

Correlating with behavioral/experimental results means applying a third-person point of view over experience, so that can't be phenomenology by definition:

> Phenomenology is the study of structures of consciousness as experienced **from the first-person point of view.**.

EmptinessInForm

I didn't say cogsci is phenomenology - I said it is phenomenology + behavioural experiments.

Btw, I would be interested to hear whether you think your or any other HH member's results in some of these studies of attention would differ from «completely wordly people that would've participated in those studies». In that

case, I would be highly motivated to come to Samandipa to attempt some experiments. This would be amazing for my research and the development of our understanding of psychology and dhamma imo! :)

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-30 16:13:40*

> I didn't say cogsci is phenomenology - I said it is phenomenology + behavioural experiments.

And my point is that if you try to combine these two, there is no proper phenomenology anymore.

> In that case, I would be highly motivated to come to Samandipa to attempt some experiments.

I'm afraid we wouldn't consent to that, as it would only reinforce the misconception that science and the Dhamma can even speak about the same things, let alone "agree" with each other. That view needs to be given up in order to meet the Dhamma where it is.

blimpyway

> And my point is that if you try to combine these two, there is no proper phenomenology anymore.

That's like saying one is forced to pick either a wrench or a screwdriver to (dis-)assemble an engine, since any attempt to use the screw will certainly screw wrenching.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-31 14:50:49*

Nothing in a wrench makes it inherently necessary to put all screwdrivers aside, so that's a false analogy.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by ApprehensiveWriter23 *2026-08-27 15:26:47*
Right livelihood as a musician

I am a musician, a violinist. I have been living by the five precepts for three years, and for the past year, I have added celibacy (I am married, but my partner agrees). The purpose of my practice is freedom from suffering, or at least to develop my mind as much as possible in this lifetime. My question focuses on right livelihood: I mostly make a living by teaching music, and very occasionally by performing live. Generally, I reduce my consumption of recorded or live music to almost nothing, except for the occasional specific reference regarding the interpretation of a piece I need to teach a student. I know that in order to progress I should give up this activity. But I need help understanding the necessity, as it is not entirely obvious to me. Should I abandon this livelihood/profession, I would need to look for a job in cleaning, transportation, or some similar service. Personally, I am not afraid of that

change, but I am afraid of the opinions of my family and wife, who would likely see it as something wrong.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-30 05:57:41*

Whenever you willingly exposure yourself (or others) to music, even if with a relatively disinterested attitude initially, you have opened the door the possibility of passion, and that choice is by itself a defilement (a kind of delusion/non-clarity) even if no acute passion ends up materializing.

It is one of those cases where the thing in question does not appear like an inherent obstacle, but it becomes an obstacle when not given up simply due to the implications of the choice to maintain it (MN 66).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by HoldenVJ *2026-08-19 01:58:37* ### Fail to escape from sensuality

I have watch a ton of videos of the teachig of Hillside. I have a lot of faith in Ajahn teaching. I have try my best to avoid sensuality. I know that it is beginning of the path. Unless one can keep 8 precepts there is no further development on Dhamma. I didnt manage to quit sensual desire yet but I try to keep it at minimum.

Yesterday we found out that my mother got ovariaon cancer. I am experiencing a lot of suffering. I know that I should’t try to manage the suffering. I should endure it as Ajahn said. But I can’t find a way out of this pain. I still rely on sensuality to cope with this pain. I know its just a distraction. But I dont have no where else to go to. I shouldnt use method like watching nostril or watching sensation to calm my self down either.

What is your advice in situation like this?

I figure the best answer might be something like “just endure it”. But I really can’t right now. I’m not that skillfull yet.

Thank you

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-20 05:20:54*

> What is your advice in situation like this?

Keep your ways of managing the pain within the precepts. You won’t realistically be able to not manage it at all from day one.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by titikshakshanti *2026-08-17 01:57:51* ### Kosambiya Sutta and fostering harmony

Where the *Kosambiya Sutta* connects”Right View” and *harmony*, HH teachings are often interpreted as an introspective pursuit that minimizes the role

of the positive actions that foster harmony and emphasise the role of avoiding the negative actions rooted in greed, aversion, and delusion.

The Buddha provides specific, actionable behavioral instructions (the six qualities) to resolve a conflict. The practice here is functional and relational. Even if imperfect, such a practice can be helpful even if the person has not attained right view, as long as it is done within the training with precepts and sense restraint.

Avoiding actions rooted in unwholesome intentions is one part of the training. Doing actions that aren't rooted in such intentions but rooted in opposite intentions should be another part of the training. The other part is not emphasised by Hillside Hermitage.

Buddha instructs Bhikkhus to treat others with bodily, verbal, and mental kindness and not just asks them to avoid actions of bodily, verbal and mental enmity.

Buddha says that these things are also essential along with living according to precepts and having right view.

I understand that like meditation and mindfulness, one's understanding of what counts as metta and karuna or friendliness and kindness will not be correct initially. But, one should strive towards that understanding in both ways: by avoiding certain actions and by doing certain actions.

Consider these quotes:

1. "… are you treating your spiritual companions with kindness by way of body, speech, and mind, both in public and in private?"
2. "Mendicants, these six warm-hearted qualities make for fondness and respect, conducing to inclusion, harmony, and unity, without quarreling"
3. "Furthermore, a mendicant shares without reservation any material things they have gained by legitimate means, even the food placed in the alms-bowl, using them in common with their ethical spiritual companions …"

My question is: Have I understood the teachings of this and similar suttas correctly? Do Hillside Hermitage also emphasise such teachings in their talks? Are such positive qualities should be cultivated while striving for the right view along with training with the precepts? Are there HH videos on this topic?

It would be great if a whole sutta study like talk is made on this topic.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-17 05:24:11*

You seem to be reading into the Sutta something that it never says: that kind and "positive" actions are *part of the training*. They are not, and that's why we don't talk about them. Not because one should refrain from them altogether.

Plus, the friendly conduct that the Sutta describes naturally arises as a byproduct of having trained the mind away from intentions of ill-will, so it's not even like one has to make that into a "practice" of its own. Trying to do so only serves to indicate that one is not overcoming ill-will but instead artificially overriding it (and those are mutually exclusive).

titikshakshanti

Thanks, Bhante, for your reply.

> You seem to be reading into the Sutta something that it never says: that kind and "positive" actions are part of the training.

This is precisely the information I wanted to have. I always thought that the silence on this topic from HH monks means something deeper. But, to be sure, I asked the question explicitly.

> They are not, and that's why we don't talk about them.

A small doubt here: but the few of the six actions mentioned in the sutta are about such positive actions. Hence, I was asking for a detailed talk or write-up on those six actions. There are many Vinaya rules and stories about such actions that foster harmony.

> … Not because one should refrain from them altogether.

That refraining could be a wrong reaction to that silence. I personally went into that direction on many occasions. I was not clear but underlying thought process was something like that: I will obey precepts against wrong speech and wrong actions and refrain from active kind and positive actions. It went to the extent of not smiling at the even simple and innocent jokes, just to give you an example.

> Plus, the friendly conduct that the Sutta describes naturally arises as a byproduct of having trained the mind away from intentions of ill-will, so it's not even like one has to make that into a "practice" of its own.

That takes time. Any guidelines for what to do till that natural state of mind is achieved? What practice advise you will give for someone whose major hindrance is not greed but ill-will?

> Trying to do so only serves to indicate that one is not overcoming ill-will but instead artificially overriding it (and those are mutually exclusive).

Yes, I understand what is wrong in the artificial overriding ill will by good actions on the top. Yet, I still find ill-will present in me even when I keep precepts against wrong speech and wrong actions. Even if it will take time to diminish with practice, refrain from active kind and positive actions or responses seem to increase the ill will.

What about doing such kind actions and showing positive behavior that foster harmony when one is resisting or refraining from them out of ill-will to which one is not fully transparent?

It sometime appears to me that I might be reinforcing my ill-will by resisting such positive actions (like smiling, saying thank you, saying sorry, small gestures of good will). Overall, this whole domain is not clear to me. I find it difficult to be see my own ill-will.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-17 14:18:32*

> There are many Vinaya rules and stories about such actions that foster harmony.

Sure. That still doesn't mean it's on par with the restraint of actions out of ill-will. Harmony is a mundane but still quite important concern especially in the context of the Saṅgha.

> I was not clear but underlying thought process was something like that: I will obey precepts against wrong speech and wrong actions and refrain from active kind and positive actions. It

That reasoning is the problem then. You shouldn't blindly try to avoid those actions as if they are bad in themselves. You should just not put them anywhere near on the same level as the precepts and sense restraint, because then you would exempt them from questioning and overlook when they are rooted in delight in company and similar.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by AwakenTheWisdom *2026-08-14 14:49:55*
I Have A Request For Hillside

□

There's a lot of misconception and misunderstanding surrounding your perspectives of sense restraint and celibacy in relation to Sotapanna attainment. I think the Venerables should

() Create an entire series strictly for laypeople in how to practice the Buddha's teachings.

() Clear up all misunderstandings and misconceptions.

Apparently, many people are confused, and in some cases, become discouraged to practice due to the beliefs of how to practice as a layperson regarding Sotapatti attainment.

Can the Venerables accomplish this task?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-14 15:38:13*

> Create an entire series strictly for laypeople in how to practice the Buddha's teachings.

This is what all of the published talks are already geared towards.

> Apparently, many people are confused, and in some cases, become discouraged to practice due to the beliefs of how to practice as a layperson regarding Sotapatti attainment.

How do you propose preventing such discouragement?

AwakenTheWisdom

Hello Bhante,

It appears that people are misunderstanding the idea of celibacy prior to Sotapatti. Full clarity is needed

() Is "permanent celibacy" require for five preceptor laypeople to attain the stream?

Or

() Is celibacy required "in the moment": Meaning that when one is hearing the Dhamma, the hindrances are not present?

I think this could clear up some things for many laity.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-14 17:21:15*

I don't think we can make it any clearer that it's the former.

account-7

Bhante - if I may, this is a subject I have thought deeply on but generally bite my tongue on here. II hope this doesn't come across as ill-intentioned or advocating for sensuality. I have noticed, including in myself, how easy it can be for our own way of practicing to become the implicit standard by which we understand the practice of others. However, I'm not here to argue, only to seek clarification and clarity on the HH stance and then potentially humbly offer an opinion on "how to potentially prevent discouragement".

We of course are both aware of the myriad examples of non-celibate householders who are attained to various degrees, so it is the nature of their non-celibacy that I'd like to get the totally clear take on from your POV. Because I am sensing two conflicting accounts, though I'm sure this is just my misunderstanding.

Is it that A:

You and those who so kindly lead the discussions here believe that it is wholly possible to see the Dhamma clearly - whereby one resolves to free oneself

of all sensuality - but as a result of their deep-rooted past tendencies may return to non-celibacy that same day. As you have mentioned here: https://www.reddit.com/r/HillsideHermitage/comments/1ogftik/comment/nmnz6ql/

And that the argument for the necessity for unbroken physical celibacy is not a categorical one from the suttas, but rather a practical and societally contextual one. That is, because today's world is filled with greater sensuality and our being long removed from our root teacher and his chief disciples, such a feat is incredibly unlikely (no matter how common it appears in the suttas)?

Or is it B:

It is necessary to be wholly celibate and intend to be forever, with the relinquishing of the determination toward sexuality being the categorical necessity. It just so happens that stream entrants - complacent with their attainments - then reclaim their desires despite the purity of their past intentions. And therefore it is a requirement to intend for permanent celibacy, while physical celibacy for an extended duration is the practical necessity in today's world, as a structural necessity per the suttas? And the various sutta examples conform to this view?

f your answer is B, then I understand the position more clearly, although I would still have difficulty reconciling that interpretation with the examples that seem to point in the other direction. If your answer is A, I respect your opinion and see the importance from your point of view on the insistence of unbroken celibacy. However, I think if it is A, the point is often misrepresented or at least comes across differently to many.

I just wonder whether explicitly distinguishing these two levels - what you understand to be categorically required, and what you strongly regard as practically necessary in the present world - might help some people understand and not thoughtlessly cast off the teaching without weakening its force.

So in the case of A, I - a nobody - do not suggest you alter your views or your claims, but recognize the distinction between what is categorically required and what you regard as practically necessary in today's circumstances. I recognize that your experience strongly suggests that those who are non-celibate are unlikely to achieve stream entry, but I humbly suggest that making that distinction more explicit may do more good than harm in the long run - especially when it that claim is contextual/observational rather than categorical. I think this not only for those hearing the teachings now, but for the longevity of these invaluable teachings from Hillside Hermitage.

I also will clarify that I almost always encourage celibacy, however, my compassion extends primarily to those in marriages and long-term partnerships whereby extensive strain is put on the relationship when that could prevented without altering fundamental doctrine. While I absolutely do see pursuing sexual partnerships, especially new ones, as pretty destructive to the path.

Another potential pitfall is in seeing young people filled with sexual energy and incapable of holding it - altering communication may cause less repression (and consequentially less adverse, unconstructive releases of the built-up pressure and the “flat out quitting because I can’t take it” I’ve seen) and more recognition of the process of gradual training. Knowing where they need to go while not feeling needlessly frustrated at where they are.

This is just a humble opinion someone who deeply respects your teachings.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-15 05:33:37*

The answer is B. It’s a structural necessity rather than a pragmatic one.

What seems to confuse people (and make them think we’re contradicting the Suttas) is that they hear “you won’t get the Right View unless you’ve been celibate for a long time” when we say “celibacy is indispensable.” But how long a person has been celibate does not by itself tell you anything about how they relate to sensuality internally (i.e., they might still not be striving to categorically break away from it).

Unconditional celibacy is simply the result of a person striving to categorically abandon sensuality and seeing the peril in it, and success in *that* is what makes insight possible (as the Suttas clearly show).

Now, how long it will take for that striving to succeed (for the mind to be free from the hindrances), you cannot say in advance. And *here* is where I would make a pragmatic rather than categorical statement: for most people it will probably take years of unconditional celibacy (and of the further restraints that only become possible within that).

And by the way, the reason why it has to be *unconditional* celibacy and not just “I’ll be celibate until I get the Right View” is that the intention to return to sensuality after the right view, or at any point, is a categorical hindrance *in the present.* It means the danger is being altogether dismissed.

account-7

Thank you Bhante - when it is put like that I understand and agree. I appreciate your clarity and preciseness. I think my suggestion still stands, however, that the emphasis on the pragmatic aspect you bring up is often overemphasized and overshadows the correct doctrinal position you explained

I don’t mean to say I think you’re doing this, it seems to come more from others misinterpretation/misrepresentation of your words here. But nevertheless it’s a common point of confusion and what may partially cause the issues I’ve brought up.

Because irrespective of my (and anyone’s) personal opinion of whether right view is a tangible possibility without years of unbroken celibacy, I think greater separation being made between the structural requirement and the

practical reality you have seen/believe in would serve to help the community and prevent discouragement.

Of course maybe I'm wrong that it would be more useful, maybe people would take that as permission to run amuck with sensuality, but that's just my view.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-15 15:37:43*

> Because irrespective of my (and anyone's) personal opinion of whether right view is a tangible possibility without years of unbroken celibacy, I think greater separation being made between the structural requirement and the practical reality you have seen/believe in would serve to help the community and prevent discouragement.

If you think this separation would make the pill easier to swallow, you're underestimating what I mean by "unconditional celibacy" and the internal abandonment of sensuality. The massive gap between the number of stream-enterers and lifelong monks proves that being celibate for decades is a far more accessible achievement than true internal renunciation.

Said differently, if "I need to be celibate for years" causes discouragement, true internal renunciation will be even more unpalatable.

account-7

Ok very reasonable point of view, particularly in regards to people who simply don't want to give up something they pull pleasure from. So I'll concede that and refrain from saying otherwise in the future.

But in regards to the other situation I presented. There is a very common situation where a layperson is in a domestic partnership where expectations exist. The video of Ajahn the other commenter sent had Ajahn saying a married 5-preceptor, so long as they regularly take on 8, has a "good chance at right view" so long as they don't lie to themselves about their compromised situation and the inherent pain they are taking on on account of engaging in sensuality and being incelibate.

Did I misinterpret what Ajahn said? It seemed he allows for the possibility of a "good chance at right view" in spite of this compromised situation. So long as they see their situation as compromised, temporary, and carve out times for the 8 precepts.

How does that reconcile with the view that permanent, unbroken celibacy is a categorical requirement prior to Stream Entry? Is it that you are suggesting for those who are aiming for stream entry, that irrespective of the pain it might cause for those around them, they should commit to brahmacharya? And that if they choose not to, it's simply preparatory practice and right view - or at least dhammanusari. - simply cannot arise in that compromised environment?

This is simultaneously under the assumption one is not deceiving oneself that incelibacy is reconcilable with the dhamma - invalidating what I said previously about those who put it off because it's too daunting/discouraging.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-16 05:37:08*

> Did I misinterpret what Ajahn said?

Yes, if you understood it as "you can stop there and that'll be good enough." That would mean not actually accepting the situation as compromised (and sensuality as dangerous and painful) and so being fine with settling within it (and *not* doing this was in fact the whole point of the talk).

If you took the five precepts and occasional eight with the right outlook, you would still be seeing every bit of sensuality as something to be abandoned and actively striving towards that ideal (and eventually achieving it if you indeed get the Right View). Meaning, you would still feel very much compelled to achieve unbroken celibacy and sense restraint, and would be unable to be content with less than that.

account-7

Thank you, this is what I understood it to be though my wording was perhaps not so precise.

I never meant to imply that a layperson in a relationship can simply settle into a "compromised" state and treat it as sufficient. As you have pointed out, there has to be some kind of friction in the situation. Which I assume if someone manages to succeed in this disadvantaged position, then either by the end of one's life or in subsequent rebirth a celibate lifestyle **must** and **willingly** will be undertaken on account of attaining the right view. Because the intention to return to sensuality after the right view, or at any point, is a categorical hindrance in the present. Though sensual craving can, of course, still be (only temporarily) intoxicating for a stream entrant.

So while I still hold some disagreements in terms of communication style and delivery of that message, this cleared up a lot of doctrinal confusion I had with some of the finer HH points on this subject

I think this also has made the whole path much clearer for me. This conversation was deeply helpful, very grateful for your time.

With metta.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-17 05:07:50*

> Which I assume if someone manages to succeed in this disadvantaged position, then either by the end of one's life or in subsequent rebirth a celibate lifestyle must and willingly will be undertaken on account of attaining the right view.

The celibate lifestyle must be undertaken to attain the right view, not after it. That was the point of my earlier comment. All I conceded is that a person can *start* with five precepts and occasional eight, but it is impossible for one's mind to be freed from the hindrances (the prerequisite for the right view) unless one's mind has let go of sensuality categorically and unconditionally. The person who properly took on the practice towards right view would be aware of this from the beginning, and hence they would be working towards it even if gradually.

So just to reiterate, nothing has changed from my first answer in this thread. Without undertaking permanent celibacy and taming the mind to be content with that, one will not get the Right View.

account-7

Ah, I see. Thank you for the final clarification, Bhante. While I'm open to my understanding evolving over time, upon a fair amount of reflection I still find myself humbly disagreeing.

Not in regards to doctrine or the general structure, but it seems primarily in regards to the possibility for a mind to be truly freed from the hindrances in a shorter duration of time and in more flexible of circumstances than you say. I personally don't believe it is only due to the Buddha / his immediate disciples acting as a catalyst that stream entry in the midst of an incelibate - though presumably sensually tempered - lifestyle is possible for these householders in the suttas.

While I worry about the effects of what you're saying on practitioners, I understand you and your experiences have told you it is necessary. I further respect the intensity and strictness in your view, especially when communicating to a mass audience online.

So in the future outside this thread, I'll keep this opinion off this sub since I don't want to place any undue conflict on your teachings. Regardless, I appreciate your time and the clarity you brought to the discussion - it's been very helpful.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-17 16:08:11*

> Not in regards to doctrine or the general structure, but it seems primarily in regards to the possibility for a mind to be truly freed from the hindrances in a shorter duration of time and in more flexible of circumstances than you say.

This is most probably because we're not on the same page about what the hindrances are. Knowing them for what they are would show why any trace of non-celibate intentions—even mere doubt about the unconditionality of one's celibate resolve—is inseparable from them.

> So in the future outside this thread, I'll keep this opinion off this sub since I don't want to place any undue conflict on your teachings.

That's not necessary. Even people who are in full agreement with our position and are already celibate can benefit from these discussions.

account-7

Thank you for your openness to discussion.

So if I'm following this correctly, then you mean "hindrance" is defined broadly enough that any residual sensual intention counts, correct? So by that metric, then "freedom from hindrances requires categorical celibacy" becomes true by definition, not by argument. In that case, there's no sutta or lived case that could count against it, because the definition absorbs the counterexamples in advance.

And that is why you would find it highly unlikely that anyone who hasn't been celibate for years could get there? To go from the grossness of having engaged in sexual activity a day ago to being absolutely, fully, completely resolved on the complete eradication of sensuality the next day and thus attaining stream entry is, seemingly, an absurd leap. That's why you say practically, years of physical celibacy are necessary for true mental celibacy - the prerequisite for the arising of right view. If I'm getting your point?

The explanation then given for the suttas seeming counterexamples would be, as I believe you've said, that the Buddha (and noble disciples) remarkable and singular ability to see the mind of the person they are talking to and navigate it more skillfully than anyone could today.

Is this what you're saying? I would like to make sure I fully follow what you're saying and am not missing anything that would change my position.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-17 19:59:49*

> So if I'm following this correctly, then you mean "hindrance" is defined broadly enough that any residual sensual intention counts, correct?

Yes. And even without explicit sensual intention, any elation or zeal toward the prospect of sense pleasures counts. It means the danger is not seen.

So freedom from the hindrance of sensuality is not "I have no thoughts about sensual pleasures at the moment", which anyone can achieve even without any real precepts through misguided practices. It's "No zeal arises even when I openly imagine the most alluring pleasures because the danger is clear."

> So by that metric, then "freedom from hindrances requires categorical celibacy" becomes true by definition, not by argument.

Exactly. Hence anyone demanding further argument or Sutta evidence is failing to see what freedom from the hindrances means.

> And that is why you would find it highly unlikely that anyone who hasn't been celibate for years could get there?

Yes, but again, the claim that celibacy is required has nothing to do with this pragmatic duration issue. It's because nothing short of permanent, unconditional celibacy and sense restraint is a sufficient condition for freedom from the hindrances. Without that, you remain settled in the infinitely more comfortable status quo of *some* sensuality compared to none at all, so the mind has no incentive to go past that—to internalize the danger and abandon sensuality at the fundamental level of the hindrances.

> The explanation then given for the suttas seeming counterexamples would be, as I believe you've said, that the Buddha (and noble disciples) remarkable and singular ability to see the mind of the person they are talking to and navigate it more skillfully than anyone could today.

Yes. Their minds let go far more quickly than usual once confined to permanent non-sensuality because the Buddha was able to directly convey to them the benefit of that total confinement—and the danger of trespassing it—purely through a well-tailored teaching (which obviously would've been much more lengthy and detailed compared to what you find in the text). But whether the Buddha is teaching you or you are doing the work yourself, the confinement must be the same, and the mind must equally lose its desire to go out of it in order to be ready to understand. How long that takes and how difficult it is—and whether you're even able to get the Right View from one or even numerous conversations; countless people did not—depends on how dependent on sensuality you were.

On the subject of the extent of dependence, one thing I've pointed out in the past but is worth repeating is that none of those accounts actually prove what people who resist celibacy want them to. Whatever sensuality those people engaged in happened either before they even knew the path existed, or after they reaped its fruits and suspended it due to complacency. Thinking one is on the path while still allowing oneself to enjoy sensuality even as a prospect, *despite already hearing about its dangers extensively*, is a very different internal situation that indicates not just a greater dependence on sensuality, but also heedlessness, stubbornness, and lack of faith in the actual teaching.

That essentially sums up the categorical obstacles to growth in the Dhamma listed in MN 16.

account-7

Firstly, again, thank you Bhante for your time to discuss with me.

To first ensure I am restating the structure correctly as I've understood it: the resistance to the idea celibacy is *itself* a hindrance to celibacy. Or rather, the resistance to *complete renunciation of sensuality* is itself indicative of the hindrance being present.

Which I've never really thought in those terms about but is really brilliant. Then, naturally, the external behavior must, necessarily follow the internal submission to celibacy (or much more importantly than narrowing it to the specific issue of celibacy, a blanket internal to external renunciation of sensuality as a whole).

As you've said repeatedly here though, it is not temporal in nature. It is here and now that this realization unfolds and manifests. And any tiny vestige of the idea that "ok I've done enough I can go back" or anything along those lines, is completely derailing the possibility for the arising of right view.

This is incredibly helpful. And more clearly than before I see the value in simply stopping there. Because that's really all that matters as it pertains to the arising of right view.

So to be honest I'm not sure if I'm altering my initial supposition or not, but even with all this being held, I still feel that the emphasis is being misplaced. If not through anything you're saying at least by the community at large here. Because it feels clear that a mind - once at least modestly weened off of sensuality and dispelled of a good number of wrong views - is still capable of letting go quickly, of rapidly letting go of intentions and all zeal for sensuality given the right environment. The nature of that environment is up to debate. One might say it's due to the Buddha's unique teaching abilities, another might say it's simply on account of physical seclusion, etc etc. Any opinion there is going to be shaped by our life experiences and subjective perceptions. To me, the fact that it's up for debate means it should be de-emphasized compared to focusing on altering the immediate intention. I understand that past behavior conditions the present intention, but nevertheless it seems more important to focus on what the mind is doing *right now*.

So changing the focus of delivery might prevent the all-too-common "I give up because I'll never get stream entry while I'm stuck in a (fill in the blank) non-monastic situation".

Because the claim isn't something that could be shown false by any experience or referencing any sutta, it can only be confirmed from the inside. By actually doing what you're describing, regardless of where one finds themselves.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-18 05:00:08*

> Because it feels clear that a mind - once at least modestly weened off of sensuality and dispelled of a good number of wrong views - is still capable of letting go quickly, of rapidly letting go of intentions and all zeal for sensuality given the right environment.

This is again based on underestimating the hindrances. The attitude “I should be able to do it in X amount of time” automatically implies an end date to the confinement and thus dismantles its unconditionality. Unless returning to sensuality is altogether out of the question, the mind will not let go of it.

account-7

I can see why you would say that, but I’m not viewing the hindrances as a shallow thing. They are poisonous darts imbedded very deeply in the heart, that can truly manifest in the most subtle of ways.

Still, I see it as underestimating the mind’s ability to let go very deeply, very rapidly in the right conditions (imo, still wholly possible in the present). Even if those conditions are fleeting and the taints quickly return. And I don’t see going there as predicated on trying to get it done in a certain amount of time, simply circumstantial, though authentic, dispassion.

Please don’t think I mean the superficial, isolated states of calm people can find on most kinds of retreats either. Or that someone can live a deeply sensual life otherwise and do this, I’m speaking to sincere practitioners in compromised life circumstances.

Anyways, I see the value in your rigor, and once again I’m open to changing my view in the future if different evidence presents itself in my life, but I am nevertheless inclined towards a more open-minded, flexible approach to the same core idea - I’ve seen the good that approach can do and the potential harm an exclusivist one can.

Reflecting back, I have altered some views of mine on account of your wisdom and found this conversation very deeply helpful. I’m incredibly grateful for your time. Thank you.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-18 19:32:13*

> Still, I see it as underestimating the mind’s ability to let go very deeply, very rapidly in the right conditions (imo, still wholly possible in the present).

It does seem you’re overlooking that even the mildest intentions to return to sensuality at some point very much exist in the present (they can’t be anywhere else). On the scale that matters, one’s letting go remains superficial as long as those intentions remain.

> Please don’t think I mean the superficial, isolated states of calm people can find on most kinds of retreats either.

I wasn’t thinking that. That’s only the very tip of the iceberg when it comes to underestimating the hindrances.

> I’m speaking to sincere practitioners in compromised life circumstances.

I would also recommend considering how much your hesitation is being influenced by a gut feeling that surely, such people must be able to succeed without abandoning those compromises because the alternative would be too grim.

If you're not emotionally prepared to accept a scenario, distrust whatever reasoning you find to reject it, since the weight of that reasoning will absolutely be inflated in a way that you don't realize.

account-7

In regards to the first bit, I do not think I'm doing that. But if your argument is that it's highly improbable that someone in a compromised cannot fully, completely, let go unless their external situation changes - that's fair. I get it, a temporary absence of desire is not the same thing as uprooting the basis for desire (here and now). Conceding otherwise is not only potentially misleading but a very slippery slope. Your argument is clearly the safer one, even if I disagree.

Though in regards to the second thing you said, forgive me Bhante, but this feels different than what you've been saying before. Instead, it comes across to me like an ad hominem argument. Firstly, my claim is largely impersonal and more about useful pedagogy. Though secondly, this is something I've seen here and I feel is not really a fair way to engage with someone because it's unfalsifiable - there's no way for me to show you that it's *not* true, since any denial made would just be read as further evidence of the discomfort you're presuming a practitioner must be facing. It proves itself, but that doesn't make it true.

I agree that feeling pressure on account of being told your situation will not be able to lead you to stream entry is not something to be reasoned out of. I wholeheartedly agree. If the real, non-abstract possibility of abandoning your family, your sensual (and sexual) outlets, etc is frightening - there's obviously a problem there. But *emotionally accepting* a scenario is different than pragmatically choosing one on account of the perceived harm you'd cause.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-19 20:34:56*

> But if your argument is that it's highly improbable that someone in a compromised cannot fully, completely, let go unless their external situation changes - that's fair.

Not quite. My point is that remaining in the compromised situation is a choice the person makes with full volition—that it is hard not to make it cannot remove that fact—and that choice it itself attachment. No letting go within that choice can override its significance, namely that one continues to perceive a charcoal pit as other than that (it's the only way to accept staying in it).

It's not that one needs to take on permanent celibacy all at once or there

is no hope. One can certainly build it up gradually, which was the point of that video we discussed earlier. But you need to be aware that making the compromise *is* being under the hindrances, and so you're practicing to make your mind strong and confident enough to *actually stop making the compromise.* Only then is stream-entry possible, but the efforts one makes within the compromise obviously still count.

> Instead, it comes across to me like an ad hominem argument.

An ad hominem is not automatically invalid in a Dhamma discussion. The Dhamma is to be realized (and craving/suffering overcome) in relation to one's personal situation, not in abstraction.

So if anything, failing to address the listener's personal circumstances makes any exchange less accurate and less likely to land deep enough, and I should've brought up that angle from the beginning.

> Though secondly, this is something I've seen here and I feel is not really a fair way to engage with someone because it's unfalsifiable

It's not unfair because this was never a competition, and the point I made is directly relevant in conveying what I've been trying to convey all along.

> emotionally accepting a scenario is different than pragmatically choosing one on account of the perceived harm you'd cause.

Taking the perception of harm caused to another as sufficient reason to not abandon sensuality is still an emotional decision rooted in one's own attachment, shown by how one wouldn't hesitate nearly as much if the "harmed" person was a complete stranger (and in that less invested scenario, causing displeasure would be more clearly seen as separate from causing harm).

The distortion of perspective is not just in full blown lust and sensual addiction. It's in accepting the charcoal pit for *any* reason.

account-7

Bhante I see your position is fully coherent and reasoned to the bottom. I actually figured that would be your response to my final point, and can understand why, from your framework, the decision to remain in such a situation necessarily indicates attachment. It's clear why, from this phenomenological pov, any compromise with sensuality is really just viewed as an active maintenance of the hindrances and demonstration of one's "stuckness".

Where we ultimately differ comes down to how we interpret the early texts regarding the minimum baseline required for stream-entry versus the higher training. Not by lowering its structural requirements, which as you've said is what you think I'm subtly doing, but by making those internal requirements more externally demanding than I find the early texts to warrant. Namely, from the oft referenced suttas I immediately think of: An 5.179, Mn 73, An

4.55, An 6.44, etc. I know you have responded to most of these sutta examples already elsewhere, so if anyone stumbles upon this I know they can look up your responses to a wide range of these. And I am aware of the numerous strong examples that seem to argue more favorably in the other direction, such as Mn 14, An 9.41, I'm sure there are many others I can't think of.

I just don't think the HH reading is the only one the early texts support on this specific point, and on the textual evidence as I've read it, I cannot help but lean the other way when being honest with myself. It really would be nice to neatly tie the suttas into a bow. Namely, that complete celibacy, or more generally a total lack of circumstantial compromises in favor of an ideal practice/renunciation environment, isn't an absolute, categorical prerequisite for stream-entry. While recognizing the clear distinction between that stance and one claiming that one can casually indulge in any amount of sensuality and still expect liberation.

Once again, If I find my perceptions wrong in the future, I will readily adopt the POV you've so kindly explained here. I do not want to make liberation - namely the partial liberation of stream entry - more accessible than it is. Doing so for the sake of, as you said, "it being too grim to think otherwise", would make me remorseful. However, I'd feel more remorse about presenting requirements that may needlessly discourage sincere practitioners from hearing and implementing this valuable information.

However, I can really appreciate you emphasizing what you have said before that "one can certainly build it up gradually [while] needing to be aware that making the compromise *is* being under the hindrances, and so you're practicing to make your mind strong and confident enough to *actually stop making the compromise.* Only then is stream-entry possible". As I've said, the hindrances and therefore the present-moment mind that's compromising appear to me to be able to be conditionally released more feasibly - both on account of my perspective and my reading of the suttas - than you're making it out to be (thus rendering stream entry possible in the context of a much larger array of life situations). Though I think this message, as you've said here verbatim, alone is useful to propagate more often here. As being sympathetic I see then you've really covered both bases. You aren't discouraging an incelibate (or whatever situation) layperson from practicing, but you aren't shortening the goal in your estimation. If it's the case that the more traditional Theravada interpretation on this matter is right - the eggs covered rightly would hatch anyways. So as long as someone doesn't give up or pick up an "easier" path - which I still fear is common - it's a win win in a good number of cases I suppose.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-20 05:12:54*

> Where we ultimately differ comes down to how we interpret the early texts regarding the minimum baseline required for stream-

> entry versus the higher training. Not by lowering its structural requirements, which as you've said is what you think I'm subtly doing, but by making those internal requirements more externally demanding than I find the early texts to warrant. Namely, from the oft referenced suttas I immediately think of: An 5.179, Mn 73, An 4.55, An 6.44, etc.

As I've noted before, all that these oft referenced examples show is that someone who's already entered the stream (or who hasn't even started the path) won't always be celibate. They cannot prove anything about the path itself.

On the other hand, the Buddha does speak decisively and in structural terms about what is required for insight and progress in the Dhamma (e.g., SN 45.24, MN 36, MN 16, AN 4.5).

> Namely, that complete celibacy, or more generally a total lack of circumstantial compromises in favor of an ideal practice/renunciation environment, isn't an absolute, categorical prerequisite for stream-entry.

We've never said one needs to obtain an "ideal practice/renunciation environment" in order to succeed. All that can be applied to every individual is the celibacy part, due to sexuality being the one thing that must always be sensual. From then on, it's up each individual to honestly question themselves as to the sensual intentions, emotional pressures, and attachments behind whatever they do and choose to maintain within celibacy.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by cryptocraft *2026-07-29 03:32:47* ### Distinguishing between samvega and aversion

Often renunciation is presented as a sacrifice, but what should one do when they experience craving towards it? For example, what if one feels aversion towards being in the company of others, or the burden of acquiring and maintaining family and material possessions? Though the inclination away from these things seem to be directionally inline with the Dhamma, what if the impulse behind it is aversion towards pressure?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-31 15:43:20*

> what if the impulse behind it is aversion towards pressure?

It will be to some extent. The whole path is based on "aversion" if you define it as simply not wanting something (i.e., suffering).

What you then have to make sure is that avoiding company and acquisitions doesn't become a goal in itself: that the extent of that avoidance remains fully determined by what you personally need to keep your mind away from to subdue its craving, rather than blindly shunning this or that thing per se.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Representative-Age18 *2026-07-28 08:34:51*
Being surrounded by beautiful women

I will start a new degree this fall in a class where 75% are women. I will have to interact with a lot of attractive women on a daily basis. I would guess a lot of people here also live in cities or work in places where they see attractive women every day.

Is this a major hindrance even if one refrains from the pressure to engage in sex, flirt, seek it out, masturbate or act in any way that relieves the pressure?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 14:50:20*

> Is this a major hindrance even if one refrains from the pressure to engage in sex, flirt, seek it out, masturbate or act in any way that relieves the pressure?

You can keep the precepts and so on, even avoid speaking to them, but since you're already not sure to what extent it would be a hindrance, the chance that you will be giving in to the pressure at least mentally—i.e., fall prey to the hindrance—is basically 100% (see the AN quote in that other comment). And for as long as that's the case, you can't take for granted that you won't act out in coarser ways when the opportunity arises.

titikshakshanti

Bhante, is this principle you are describing above applicable to only the precept against non-celibacy or sexual misconduct or is it applicable to other precepts as well like precept against intoxication and entertainment? Is physical proximity to opportunities for such violations of other precepts are too be avoided similarly?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-02 06:34:42*

It applies universally only to the third precept.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Agreeable_Range_8732 *2026-07-27 18:48:47*
Can I keep the precepts as a trial for a few months before committing to them for life?

I have committed to the 5 precepts for life, but I'm hesitating committing to celibacy and non-entertainment for life. I know it's the right thing to do, and I've tried to convince myself with tons of HH videos and contemplation, but to no avail. I need to see the benefits first hand. And to do that, I need to progress in the practice, but is there any progression whatsoever without having made the clear intention to keep the 8 precepts forever?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 14:38:54*

What's more important than committing for X amount of time is to change your view regarding the precepts: the point is not to figure out why you must keep them, but to confine your mind within them. No matter how clear and confident about your determination you were initially, that will fade once the mind starts feeling the confinement and trying to get out again. You have to be able to withstand even the most convincing feeling of "this is pointless" in order to succeed, because that's how much influence over your perception an untamed mind has.

If that's clear then sure, you can start out with a few months (but still unconditionally) before taking on the precepts for life.

wandering-on

If I may add some nuance, venerable, as I think it may be helpful to explore from a few more angles for OP: confinement for confinement's sake doesn't lead anywhere. The anguishing kind of confinement felt, the "get me out of here" and all the tricks the addict mind plays on you that goes with it when you live 24/7 in the context of having determined to keep the precepts forever… is a *consequence* of its craving, untamed, ignorant state, as you say. It can be helpful to recognize the other side of it, that the "confinement" of renunciation, of keeping the precepts, is in fact a joy, a bliss, a gift, a medicine, for the mind that sees rightly. You have to put in work to change the view… The more you tame, the better you can see.

Thank you for all your teachings

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 18:29:25*

> It can be helpful to recognize the other side of it, that the "confinement" of renunciation, of keeping the precepts, is in fact a joy, a bliss, a gift, a medicine, for the mind that sees rightly.

That will remain on the level of wishful thinking when the mind is obsessed with getting out of the confinement, and emphasizing it out of a sense that "renunciation shouldn't be unpleasant" will realistically result in compromising the confinement. The unpleasantness is not something you get to decide; it depends on how wild the mind is.

Agreeable_Range_8732 *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

> the point is not to figure out why you must keep them, but to confine your mind within them.

Yes, I understand that, and that was the entire reason for asking this question. My doubt is whether my mind will even be confined properly by intending to keep the precepts for just a few months. Won't my mind get an escape route if I don't intend to keep them forever?

The ideal scenario in my mind was to keep the precepts for a while, and

progress enough in the practice for me to **want** to keep the precepts for life, instead of forcing myself to. I mean, I would still be forcing myself, but having seen enough of the drawbacks of sensuality, have enough sense to naturally not give in. Is that possible?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 18:52:47*

> Won't my mind get an escape route if I don't intend to keep them forever?

If you're preemptively making plans to break them during the few months then yes, that would be the escape route. So you just don't give the mind any confirmation that you will break the precepts at any point until the period is over (and that keeps fully open the possibility that the confinement will continue beyond that). That's also how the Uposatha should be kept.

> The ideal scenario in my mind was to keep the precepts for a while, and progress enough in the practice for me to want to keep the precepts for life, instead of forcing myself to. I mean, I would still be forcing myself, but having seen enough of the drawbacks of sensuality, have enough sense to naturally not give in. Is that possible?

Not quite. Until the mind is fully tamed you will always be forcing the restraint to some degree, which is why the Dhamma goes "against the grain." What diminishes is how much the mind kicks back at you in response.

But if you commit steadfastly for a long-ish period in the above way then it is very possible that the worst of the mind's rebellions will over by the end of it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Seekfinderin *2026-07-26 09:56:08 ###* Where does my responsibility end?

I am reading the text about authority by Sister Medhini. It stresses how we should be very clear about what we are responsible for and what we aren't responsible for. Like the stoic philosophy basically. But I am very confused about where my responsibility ends and how this whole responsibility thing works in case of mutual influence.

In our everyday life we are influencing others. Sometimes consciously, sometimes unconsciously. E.g. if I am a teacher of children, then I have to influence them. Educate them. I take measures.

Sometimes what I do has the desired effect and leads to e.g. the child learning what I want to teach it or behaving as I would like it to behave. Sometimes my actions may not work out and have the opposite effect, e.g. I raise my voice and try to educate it about a particular behaviour that e.g. is hurtful against others, but instead of it changing that behaviour it may rebel and show more of it and my intervention simply wasn't successful.

Now, where does my responsibility begin or end here? If I am a parent or a teacher I cannot simply say: Everyone is only responsible for oneself so I shouldn't influence the child in any way as it is responsible for his own actions solely. I have some responsibility here, it seems. Depending (in parts) on what I do, the child behaves in some way. Sometimes contrary to what I wanted. But nonetheless his action or reaction was (in parts) triggered by my action, by my attempt to influence it, so is not the reaction of the child a part of my responsibility?

If I scream at someone and he slaps my face as a reaction to it, then of course he is responsible for hitting me, but am I not ALSO (in parts) responsible for his action, because it happened as a reaction to what I did? If it wouldn't have happened if I didn't scream, how then can it not be within my responsibility?

In case of the child: Due to my influence it may make some decisions that I then regret. If it wouldn't have made those decisions if I had spoken to the child in a different manner or tone or used different words, is it then not clear that it is within my responsibility? And where does it end then?

To me it seems that my responsibility in fact is almost endless. I think that I cannot even fathom the extent of what I may be responsible for in this world. My influence, no matter how small it may be in the grand scheme, may have impact on generations. So I see no end of my responsibility. And I cannot "not" act, not even as a monk in solitude, but certainly not when I e.g. am a parent or a teacher, a husband or a wife or in any other way living in an exchange with others.

So how can I take responsibility, if my responsibility seems so endless, if I cannot control what my actions may cause in others and what they may cause others to do in consequence of it?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 14:19:32*

All of the "responsibilities" you refer to are real from a worldly standpoint but irrelevant when it comes to the Dhamma. What you're responsible for in that context is your own suffering, which is due to the craving that you are here and now either fueling or undercutting.

Putting first your failure to meet the worldly responsibilities will distract you from that internal responsibility (which is worth prioritizing because it's precisely due to suffering that you care about everything else).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Objective-Work-3133 *2026-07-24 01:49:42*
Just a couple of questions

1. If i am not successfully keeping the precepts, is there any point of abiding in non-activity, or is it wasted effort? The precept i struggle with the most

is the fifth. I consume caffeine and vape. Celibacy is difficult but i did go a month.

2. I have back pain. I went three months without being able to sit at all. Is it ok if i am changing my position every 20 minutes or so, when trying to be non-active? Getting up to get a pillow or towel for my back, adjusting the recliner, stretching, switching to lying down, etc.

I would also like to request some clarification for what i actually should be doing when i "sit". I know i am not supposed to be sensation watching or trying to think of nothing. I am supposed to neither accept nor deny my thoughts rooted in greed, hatred, or distraction. Is acceptance or denial of the thoughts more about the attitude with which i regard them, as opposed to what i do with them when they arise? So, i am sitting. I think about someone who is *making me angry. Then, i recognize the thought, which is itself another thought. Do i go back to thinking about the person making me angry, so that i can patiently endure the anger? Or do i just think about something else, making the patient endurance not so much the endurance of the unwholesome thoughts' contents and their concomitant feelings, so much as the endurance of the process whereby the unwholesome thoughts repeatedly assault me and i choose to think about something else. But if that is the case, isn't that denying them? I am saying no to them, which is what denial is. The only thing that makes sense to me so far is what i suggested earlier; acceptance or denial is in the attitude with which i regard the thoughts, not so much what i do with them when they arise. I think the way Ven. Nanamoli phrased it is "not putting out the welcome mat."

*not literally. i make me angry. or, "anger happens".

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-28 13:48:39*

> If i am not successfully keeping the precepts, is there any point of abiding in non-activity, or is it wasted effort?

It is highly inefficient and potentially counterproductive effort. It implies you still have coarser things to deal with, and thus you won't have the experience of taming your own mind that is required to properly understand what non-activity means.

A lot of people hear the talks on "non-activity" and take it as some kind of "HH-approved sitting practice" that can be done instead of mainstream forms, but you actually need to abandon that whole attitude of wanting something to perform, however subtle, in order to understand what is even meant with "non-activity". Otherwise you'll be maintaining precisely the activities that need to be abandoned because you don't even see them. And you can forget about successfully abandoning the subtle attitude of depending on activity if the coarser attitude of non-virtue is still there.

Objective-Work-3133

Thank you for your reply Bhante. Just to clarify, then; you would include my vaping/caffeine habits, as they are coarse forms of sensuality (in particular for me; seven or more cups of coffee worth of caffeine a day, no hour passing without hitting the vape) as precept violations in spirit, whose abandonment is a necessary prerequisite for my being able to reasonably expect any understanding of what even needs to be done as far as non-activity is concerned.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-30 05:44:36*

At least caffeine is not sensuality nor a precept violation in itself; the issue might just be the attitude with which you resort to it (and the amount is a byproduct of that).

> whose abandonment is a necessary prerequisite for my being able to reasonably expect any understanding of what even needs to be done as far as non-activity is concerned.

The precepts are just the very beginning. “Non-activity” is quite far ahead of that. It’s basically abandoning the hindrances (which, it’s worth emphasizing, has nothing to do with sitting motionless).

Dhingy1996

Bhante, could you clarify a bit on what you mean by “the attitude with which you resort to it”?

I’ve abstained from caffeine for about 130 days because I noticed that, for me, it has a strong uplifting effect on the mind. I become more energetic but also more impulsive, and generally more inclined towards sensuality. I also found it quite addictive - I would look forward to it and easily build a habit around it.

Now that I’ve been without it for a while, there are still days when I feel lethargic or unmotivated, and the thought of having a coffee comes up. It seems to me that the main reason I would drink it is because I don’t want to endure the unpleasant feeling that’s already there.

Given that, I’m struggling to understand why caffeine, for me, wouldn’t count as resorting to sensuality in the same way that eating delicious food for the sake of pleasure would.

Is the issue simply *why* I drink the coffee (as in, is there clearly an impulse behind the prospect or not), or does the fact that it quite predictably intensifies impulsivity, and heedlessness in my case also make abstaining from it a form of wise sense restraint? Or am I still making caffeine itself into the problem, rather than the attitude behind using it?

Thank you.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-08-01 20:21:30*

Caffeine cannot make you more inclined towards sensuality; it just puts you in an energetic state of mind which, when the mind is ignorant of the danger in sensuality and is not sufficiently trained in sense restraint, becomes a basis for sensual proliferation. In the same way as being excited leads a dog *that's not trained* to start knocking things over.

Even actual intoxicants like alcohol can't induce defilements. It's just that you lose the perspective necessary to notice and restrain the defilements that were already there. Caffeine still leaves you with plenty of opportunity to do that.

> It seems to me that the main reason I would drink it is because I don't want to endure the unpleasant feeling that's already there.

That's not automatically the case just because lack of energy is unpleasant and caffeine removes it. That logic would make virtually every choice to sleep or eat unwholesome.

If you are resisting the lack of energy on the mental level already (you need to see this first and foremost, independently of any particular action) and the prospect of drinking coffee arises *in that light*, then you would be acting out of resistance by drinking coffee. You then wouldn't do it until the action presents itself to the mind in a different light.

That said, don't worry about resistance to lethargy when the mind is still in a sensual orientation. In fact, drinking coffee at that point might even be beneficial so that it's harder to confuse training the mind with controlling its moods.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by nanassaka *2026-07-23 14:41:04* ### Questions on entertainment

According to Bhante Anigha, trying to spend too much time in non-activity can itself become another form of distraction when one is still at the preliminary stage of establishing the precepts. Likewise, even listening to the Dhamma should be regarded as an optional mundane activity, since doing so with the wrong intention can obscure where the real work lies. One might mistakenly think that listening to the Dhamma is itself the practice, when in fact the essential work consists in simply not breaking the precepts at the time

Having some form of activity, while also allowing oneself a reasonable amount of leisure, might actually provide the opportunity to experiment with activities that are not necessarily rooted in wrong intention, rather than pouring one's all in restraining one's mind, which would otherwise be taking them further. Some hobbies are also acceptable for as long as they are done in solitude. My questions are therefore these:

1. Is reading literature necessarily contrary to the entertainment precept? For example, could one read *The Brothers Karamazov* instead of spending time in non-activity, if, at one's present stage, non-activity is actually more likely to become rooted in distraction than the reading itself?
2. Likewise, is watching YouTube videos with the intention of learning new subjects—such as astronomy, biology, or other worthwhile topics—more likely to be contrary to the entertainment precept? If reading Wikipedia articles is not necessarily considered entertainment, would the same apply to watching carefully selected YouTube videos, provided one is mindful of what one is watching and the intention behind it?

One could take these activities as a form of containing one's own mind within a consistent and disciplinized form of activity. Rather than trying to sit in non-activity for 8 hours a day and missing that *thats* where one's wrong intentions are, one could choose an alternatively mundane activity, but to check whether it is rooted in compulsion here and then. *That* would have more chances of revealing one's own intentions and whether they are rooted in a desire to distract oneself or not, rather than trying to deny everything

Likewise, what advice would you have for a student in the summer break who has all the free time in the world? What should I preoccupy my time and efforts with? Should I learn a new hobby? Should I spend more time doing nothing? I have also been trying to not listen to too much instruction so I dont de-value it through over-repetition and over-saturation, but without that I am left without any forms of activity. Is it important that I find something to do that allows me to sketch out some basic routine or discipline, or not so necessarily? Thank you in advance

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-23 16:56:49*

It's true that you shouldn't force yourself to do nothing the whole day, but there's a world of difference between doing things that you have to do or will benefit from doing regardless of any passion—like chores and duties—and the type of activities you listed.

If you don't have any chores to do then pick up something that you don't enjoy but that you know is good for you, and don't lose sight of the mind's attitude towards it in case it starts to develop passion.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by None *2026-07-23 01:05:22* ### How do we know whether we're uprooting suffering or merely managing it?

[removed]

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-23 07:54:22*

> Is the liability being uprooted when painful feeling can remain without resistance, appropriation, or the urge to escape? Or could "en-

> during without reacting" itself become another subtle way of managing the experience?

Prior to attaining the right view, you *will* be conflating those two to some extent. You don't clearly understand feelings as they are yet.

So the "clearest" and only reliable sign is that you became a sotāpanna: you're free from the second arrow whether you practice or not, you're beyond doubt about how that came about and how to develop it further, and by extension, you're incapable of seeing any value in a practice other than that one.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Representative-Age18 *2026-07-21 16:09:32*
AN 6.44 directly opposes Bhikku Anigha's claim that "Stream entry requires celibacy"

In this sutta Ven. Ananda is approached by laywoman Migsala.

She is confused because the Buddha has recently declared two individuals once-returners; one of them was celibate and the other was implied to be sexually active, living with his wife. Presented as chaste vs unchaste.

So she ask ven. Ananda how this could be. He goes back to the Buddha for answers.

The Buddha essentially says that you cannot know a person's mind based on superficial actions unless you are the Tathagata.

This sutta strongly proves that you do not have to be celibate to attain a degree of enlightenment.

What my claim is not: That celibacy isn't helpful, it surely is helpful for the path.

What I may claim: That one should be careful with throwing around absolute statements such as "Stream entry is IMPOSSIBLE without celibacy" or "This is absolutely required for this".

The laywoman thought she knew the conditions for enlightenment, and thought she could predict a practicioner's attainment based on their celibacy or non-celibacy. The Buddha quickly corrected her conceit.

The key takeaway and moral of this sutta that the Buddha is trying to convey is that one should not think one knows, and one should have epistemic humility.

Edit: Hey, sorry I meant Sakadagami, not Anagami. My bad. Corrected now.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-22 07:29:14*

We've discussed this Sutta many times before and refuted the strawmans presented along with it.

> What my claim is not: That celibacy isn't helpful, it surely is helpful for the path.

What defines the *puthujjana* is not that they utterly abhor celibacy and withdrawal from sensuality. It's that, at minimum, they see it as merely "helpful" rather than *necessarily* part of the path. Not seeing the four noble truths, they deep down feel that some amount of craving can be had and acted out of without automatically hurting themselves.

So that's why, as we've repeatedly clarified, our position is not "you will never get the right view unless your celibacy has been perfect for years" (that *would* be refuted by plenty of Suttas). It's also not "someone with right view will never engage in sensuality." Rather, it's "the path begins with (and remains based on) abandoning sensuality; anything outside of that is not the path." There's a huge gap between those.

Representative-Age18

No I fully agree that sensuality is hurtful, that's not what I said. All I'm doing is refuting the view that celibacy is somehow an absolute necessity for the first path. It's just not true. It's true for 3rd and 4th path.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-22 13:51:38*

> No I fully agree that sensuality is hurtful

Well, there is no (right) path at all and no deeper realization of that insight unless you *live* that view instead of simply "agreeing" with it—which means taking on celibacy/non-sensuality, AKA right intention. That's why it's not enough to merely "not deny" the usefulness of celibacy.

Representative-Age18

Well personally I'm currently being celibate myself, and trying to follow 8 precepts on most days. Why do you make presumptions about me and my practice? We're discussing a sutta interpretation, not me personally

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-23 07:02:52*

It doesn't matter whether you're actually celibate or not. The mere view that sensuality is not automatically an obstruction to the path is by itself a bigger obstruction than seeing celibacy as indispensable and taking it on, yet stumbling from time to time.

That's because the whole point of the practice (no matter what stage you're in) is to train your mind so that it can't *return* to sensuality and craving, not just to not have it in the moment. If your view sees it as not inherently a problem—for yourself here and now, not just an arms-length "yes, eventually sensuality must be given up to become an *anāgāmi*"— then you're already not trying to abandon it as a possibility. Hence the Buddha rebuked Ariṭṭha so

strongly despite the fact that, as a bhikkhu, he was not engaging in sensuality himself.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by noobknoob *2026-07-21 11:34:34 ###* About a recent post that has been deleted

I saw a post here recently in which the OP was presenting the idea that "the HH way" of trying to establish the virtue might be partially flawed. OP was saying something along the lines of "HH has a tendency to subtly/indirectly/maybe unintentionally shame the people who are failing to develop the precepts. Which might ultimately be non-conducive to developing them".

I myself has felt that sometimes and thought that discussion might be useful. Can anyone explain why that post was deleted?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-22 05:49:19*

I must have been deleted either by the OP or by Reddit, not by a mod.

As for the argument itself: it may appear "non-conducive" if one assumes that precept-observance is the end goal—in which case a "gentler" approach might indeed produce the desired external behavior in more people. But that misses the point. The goal is not the precepts by themselves but precisely to develop shame regarding unwholesome states.

A person who is anchored in that sense of shame will be progressing at some rate even if they keep stumbling in their precepts until the day they die, whereas one whose behavior is utterly pure from day one but does not develop shame is not practicing at all. They'll remain at the level of an infant.

noobknoob

Thank you for your thoughts, bhante

Something I will reflect on further, for sure.

> The goal is not the precepts by themselves but precisely to develop shame regarding unwholesome states

Would it be more accurate to say "to develop the right type of shame"? And I don't mean the shame that a noble disciple feels. Would you say that even for a puthujjunna, there's wrong shame and less wrong shame?

IIRC, I heard in one of your discussions that the way to distinguish between these two is to see if your conduct improves over time. If it does, then it's the right type of shame. If external behaviour is not the only criteria for progress, does that point still hold?

Something I learnt recently that I'd love to hear your thoughts about: In psychology, they discuss 2 types of shame: healthy shame and toxic shame. Healthy shame is directed towards actions (these actions are wrong) and toxic shame is directed towards core identity (I am worthless/wrong/unlovable). This second type of shame is always counter-productive and just dysregulates you further, taking you further away from your goal.

Would you say that the goal is to feel healthy shame in regards to misconduct? And what are your thoughts on using psychoanalysis insights to help with addictions and to improve overall well-being in general?

Thank you

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-23 16:48:48*

> Would you say that even for a puthujjunna, there's wrong shame and less wrong shame?

Yes, but it's shame about having actually broken the precepts—rather than not meeting some projected standard beyond that—then it's universally right enough and should not be covered up.

> I heard in one of your discussions that the way to distinguish between these two is to see if your conduct improves over time. If it does, then it's the right type of shame.

Yes, but the timeframe will generally be longer than you expect it to be. It could take years, weeks, or days from the point that you start feeling ashamed of misconduct to the point that you finally give it up. And even that will not be a permanent abandonment until non-return, which is why shame remains one of the faculties driving a noble disciple's progress.

> Would you say that the goal is to feel healthy shame in regards to misconduct?

Not quite. Shame is shame, and it's not healthy or unhealthy in itself. The unhealthiness comes from what the person decides to do with the impetus born out of shame (i.e., further unwholesome things like revolving around self-hatred or even abandoning restraint altogether).

> And what are your thoughts on using psychoanalysis insights to help with addictions and to improve overall well-being in general?

It should be seen as a compromise rather than as an aid to the real practice.

interested-in-dhamma *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Hello Bhante, would there be any issue if that shame is experienced as pleasantly, a welcoming quality, even a blessing that one has capacity for shame?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-23 16:50:07*

No, as long as it's still used to commit to restraint in the future.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Representative-Age18 *2026-07-20 10:17:22*
AN 8.54 - A layperson can develop liberating wisdom without 8 precepts, according to the buddha? Criticism of HH

In this sutta the Buddha instucts a layperson to develop liberating wisdom without any mention of the 8 precepts or the typical monastic sense restraint formula. I noticed something interesting about this sutta that I'd like to see discussed.

I'll skip to the part where he gives advice on "(…) the four things that lead to the welfare and happiness of a gentleman in this life."

He mentions:

"What four? Accomplishment in faith, ethics, generosity, and wisdom."

Faith: faith in the buddha

Ethics: the five precepts

Generosity: he instructs the layperson in developing acts of geneorsity

Wisdom: "And what is accomplishment in wisdom? It's when a gentleman is wise. He has the wisdom of arising and passing away which is noble, penetrative, and leads to the complete ending of suffering. This is called accomplishment in wisdom."

I'd like to put emphasis on the Wisdom part.

Here the Buddha is telling a layperson to develop wisdom that may cultivate in the complete ending of suffering with ONLY THE FIVE PRECEPTS as the basis.

This seems to undermine the HH position that any attempt at cultivating wisdom is redundant and only a form of management before the mind is fully tamed.

Btw, I'm closer alligned to the HH position than the other schools, and believe sense restraint to be alpha omega, but this sutta does really seem to soften the position that 8 precepts/ celibacy is a hard cutoff for right view.

HH is a breath of fresh air in the Dhamma community, because bypassing is like the foundation of most dhamma nowadays. However, their position can cause a lot of tension in householder follower's hearts, as HH has a very strict 8 precepts cutoff for gaining noble wisdom, making the dhamma essentially impossible to develop for laypeople and all attempts at developing becomes "A managment technique, escape" or similar. This is why I find it important to push back.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-20 14:22:10*

> Here the Buddha is telling a layperson to develop wisdom that may cultivate in the complete ending of suffering with ONLY THE FIVE PRECEPTS as the basis.

The discourse doesn't say "wisdom can be developed based on these other three things"; it says "these four things are very beneficial." We know that it *cannot* be saying the former because in other Suttas (MN 16, MN 36) the Buddha says that simply harboring desire for sensuality internally is an obstruction to development in the Dhamma. The Chinese version of MN 41 makes it even more explicit:

> "If one wishes to cut off the three fetters and attain the fruits of stream-entry, once-returning, and non-returning, the unlimited supernormal powers, the divine ear, the knowledge of others' minds, the knowledge of past lives, the knowledge of death and rebirth, and the knowledge of the destruction of the contaminants, they will all obtain them. Why is that? Because of Dharma practice and right practice, **maintaining virtue and being free from desire,** what is wished for will certainly be obtained." —SĀ 1042

Only a person who sees noble wisdom as something other than the abandonment of craving—i.e., who is headed in a completely different trajectory than Nibbāna—would think that engaging with sensuality can coexist with attempts to develop wisdom.

Representative-Age18

Yes he is in fact saying that wisdom can be developed based on these other three things.

Why would he teach this layperson 4 things, but only 3 of them are actually relevant to him? The Buddha clearly is giving him a tailored set of instructions on how he can be happy 1) Faith 2) Five precepts 3) Generosity and 4) Development of wisdom

"It's when a gentleman is wise. He has the wisdom of arising and passing away which is noble, penetrative, and leads to the complete ending of suffering."

Notice he is saying "gentleman" referring to a householder, not using the word disciple, monk or mendicant. No, using the word he uses for householders.

Notice he is telling this layperson in the same breath as he is telling him to keep FIVE precepts, to develop wisdom that is "noble".

The context of the sutta is that Dighajanu is asking the Buddha for personal instruction on how he can practice Dhamma in a way that leads to happiness and welfare in this very life.

Now notice that I'm not saying five precepts is enough to make you an arahant. It factually isn't.

I'm saying that the Buddha clearly says that this layperson, whom he thinks should follow five precepts, should become accomplished in noble wisdom.

And yes, of course sensuality to any degree is an obstruction to developing the dhamma. The less sensuality the better. BUT the Buddha understood that progress away from sensuality for many people has to be gradual. But he also does not deny that NOBLE WISDOM IS POSSIBLE for someone who isn't fully seperated from sensuality.

Sensuality and wisdom are opposites, but they exist on spectrums.

Did the Buddha say he will reach nibbana in this life with five precepts? No

Did he say you can make some significant gains in wisdom, potentially reaching a degree of noble wisdom based on the five precepts in this sutta? It sure seems so.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-20 14:53:43*

> Why would he teach this layperson 4 things, but only 3 of them are actually relevant to him?

It's not irrelevant to him, because he (and every other householder) *can* develop wisdom if they start striving for the cessation of craving—which begins with the most obvious one, namely sensuality.

> Notice he is telling this layperson in the same breath as he is telling him to keep FIVE precepts, to develop wisdom that is "noble".

Sure. That doesn't mean the Buddha thinks he will be able to do that *with* five precepts.

You can tell someone "get a degree and become an astronaut." Does that imply that the degree is all they need? Of course not, and unless they were seriously deluded about what being an astronaut requires, it would be obvious to them as well.

> But he also does not deny that NOBLE WISDOM IS POSSIBLE for someone who isn't fully seperated from sensuality.

He very much does in the Suttas I cited above.

> Sensuality and wisdom are opposites, but they exist on spectrums.

Yes, and nobody denies this. That's why we advise people who struggle with celibacy to start with the five precepts and build gradually towards the eight. But it's quite something else to say that while having settled on one end of the spectrum, one can nevertheless arrive at the other.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Particular-Review-65 *2026-07-20 09:20:59*
Repressing anger is inevitable for an ordinary person, in order to not act out.

I might be wrong. But sometimes when anger gets too strong, it feels almost impossible to just let go. First I might repress it, to keep my precept, then I might channel the anger into more productive activities, albeit worldly ones, like exercising, reading books, or even contemplating anger.
Am I doing it wrong? Please give me advice to deal with anger? Maybe more sense restraint? Stay in seclusin? Manage my environment? Patiently endure? I am a puthujanna, I still don't know how to endure without resisting/repressing it at all.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-20 14:45:05*

The fact that anger arises and doesn't go away is not at all "wrong." It's what supposed to happen. By not acting out of that anger that stays nor managing it—which is what any "letting go" that a puthujjana can wrap their head around will be—you will eventually be able to understand it and thus uproot it (by removing the resistance to unpleasant feeling, not the feeling itself).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by ToLazyToPickName *2026-07-18 09:21:34*
Do you need to be free from the 5 hindrances (i.e. get 1st jhana) to become a sotapanna (i.e. get right view)?

I read some posts on this subreddit (Post #1 & Post #2), but I don't think this was answered clearly. Bhikkhu Anigha seems to say one must be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view in this essay.

But if one needs to be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view, doesn't that mean one must get the 1st jhana to get right view, since the 1st jhana is being free from the 5 hindrances?

It seems like Anigha's answer on Post #2 is saying that one can be free from the hindrances temporarily but still not be in 1st jhana, because 1st jhana would involve being good at abandoning hindrances.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-18 14:45:39*

> But if one needs to be free from the 5 hindrances to get right view, doesn't that mean one must get the 1st jhana to get right view, since the 1st jhana is being free from the 5 hindrances?

No, because the first jhāna is one of the things that a mind without hindrances can realize; it's not the freedom from hindrances itself. The first jhāna always comes *after* freedom from hindrances in the Suttas, and sometimes the monk doesn't enter jhāna but other states like the brahmavihāras. But this is often overlooked due to the prevalent misconception that jhāna/samādhi is some

sort of absorbed or concentrated state, and that that's what removes the hindrances.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Ok_Watercress_4596 *2026-07-12 06:34:08*
The sense of self

I started wondering recently why certain contemplations that are related to the sense of "I am" are never mentioned and I haven't found them in the suttas. The sense of self is a clear and obvious phenomena that often appears in the periphery as well as experientially in the body, covering up the feelings and so any pointer to it reveals suffering yet nobody ever mentions this aspect of the experience as a whole

Contemplations such as: "Who is writing?" "To whom does this issue concern?" "Who is speaking?", "Who am I?", "Who am I then?" and plenty of other questions that pop up to anybody investigating their experience

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-12 16:39:27*

Because all those questions are pointless speculations that treat the sense of self as if it's some sort of illusory appearance instead of a pernicious attitude. They are even explicitly called out as *ayoniso manasikāra* in MN 2.

Rather than asking such questions, ask yourself why you suffer when you can't get pleasure or avoid pain. That's where the actual sense of self (i.e., assumption of ownership) is.

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Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-17 06:44:49*

> So as a puthujjana my sense of self experiences pleasure and pain, but if that sense of self diminishes then so does the ability to experience pleasure and pain?

No, what diminishes is your suffering on account of not experiencing pleasure or experiencing pain (the second arrow).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Embarrassed-Box6857 *2026-07-08 14:50:33*
Questioning my views

Hi everyone, i have been restrained/ practicing deeply for a while now and have some views and assumptions that i would like to question. I am comfortable spending most of my day enduring craving and contemplating, and now have subtler questions arising. I'm not looking for reassurance or speculation

but for corrections wherever I'm wrong. I would especially request those who are very sure about their views to help me out.

All these reflections are based on direct experience in my practice along with some intellectualisation but still mostly experiential. I have also not structured the post much and left it more "raw"- I think when left like this it conveys my views in an honest and undistorted way. Apologies for the length and rambling in advance..

Q1- What exactly is the extent to which one needs to understand dukkha. Is it about dukkhas all pervasiveness? its subtlety? I'm able to tell in most cases whether there is suffering or not, however there are times when suffering is subtle so i question- is this situation actually dukkha? I guess it sounds weird but sometimes i genuinely am not sure if I'm suffering, i assume this is what one needs to clarify?

Q2- Previously I thought that with the deepening of practice I would eventually find craving as an object or a "thing"(no matter how ambiguous or vague) but then i came across the line from mn 44
-"That assumption is not the same as the five assumption-aggregates. Nor is assumption one thing and the five assumption-aggregates another. It is the desire-and-passion for the five assumption-aggregates that is the assumption there"
and this of course made me realise that craving can never be "found" no matter how vague because it's always in the attitude towards any object. so i guess that's why the Buddha dosent say "understand craving" but abandon it- only dukkha is to be understood. Is that because craving cannot be "understood" like dukkha can? I guess dukkha is the only doorway to the dhamma? Then is the only duty with regards to craving to endure it?

Q3- For a stream enter who has confirmed knowledge that nibbana is the cessation of bhava(SN 12.68) how does one actually get that knowledge? I see repeatedly how cessation of craving is the cessation of suffering, not to the extent necessary for stream entry yet but, enough that I am quite confident in that recognition and can understand how a stream enterer could develop unshakable faith in that. but as for the cessation of bhava I'm confused? I do see how restraint and endurance has definitely reduced the proliferation of my "existence" so to speak, is this what they mean? How the mind establishes itself in existence or leans towards any direction for refuge/relief?

Q4. What does the convincingness of an experience have to do with craving? I have had times when i subtly crave something (not much pressure) yet it is more believable and the "this matters" significance is high which makes it harder to endure when compared to even some very gross cravings/ pressures which are easier to endure. Why would this be? I guess i could say that even though there is less pressure the fact that it is believable is itself more suffering even if its felt less oppressively? This makes me think craving and

suffering are not necessarily 100% proportional or linear in that sense?

Q5. Why does hh translate phassa as pressure? i clearly see that phassa has “significances” (me, mine, good,bad etc) built into the perception itself however none of these significances-no matter how significant- can pressure me in and of themselves unless there is a pressuring feeling. what i mean is when i endure cravings i have experienced the same objects without craving/emotional pull or “pressure “ so the whole experience is pressureless. from what i understand the pressure would only come from craving- i guess one could say that even feelings pressure one- but the actual felt emotional signifcance of things one is experienced with craving otherwise things are just things.…

Q6. I’m quite confused with whether what i call feelings are actually feelings. i clearly understand(intellectually and sometimes experientially) that feelings are not bodily sensations, yet i can’t help but wonder is “this” feeling when it might just be a bodily sensation. How do i improve this recognition? When there is craving i immediately feel unpleasant in my body(unpleasant feeling mixed with body sensation- sometimes positive otherwise painful) and i cant seem to “seperate” feeling or confidently say “yes thats feeling!”… Am i mistaking trying to isolate it?

Q7. Can i ever have unpleasant feeling without craving as a puttujana?
As i understand according to pattisamupada and hhs view no- then how can i ever understand what is suffering and what is not? because if i can never see “ahh this feeling isn’t a problem “ then how does one truly break through?

I do see -time and time again- that when i am craving and i endure i literally experience craving and suffering cease, but if i always have craving then what i am discerning that is ceasing? Is it just slightly less unpleasant but craving still there? It genuinely feels like that craving and suffering ceases for the time being

Q8. i have also had cravings when i was overall calm, but im confused because the Buddha clearly said one can only feel one feeling at a time. yet im perfectly calm- but there is craving. what am i misunderstanding?

Q9. I understand the connection between understanding the 4nts and removing doubt, silabataparamasa. but i don’t see the connection between the 4nt and sakaya ditthi. Is that because craving maintains sakaya, so in that case the undoing of sakaya would be proportional to the undoing of your craving? Is that why understanding the 4nt removes sakaya ditthi? What is the threshold for that understanding?

Q10. Why is the knowledge of a sottapana “whatever has the nature to arise has the nature to cease” , given more importance than understanding of the 4nts in terms of the standard phrase? Is that just textual bias, or does this line just show the universality of the their recognition?

Q11. How does one practically contemplate the arrow sutta since a puttujana can never experience the first arrow without the second? How does one even recognise either in that case? It seems impossible to me, you only have “this” which is either both arrows or none…

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-09 07:55:22*

1. What exactly is the extent to which one needs to understand dukkha.

To the extent that you no longer look past it and expect it to find it where it isn’t. For example, if you can’t see any suffering but you’re not sure if you’re actually suffering, that vague uncertainty is already suffering. You need to get used to seeing it on that level without it feeling “insufficient” and needing something coarsee and more particular.

2. so i guess that’s why the Buddha dosent say ”understand craving“ but abandon it- only dukkha is to be understood. Is that because craving cannot be “understood” like dukkha can?

Yes. You can’t “understand” craving because craving can only exist in the dark. It can’t be there while you’re actually seeing it. Hence the whole mass of suffering begins with ignorance, not with craving.

3. For a stream enter who has confirmed knowledge that nibbana is the cessation of bhava(SN 12.68) how does one actually get that knowledge?

By understanding craving and its cessation. Being is the inseparable byproduct of craving, not something that exists on its own. And yes, being is the result of the mind (not you volitionally) assuming certain things as refuge/safety in the broadest sense. That’s why you have different types of bhava.

4.

“Convincingness” is a suitable basis for craving to become established, but it’s not craving per se (see AN 6.55). Craving is the mind taking the convincingness at face value and not fully seeing it as a bait.

5.

> but the actual felt emotional signifcance of things one is experienced with craving otherwise things are just things….

Not really. See the above.

Also, what you’re describing as a “pressureless” experience is not genuine absence of pressure; it’s an absence of pleasant and unpleasant pressure, i.e. neutrality, which is the third kind of *phassa.* That too is pressuring you, just not as coarsely.

6. Yes, trying to "isolate" it is bound to lead you astray, because a feeling will always be more general and undefined compared to things that you can neatly pinpoint with your senses and intellect. So for example, when you find yourself being unsure of what a feeling is and not being able to pinpoint it, how does that *whole experience* feel? That's what the feeling is; not whatever you're expecting to find with your direct attention.

7. You can have *less* craving in regard to an unpleasant feeling as a puthujjana. That's in fact the natural result of keeping the precepts and so on. But that's not going to free you by itself because as I already wrote, ignorance, not craving per se, is the root of the whole thing. So even if your craving factually lessens, you are not free for as long as your understanding overlooks the true extent of craving.

8. You might be misjudging what calm is by only considering very coarse forms of agitation. But even if you were factually calm, craving is still going to be there because as I said, neutrality too is a kind of pressure, and the ignorant mind is going to be dragged into craving by that pressure too.

9. *Sakkāyadiṭṭhi* is the byproduct of not understanding suffering and craving. By not seeing the extent of their own feelings and their mental attitudes in regard to those (i.e., craving), they automatically assume (inadvertently obviously) some part their experience as a whole to be independent of both of those things. And that's where they assume a self, no matter how strong their conviction is that there isn't one.

That's why one should think in terms of "I inadvertently assume a self for as long as I'm not a sotāpanna" rather than "there is no self because the Buddha said so," as if it was ever a matter of what you believe to be the case.

10. Both descriptions point to the same thing, although the "whatever has the nature of arising . . ." one highlights more directly what the puthujjana's blind spot is. It's not that they have absolutely no concept of what suffering and craving are, but that they don't see the true extent of certain aspects of their experience (their feelings for instance). Thus, they don't see how those aspects are actually liable to arise and cease on their own, which means they are automatically "trapped" in acting out of their feelings, dealing with and managing them one way or the other.

11. As the Arrow Sutta describes, the puthujjana is struck by the second arrow due to their ignorance of feelings. So you don't become a sotāpanna by learning to prevent the second arrow as some people believe—which is really just management of the first one—but by understanding the experience of suffering. And you can only do that if, as we often say, you don't automatically try to get rid of *any* of iti—ncluding what you would wrongly take to be the second arrow—in the name of "practice."

Embarrassed-Box6857

Thank you so much Bhante, your responses are always helpful!

I just have a few follow up questions

1.

What exactly is the extent to which one needs to understand dukkha.

To the extent that you no longer look past it and expect it to find it where it isn't. For example, if you can't see any suffering but you're not sure if you're actually suffering, that vague uncertainty is already suffering. You need to get used to seeing it on that level without it feeling "insufficient" and needing something coarsee and more particular.

According to PS a puttujana is always suffering? So if I think I'm not suffering I'm overlooking it?

2.

so i guess that's why the Buddha dosent say "understand craving" but abandon it- only dukkha is to be understood. Is that because craving cannot be "understood" like dukkha can?

Yes. You can't "understand" craving because craving can only exist in the dark. It can't be there while you're actually seeing it. Hence the whole mass of suffering begins with ignorance, not with craving.

This makes alot of sense. What exactly do you mean by when one is actually seeing it? Do you mean that through repeated restraint/endurance one is already seeing it, or do you mean that it is only fully "seen" at the moment one becomes an ariya?

5.

but the actual felt emotional signifcance of things one is experienced with craving otherwise things are just things....

Not really. See the above.

Also, what you're describing as a "pressureless" experience is not genuine absence of pressure; it's an absence of pleasant and unpleasant pressure, i.e. neutrality, which is the third kind of phassa. That too is pressuring you, just not as coarsely.

Right i guess since I've only known coarser pressure to me it seems pressureless. I assume over time I will come to see that even this is actually not pressure-less?

7. You can have less craving in regard to an unpleasant feeling as a puthujjana. That's in fact the natural result of keeping the precepts and so on. But that's not going to free you by itself because as I already wrote,

ignorance, not craving per se, is the root of the whole thing. So even if your craving factually lessens, you are not free for as long as your understanding overlooks the true extent of craving.

How do you not overlook the extent of craving, is it similar to not overlooking suffering?

8. You might be misjudging what calm is by only considering very coarse forms of agitation. But even if you were factually calm, craving is still going to be there because as I said, neutrality too is a kind of pressure, and the ignorant mind is going to be dragged into craving by that pressure too.

Im confused with feelings— Can there be multiple feelings at the same time- one general and many particular? Something like hunger or pain is always accompanied with particular displeasure regardless of the general feeling? And it's the general feeling which sets the "tone" so to speak?

In the calm example, I'm generally calm and not specifically craving for the calm feeling, I'm craving for sensuality and relief from particular displeasure *while* being generally calm. This would mean craving can happen for any feelings, be it general or particular?

10. Both descriptions point to the same thing, although the "whatever has the nature of arising . . ." one highlights more directly what the puthujjana's blind spot is. It's not that they have absolutely no concept of what suffering and craving are, but that they don't see the true extent of certain aspects of their experience (their feelings for instance). Thus, they don't see how those aspects are actually liable to arise and cease on their own, which means they are automatically "trapped" in acting out of their feelings, dealing with and managing them one way or the other.

By seeing the extent of feelings you would mean seeing how one is truly "trapped" within feelings, what does that mean practically? And because of not seeing feelings they cannot see how the actual feelings are uncontrollable, rather they see what they assume feelings to be?

11. As the Arrow Sutta describes, the puthujjana is struck by the second arrow due to their ignorance of feelings. So you don't become a sotāpanna by learning to prevent the second arrow as some people believe—which is really just management of the first one—but by understanding the experience of suffering. And you can only do that if, as we often say, you don't automatically try to get rid of any of it—including what you would wrongly take to be the second arrow—in the name of "practice."

So this is the reason why the more restrained one is the deeper one can understand the Dhamma? Because what one has to understand can *only* be "visible" after restraining?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-12 08:03:43*

> According to PS a puttujana is always suffering?

Yes, just to different extents.

> This makes alot of sense. What exactly do you mean by when one is actually seeing it? Do you mean that through repeated restraint/endurance one is already seeing it, or do you mean that it is only fully “seen” at the moment one becomes an ariya?

An ariya is defined by the ability to discern craving correctly. Craving cannot exist while it is discerned (which doesn’t mean that an ariya discerns it constantly).

There is no “moment” of becoming an ariya in the sense of a some novel dimension suddenly opening up. Stream-entry means recognizing beyond doubt that you now have the right view, in the same way as you would recognize after a period of training that you have rightly understood something that you didn’t understand before.

> How do you not overlook the extent of craving, is it similar to not overlooking suffering?

By not taking for granted your notion of what craving is until you’re a sotāpanna. That entire notion is really the issue, not that you see “only a part” of craving’s manifestation.

> Im confused with feelings— Can there be multiple feelings at the same time- one general and many particular?

No.

Hunger is not unpleasant if being hungry is giving you something you’re very happy about. The sensations of hunger or even damage to the body are not unpleasant in themselves.

> So this is the reason why the more restrained one is the deeper one can understand the Dhamma? Because what one has to understand can only be “visible” after restraining?

Yes, you need to contain your ways of acting out of suffering because those are what perpetuates your non-seeing of that very suffering, let alone its origin, etc.

CelibateAromas

> No.

From your essay, Seeing a Body Within the Body, you wrote: “In the case of feeling, there’s always a feeling in your experience that’s more ‘central’ than

all the others, which are comparatively fleeting…**If you see that at the core of all those other more particular feelings, determining them, lies that more primary feeling**…

…With ‘a mind within the mind’, **it’s the same. A more primordial state of mind always *simultaneously* underlies all the more particular moods that may arise**…”

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-07-13 13:35:20*

Yes, I am aware of that. I now see that there is a reason why the Buddha described it as he did in MN 74. It’s a more precise description because it stays purely at the level where suffering actually is.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Representative-Age18 *2026-06-28 11:24:36*
Metta to calm aversion, not get rid of pressure without fully developed virtue

My question is essentially whether it would be wrong to cultivate generosity, kindness and a mind of friendliness if I’m still not yet fully developed in restraint. (Not yet fully celibate). Will it help me towards deepening renunciation and understanding, or will it just be another escape from pressure.

Assuming I’m not doing it when pressured to do so, but with the right intention of calming aversion to pressure, instead of getting rid of pressure thru sensuality.

Btw, I understand metta better as friendly (non illwill) bodily, verbal and mental action, not just repeating phrases in my head.

Should I make it a serious focus of my practice to not only never harm, but also do kind acts to other beings, charity and generosity and train the mind in friendly attitude?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-28 14:22:54*

You can practice generosity, but don’t think that you are calming aversion and developing *mettā* if you don’t have the right view yet (even if you were keeping all the precepts perfectly).

In order to cultivate a friendly mind, you need to see your mind first, i.e., have the right view (for which virtue is necessary). If you don’t, whatever friendliness you commit to will be tainted by a mind that wants to get rid of unpleasant pressures (aversion) even if you think that’s not what you’re aiming for.

Representative-Age18

So generosity and kindness is pointless before sottapatti and won’t help you develop right view?

Pointless as in it isn't wholesome

Ajahn said in the Practice of Generosity video that generosity is wholesome even if done for selfish reasons, ie. Wanting to calm aversion…?

https://youtu.be/b0SJ_E8PPIs?is=Fj1PE2ss_MRGaclR

In this video, Ajahn also says that Metta won't take deep roots until the mind is tamed BUT he says that one should still practice metta meditation with an untamed mind

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-29 06:57:35*

> So generosity and kindness is pointless before sottapatti and won't help you develop right view?

No, it's not pointless. It can indirectly contribute to right view provided one is doing everything else properly, i.e., virtue, sense restraint, and having enough faith and urgency to be ready to question all of one's views.

> In this video, Ajahn also says that Metta won't take deep roots until the mind is tamed BUT he says that one should still practice metta meditation with an untamed mind

A mind that hasn't been sufficiently tamed by virtue is not the same as a mind that is *bypassing* virtue. It sounds like the latter is what you're going for, and that will inevitably be superficial management of discomfort while actual defilements are left unchecked.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by spiffyhandle *2026-06-26 12:20:47* ### What flaws do you see in my understanding of practice?

Hi practitioners,

I have made several misunderstandings of HH teachings on core topics in the past. I am not talking about finer points like the jhanas or satipatthana. I mean mistakes about what the fundamental practice of virtue is. Instead of going into my history (what I used to think and why it was wrong) what follows is my current understanding. Do you see any flaws in it?

My current goal is keeping the 7 precepts. My next goal will be keeping the 8 precepts, then avoiding unwholesome speech, then not doing unwholesome things that don't break the precepts, then sense restraint, then moderation in eating. At the moment, I'm not too concerned with what sense restraint and moderation in eating are. I just want to develop the foundation of virtue.

I understand my current practice to be, just keep the precepts I've undertaken with a minimum of management. I've taken the precepts in a broad sense; what's given in the suttas are examples to exemplify the essence of

them. At this level, if something doesn't break a precept, then I shouldn't bother scrutinizing it.

I understand the next levels of practice to be the same, but with more precepts (7 -> 8, then no unwholesome speech).

Following this, there are no more precepts to undertake. The training is now done at the level of mental intentions. If I detect an *intention* of greed, aversion, or distraction, don't do it. I understand the intention to manifest more as an emotional reaction and not an intellectual justification. Perfecting understanding and restraint of unwholesome intention might be sotapatti and then I won't need further clarification on sense restraint and moderation in eating.

If I did need further clarification, I figure I should wait until I am more developed in virtue and closer to the next step to clarify what to do. I have read Bhante Anigha's essay on sense restraint.

Questions

Once I can keep the 7 precepts well, should I move to watching intentions? Or should I move to 8 precepts then 8 precepts with no unwholesome speech then watching intentions?

Is focusing all my effort on precepts, the right approach or too narrow?

Practice

My practice within the 7 precepts is basically focused around celibacy. It's the precept I struggle with the most. I'm not asking for a method or a cookie cutter technique. I'm figuring out for myself what will help me be celibate. Do you see anything that is obviously wrong?

Things I'm doing or have tried or might try:

- Journaling about precepts, sensuality, celibacy, sexuality, and so on.
- Contemplating my faith. What do I have faith in and why?
- Trying to cultivate hiri ottappa, but I'm not really sure how to do this. Figuring it out.
- 5 recollections, and especially death recollection
- Noticing that lack of lust feels good and lust feels bad.
- Thinking about the value of renunciation.
- Trying to see sensuality like burning coals.
- When unagitated and in a safe environment, imagining scenarios that might tempt me to break precepts then contemplating the drawbacks and why I should still keep the precepts.
- Management techniques
- Trying to do the basics of anapanasati rightly so I endure more. When done wrongly, it seems like a management technique which is still better than breaking precepts.
- Reflecting on Dhamma talks, essays, suttas, etc.

EDIT: Maybe it would be helpful to share my history of major misunderstandings.

1. Years ago, I thought I should just sit in a chair and not do anything for hours a day because anything I did would be out of craving.
2. Thought I should keep the precepts, but also never do anything that had an unwholesome state behind. Virtue wiki explicitly says this is wrong. So I was keeping my practice tighter than it should be.
3. Today - ???

EDIT 2: **My main concern is having the appropriate sub-goals and goals.** If that is off, then practice is wrongly directed.

The things I've tried, are just my attempts at what might help with the sub-goal of keeping the precepts. I don't know what works, but you can probably infer a rationale behind them.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-28 14:13:13*

It seems like you think you need a strategy that diminishes the challenge of keeping the precepts in order to reliably keep them. That attitude is going to make your virtue conditional (and thus not a proper container for training the mind).

It's not inherently wrong to make some effort to diminish the difficulty, such as changing your environment to reduce overwhelming temptations (though as we've said before, management techniques distract you too much from where the actual work happens in order to be useful). But in the end, you will keep falling off the wagon unless you are ready to not give in even when it's most challenging, because the strong pressure to act out will always return eventually.

spiffyhandle

Bhante, I thought about what you wrote about mistakenly using strategies to keeping the pressure lower so the precepts (especially celibacy) vs keeping precepts unconditionally regardless of pressure. Other than management techniques (which are less than weekly) I do think I aim at unconditionally keeping precepts regardless of pressure. The reason I have tried all those different practices is because I see celibacy vs incelibacy as a choice. Basically, **I am trying to find the reasons that will cause me to always choose celibacy and to not forget those reasons.**

The most difficult times for me is not when there's a ton of lust. When lust is extreme, it highlights how painful it is and the nature of the trap. The times when it's hardest to keep celibacy is when sexuality is alluring and I stop caring about my precepts.

Part of me feels like I'm overly intellectualizing this and I just need to say "no!" to breaking celibacy. To that end, I've started setting some quiet time aside in the morning to remind myself that I want to be celibate then keep that intention alive throughout the day.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-30 07:46:39*

> Basically, **I am trying to find the reasons that will cause me to always choose celibacy and to not forget those reasons.**

Sure, developing that clarity is part of the picture. But my point is that the "bedrock" is not that clarity, but rather the resolve that you will not act out even when you completely forget those reasons (which will happen no matter how hard you try to prevent it, because the strength and clarity of the context will not be permanent).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Agreeable_Range_8732 *2026-06-21 17:29:17 ###* Seemingly contradicting statements by Ajahn Nyanamoli and Bhikku Anigha on meditation (as far as I can tell)

From Bhikku Anigha:

“Under that Buddha’s own definition, meditation (bhāvanā), be it Anapanasati or anything else is the cultivation of the 7 enlightenment factors, and these exist only for a stream-enterer.

So in the end, the problem is not ***what*** a person is practicing per se. The point is not that if you do AN’s “method” instead, you will be practicing properly. If only it were that easy.

Meditation is the further development of the cessation of suffering that person has already understood. Thus, if they don’t see the cessation of suffering, it follows that whatever meditation they’re doing will be about something else (managing*,* running away from suffering, or getting a separate pleasure to cancel it out). Whether or not they regard it to be in line with the Four Noble Truths or not is not a valid criterion, because the point is that they haven’t seen those truths yet to begin with. In fact, an attempt to cultivate the 7 enlightenment factors when one still hasn’t understood what enlightenment entails taking one’s current idea of what enlightenment and suffering are for granted.”

From Ajahn:

“If a person wants to do his meditation in a “formal” manner,

such as sit for an hour a few times a day, that is fine. As long as it

is not done for the purpose of developing some sort of “experience of

absorption” out of it. Like trying to watch one’s breath hoping for

some novelty energy release or pleasures. The point of meditation

is to remain aware as much as possible. Aware or mindful of whatever

is already there enduring (feeling, perception, intentions). Not

interfere with it, or deny it, or try to replace it. Just discerning the

enduring presence of the arisen experience. Emotionally, perceptually

and intentionally. That kind of composure can then be “spread

out” over one’s entire day, even when a person is not sitting down

to meditate. ”

The book I got Ajahn's quote from is Dhamma Within Reach, which was what was recommended to me by Sister Medhini when I first discovered HH and was starting out. So, I assume that this book is applicable to beginners as well. So, why does it have any mention of meditation at all if it is aimed at beginners?

Bhikku Anigha claims that meditation is for sottapannas and above, that if we were to try to meditate, try to cultivate the 7 enlightenment factors (one of them being mindfulness, the practice of which is clearly explained in the excerpt I gave), that it would not work. If I'm not mistaken, he mentions in another post that this would lead to Wrong Liberation.

So, if Ajahn's book is not only for sotapannas, why is meditation mentioned at all if HH doesn't want us to practice it at this stage? And if that part is solely mentioned for sotapannas only, and puthujannas need to ignore that part and follow the rest of the book, then the book should mention that.

Why did Sister Medhini even recommend me a book that may be to advanced for me?

Here is another quote from Ajahn, where he mentions in the same book that is, mind you, **for beginners**:

"One needs to find that kind of

composure that one can maintain in different circumstances. The

way to do this is by establishing the general mindfulness. Not the

particular observation and adherence to the prescribed steps of a

"meditation" technique, that results in one being absorbed in it. But

the opposite: awareness of one's general situation as a whole (e.g.

an enduring mood, state of mind, persisting feeling etc.). Common

practice of "absorption" can then be seen as the complete opposite

of this type of general mindfulness."

While Bhikku Anigha says, "Under that Buddha's own definition, meditation (bhāvanā), be it Anapanasati or anything else is the cultivation of the 7 enlightenment factors, and these exist only for a stream-enterer."

Mindfulness or awareness is one of the seven enlightenment factors, and he says they are only for a stream-enterer, while Ajahn tells us to establish general mindfulness, in as soon as the 3rd chapter of a beginner's book.

Another comment by Bhikku Anigha: "Any type of meditation that promises itself to be right while one is a puthujjana is intrinsically wrong, whether it's noting, watching your breath, loving-kindness mantras, or even **"choiceless awareness"/"open awareness"**, simply because it won't push you to become

aware of your intentions, which is where craving, the defilements, and everything you actually need to understand lies. Your mind is still subject to greed, aversion, and delusion not because you don't spend enough time"noting" or because the noting hasn't given rise to some special fruition experience, but because you don't sufficiently recognize the degree to which your own intentions, including the intention to practice noting, as well as anything else you do, say, or think, is affected with those defilements."

So Bhikku Anigha denies that any kind of "meditation technique" works, even if it's something like some sort of awareness practice, or trying to be aware of your intentions when sitting in solitude.

While u/kyklon_anarchon says this for open awareness: "in the way i see it, open awareness properly understood [and carried through as both an on cushion and off cushion attitude] is the functional equivalent of guarding the sense doors. [only two monastics that i ve read explicitly see it in these terms though – Bhikkhu Analayo and Bhikkhu Aggacitta, who, incidentally, is a student of Sayadaw U Tejaniya, and has talks about this on youtube – examining how what he considers open awareness is the sense restraint in the gradual training].

[so, what you are doing both in open awareness if you don t mystify it and in guarding your sense doors is that] you notice you dwell on something with lust or aversion in the background, and you unhook yourself from dwelling on that object / topic through explicitly including / recognizing *something else* that is co-present. one question that both Ajahn Nyanamoli and Joan Tollifson use to this effect is "what else is there?" – and the question leads the mind in the direction of *finding something else, co-present*. for me, the main "thing" that is there regardless of what else is there – and acts as a condition of possibility for *anything else* being there – is the body. in becoming aware of the body as present – which is not the same thing as "feeling the body", but also *does not exclude* feeling the body, one becomes unhooked from that which was absorbing, and can dwell in a way that is aware of the basic situation one is in, which includes the body *and everything else correlated with its presence*. one can use any satipatthana as this kind of place to return. it seems to me that, in his own practice, judging by old videos, Ajahn Nyanamoli was prioritizing vedana; at other points – kaya."

Everyone seems to be contradicting each other, as far as I can tell.

And I personally don't really see what's wrong with trying to set up peripheral awareness or mindfulness when I sit in solitude. How can that be unbeneficial or unwholesome? Seems like the fastest way to progress to me, since mindfulness is the endgame.

If I am missing something, I'm happy to be corrected. I want to reconcile everything here, I am very confused. I also apologize for the very messy format, the questions are all over the place.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-22 05:18:58*

> How can that be unbeneficial or unwholesome?

Not seeing how it could be unwholesome is what will make it unwholesome. It means you will be assuming a certain practice (whatever that is) to be correct because of *what* it is, independently of whether you're doing it out of longing, aversion, restlessness, etc. And that's precisely why a puthujjana cannot simply dedicate themselves to "practicing mindfulness." The definition of being a puthujjana is not clearly seeing those unwholesome states in their own mind, which means their attempts to purify their mind are guaranteed to be informed by tradition, hearsay, reasoning, etc., rather than on the actual decrease of their defilements.

That doesn't mean that a puthujjana is automatically doing something wrong if they try to develop wholesome states (unless they are doing so on the basis of incomplete precepts and sense restraint). But if they are ever to cease to be a puthujjana, that effort should be centered on understanding what wholesome states are in the first place, not developing whatever impression of wholesome states they currently have (which, again, will inevitably be based on external standpoints). That automatically rules out every single "method" you could ever come across, including anything you could try to extract from HH teachings.

So there isn't a contradiction in the different statements you quoted; you will even find plenty of instances AN saying similar things as what I wrote, and vice versa. That's because both angles need to be incorporated simultaneously: "I don't see what the right effort is, but I will inevitably be making some sort of effort. Thus, within that effort, let me try and understand what makes certain efforts right and others wrong."

Agreeable_Range_8732

So if puthujjanas were never meant to practice mindfulness, then why does Ajahn even mention mindfulness in a book for beginners, let alone describe how it's to be done?

And I still don't understand how simply trying to be mindful can be unwholesome. When I just sit there in solitude, I have no intentions to do anything. My only intention is to just sit there. While intentions to stand up and go do something, or some other unwholesome intentions do come up, I don't act out of them, neither do I push them away. I simply endure them until they leave. So, up until now, neither have I done anything unwholesome, neither have I entertained any unwholesome intention in my mind, neither were there any unwholesome intentions to start the practice (for example, practicing for mystical experiences). Then I simply try to set up peripheral awareness, of the breath or of mood/feelings or of any other anchor, as best as I can.

My primary intention of even doing this practice is to simply be aware of un-

wholesome intentions in my mind, so that I can be rid of them. Ajahn even mentions in the same excerpt I gave, that you can carry this practice off the cushion as well, spreading it out over your entire day.

How is any of this unwholesome? I'm genuinely trying to grasp how this practice can be detrimental.

And even if I don't understand what wholesome and unwholesome is, some degree of faith has to be kept to even start the practice, right? It's the same with precepts: I don't intrinsically know that breaking the precepts means acting out of craving, but I do know that theoretically. The same way, I don't know that my practice of mindfulness as described by AN is wholesome or not, but I at least have to try it.

And why should the effort should be centered on understanding what wholesome states are in the first place? You never gave an explanation as to why it's to be done first.

And if that is the case, then you cannot even start the precepts because you'll be assuming that the practice of precepts is correct/wholesome. You also said, "Not seeing how it could be unwholesome is what will make it unwholesome." I definitely do not see how precepts can be unwholesome, so does that mean following the precepts becomes unwholesome?

My attempts to purify my mind using precepts are also informed by tradition, hearsay, reasoning, etc., rather than on the actual decrease of their defilements.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-23 14:17:15*

> My primary intention of even doing this practice is to simply be aware of unwholesome intentions in my mind, so that I can be rid of them. Ajahn even mentions in the same excerpt I gave, that you can carry this practice off the cushion as well, spreading it out over your entire day.

That's fine in principle. The point to remember is that not having the ability to discern unwholesome intentions is why you're not a *sotāpanna*. Then you won't be assuming that you found the way to "abandon unwholesome intentions," and you will be more focused on learning what that actually means than on doing what you think it means (some extent of the latter is inevitable, but the priority remains on the former).

As I already said, you will have to be doing *something* in the name of practice, and whatever it is (including complete abstinence from practice) will be tainted with ignorance until you're a *sotāpanna*. The hindrance is not to merely *be* in the wrong, but rather to not acknowledge the initial wrongness (which is the same attitude that would stop you from gaining true expertise in anything, not just the Dhamma).

Agreeable_Range_8732

I think I understand to some extent. What I understood from this was that I can keep practicing the way I've been doing (precepts, trying to discern intentions before acting out of them in daily life) ***including*** peripheral awareness, but I have to acknowledge that whatever practice I do will be somewhat incorrect. So always intending to upgrade to a superior version of the practice. Is this right, or have I misunderstood?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-24 05:23:47*

> So always intending to upgrade to a superior version of the practice. Is this right, or have I misunderstood?

In essence, yes. But there needs to be a sense of genuine urgency and doubt behind that, through seeing how you continue to be liable to suffering one way or the other, despite your best attempts to overcome that liability. Not just an arms-length intention for improvement that virtually every practitioner has while ultimately continuing to take their core views for granted.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-06-15 04:44:52*
How to Interpret the Vinaya

This question is mostly directed towards u/Sister_Medhini and u/Bhikkhu_Anigha since they are the ones most qualified to answer it. I am unsure how exactly to work with the conflict between what I see as three overlapping categories: the Vinaya, the traditional interpretation of the Vinaya, and the practice itself. I'll give a few examples. Pācittiya 35 states that once a bhikkhu has turned down an offer of more food, he cannot then go and eat more food. The background story to this rule makes it clear that it is mostly about having concluded a meal with one donor, and then going and taking food from another donor anyway. However, the Commentary (which my tradition follows) interprets this as meaning that, having refused any offer of food during a meal, one cannot accept any more food and must finish their portion without even leaving their seat. Obviously this interpretation is silly; I should be able to turn down one kind of food and accept another kind during a meal, or be able to get up. It even leads monks to frustration in trying to somehow signal to people that they don't want the food they're being offered without formally refusing it so they can continue to take food. Nevertheless, at least this example is fairly simple to work around — if I followed the Commentary here, it would be just so I don't get told off by my tradition, but I would know that if I didn't follow the Commentary, I wouldn't be doing anything wrong per se. It does show that you have to double check everything you hear people say about the Vinaya, though.

My problem is that, despite the fact that the Commentarial interpretations of the Vinaya are often overtly ridiculous, that doesn't change the fact that even

an ’EBT interpretation‘ of the Vinaya still has to be an interpretation. For example, Ven. Ṭhānissaro’s BMC states:

> […] in the West we are left with a somewhat zigzag line separating what are and are not staple foods for the purposes of the rules: Meal pounded from grain is a staple; flour ground from grain is not. Bread made with oat meal, corn meal, wheat germ, etc., would thus be a staple; bread made without any grain meal or eggs would not. The same holds true for pastries, noodles, and pasta.

I feel like someone who is faithful to the spirit of the Vinaya could reasonably either try to preserve the original definition of a staple food here, or rather re-define it such that it includes anything that would be a staple food in the West. But by what criteria should one make such a decision? My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind, and therefore that an attempt to adequately interpret every rule in the Vinaya becomes more of a scholarly endeavour than a practical one. As we know, the Buddha himself said the minor rules could be abolished. We also don’t know for certain that the Vibhaṅga is accurate in preserving the original purpose of a rule. Additionally, the interpretation of the specifics of the Vinaya differs within Theravāda Buddhism so much that one cannot even claim that interpreting these rules is important for social harmony either. By following that criteria, one would instead often have to go along with the Commentarial interpretation followed by one’s monastery (as indeed I do, in order to avoid any criticism). If EBT monastics were to start ignoring the traditional rule of having food placed directly in their hands, it would most likely cause more disruption than it’s worth, for example.

So if many of these rules are basically historical fossils, and they are not directly relevant to the practice (as is hinted at in the Suttas and the Vinaya itself many times), how should Westerners who are concerned about authenticity interpret them? For example, it is not uncommon for me to be offered small things like garlic, berries, chocolate, etc. in the evening. My guess would be that by a strictly academic reading of the Vinaya, these would not be allowable. But why would I go through the social awkwardness of turning these offers down and risking a discussion about the Vinaya if I know it isn’t even unwholesome for me to accept it? Trying to draw strict lines here creates many silly results, such as debating at what point milk turns into buttermilk, or not being allowed by your monastery to drink milk in the afternoon but still being allowed to eat some solid foods. I feel like even a faithful EBT reading of the Vinaya could fall into the same trap of ridiculous legalism that the Commentaries fell into many times. It feels to me like dealing with these boundaries is more unrelated to the actual intentions present in one’s mind than practicing with the boundaries of the 8 precepts as a householder. Obviously I would take the 10 precepts as fundamental to the life of a monastic (if vikāla bhojana is defined as not eating a proper meal after noon, in order to

avoid all the nitpicking I mentioned before), but I am unsure how to deal with the minor rules. Thank you!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-16 18:28:30*

> My problem is that many of the rules in the Vinaya are not relevant to the actual practice of training the mind

True, but the fact is that you will often be more inconvenienced by dismissing them than by simply keeping them, as even in the West you will still often be perceived in a bad light by those with EBT knowledge if you dismiss even minor rules. And those rules certainly don't *interfere* with the training of the mind either.

So you end up in basically the same situation as the elders in the same council: the Buddha did say the minor rules could be dismissed, but trying to implement that allowance will just create unnecessary criticism from laity and arguments within the Sangha.

That also means that it's not terribly relevant for you as an individual whether a certain rule or custom is "EBT-based," or developed through commentaries or Asian culture. Back then they had to do things to cater to people's arbitrary expectations. Nowadays it's the same, just that the ones holding the expectations happen to be Buddhist.

Formal_Breath_2026

> That also means that it's not terribly relevant for you as an individual whether a certain rule or custom is "EBT-based," or developed through commentaries or Asian culture. Back then they had to do things to cater to people's arbitrary expectations. Nowadays it's the same, just that the ones holding the expectations happen to be Buddhist.

But does that mean that when I am offered small pieces of food in the evening like chocolate or garlic, or the five tonics even when I'm not sick — things that I know would probably not be acceptable under the original framework of the Vinaya but are for some reason considered so by my tradition now — it is okay to accept them for the sake of non-conflict? I am wondering if with the minor rules what you said goes both ways, i.e. does it only apply when the tradition is stricter than the original rule or does it apply when the tradition is looser as well. Obviously not including when certain traditions ignore major rules like handling money or eating full meals in the evening.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-06-17 18:34:02*

> But does that mean that when I am offered small pieces of food in the evening like chocolate or garlic, or the five tonics even when I'm not sick — things that I know would probably not be acceptable under the original framework of the Vinaya but are for some reason

> considered so by my tradition now — it is okay to accept them for the sake of non-conflict?

If greed is the motivation (i.e., the arisen state of your mind at the time, not a theoretical inference) then you shouldn't accept the tonics even if they are fully allowable. As long as you never compromise on that, everything else is secondary. And you will be distracted from that criterion if you put the technicalities first and think that you are "more pure" simply by following "the original framework" (which is an easy trap to fall into).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by None *2026-05-26 17:56:59* ### Venerable Anigha and Venerable Medhini please have pity on me

[deleted]

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-28 17:36:46*

> In my doubt, last night, I decided to see what it would feel like to have that pressure endure. So I thought up some lustful images, and started masturbating to the point where I was close to ejaculation, and I had to absorb myself in the fantasies to keep going. I stopped and observed what would happen in my mind. There was an urge to keep going, and as soon as I stopped willfully ignoring it, it stopped pressuring me. I went to bed without trouble.

Enduring the pressure on the right level means not thinking up the lustful images to begin with, let alone masturbating. Whatever change of course happens after those choices is really just containing the defeat, not victory.

So it sounds like you just have to take the precepts and celibacy more seriously. From where you are standing, that will undoubtedly lead to covering up/suppressing things less, and there is no point in worrying about subtler cover ups until that's sorted.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Emergency_Win_3698 *2026-05-26 15:33:38* ### Is treating gender dysphoria through medical intervention acting out of craving?

Side note: I'm making another post specifically for this question because the last one was supposed to be about monastic options for a person that stays on HRT and gets some surgeries to address their body dysphoria, and it sort of went off track. I have also discussed this question with others (including privately) and I don't feel that a consensus was ever reached. I would appreciate any insight into this issue.

Description of my situation: I experience intense dread when I imagine indefinitely ceasing the medications I currently take that suppress my androgen

levels (and raise estradiol) in order to prevent further masculinization from occurring. I also experience dread when I imagine indefinitely foregoing surgeries and trying to accept my body as it is.

On top of that dread, there is a baseline of wrongness/unpleasantness, escalating sometimes to a considerable level of distress (though it is not a constant) that is amplified when I focus on a given feature that is male/masculine. But it is always palpable as a baseline unpleasant quality of experience that is present the second I wake up. This is worse for secondary sex characteristics like bone and cartilage development, increased upper body musculature, balding, facial and body hair (rather than genitalia for which my aversion tends to be comparatively weaker). Social situations tend to amplify this issue by increasing hypervigilant attention to a cluster of traits (e.g., shoulder width, height, face, skull, hands, feet, etc.), usually resulting in more intense distress than when I am alone, though it depends on the circumstances.

Detransitioning *feels* like it would be self-mortification because of the distress that I expect it would result in. But I also acknowledge that the fact I feel so much dread and aversion toward this issue is potentially evidence that I am incredibly attached–perhaps more so than to anything else. Why, for example, do I even take the HRT? I do so because I feel a lot of anxiety and dread around masculinizing any more. So, there is clearly aversion toward that present.

Also, no matter how I justify it to myself, medically transitioning feels like a diversion/distraction from the path and from nibbana, as I am essentially trying to make the body be the way I want it to be and hold the belief that I cannot achieve peace (or even successfully practice) otherwise. I realize that I had the belief that I "just need to fix this" and *then* I can take the practice off the backburner and dedicate my life to fully uprooting suffering. But that's not really logical, is it?

At present I am working a job in order to cover the surgeries I would need to make a dent in my dysphoria. So, the stakes are genuinely high and deciding to call the whole thing off would be a huge decision for which I would need substantial justification.

Questions I have (apart from post title):

1. Do you think that going through with surgeries and such to modify the body will permanently increase attachment to it in the long run and/or obstruct the right view?
2. If medical transition is a poor idea because of the above, what should I do instead (keeping in mind that this isn't an identity issue of "I feel like [preferred gender]." It manifests as often intense distress that has in the past compelled me to desire death)?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-26 20:06:15*

There is no doubt that these interventions constitute acting out of craving

(and the intense dread you experience at the prospect of stopping them only proves it further). Pursuing them is reinforcing the deep-seated assumption that the escape from suffering lies in changing the circumstances.

The thing is that, going by what you describe, it's likely not realistic to stop it all at once. It may be too much pressure for you to withstand at this point, and you may well end up in a worse position in the aftermath of quitting too rapidly.

The more realistic course of action is to gradually cut back on the interventions, while also starting to challenge all the emotional attitudes driving you to them rather than taking them for granted and justifying them.

The fact that there could be a minimum degree of treatment necessary to prevent yourself from falling apart—at this time, due to insufficient training of the mind—doesn't mean that you have to accept other measures that build on top of that. And it is almost certain that you are currently doing more than that bare minimum.

By going closer to that minimum, the aversion will come up in a more manageable degree, and that will create some basis for training and going against the grain. Up until you can finally abandon the whole thing when the aversion in regard to *that* isn't strong enough to completely overwhelm you as it might now.

Emergency_Win_3698

Thank you, Bhante.

> and the intense dread you experience at the prospect of stopping them only proves it further

Why is that diagnostic? Are you saying that the severity of the condition is what justifies withdrawing the treatment?

> Pursuing them is reinforcing the deep-seated assumption that the escape from suffering lies in changing the circumstances.

Couldn't this charge be leveled at any form of medicine that is treating a condition that causes suffering?

Doesn't MN 2 state that one should take medicines to "ward off the pains of illness" (or to ward off 'oppressing feeling')?

> There is no doubt that these interventions constitute acting out of craving (and the intense dread you experience at the prospect of stopping them only proves it further)

Is there any way that I could continue to intervene without acting out of it/fueling the craving, like how one could take pain medication with a mind of craving without the intention being itself rooted in craving?

> while also starting to challenge all the emotional attitudes driving you to them rather than taking them for granted and justifying them.

I'm not sure how exactly to go about doing this.

> And it is almost certain that you are currently doing more than that bare minimum.

I don't think so. I'm not sure how I could be doing any less than what I am currently doing. All I do right now is take HRT, which prevents the situation from worsening. It doesn't really do anything else. It doesn't make the dysphoria much more manageable. I am looking into getting some surgeries, which would likely put a dent in it (but not get rid of all the aversion either per se, as some things cannot be easily fixed or at all). But I would say that it's not very manageable right now because I am in constant pain and discomfort over it and it causes significant dysfunction.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-27 14:51:37*

> Why is that diagnostic? Are you saying that the severity of the condition is what justifies withdrawing the treatment?

The severity of suffering shows the extent of craving (that's how it works across the board).

> Couldn't this charge be leveled at any form of medicine that is treating a condition that causes suffering?

Not in the same way. The crucial difference is that most conditions can exist independently of craving and suffering, whereas gender dysphoria cannot. That means that treating it externally can never be a neutral choice from a Dhamma perspective.

> Is there any way that I could continue to intervene without acting out of it/fueling the craving, like how one could take pain medication with a mind of craving without the intention being itself rooted in craving?

Therefore, no.

But just to repeat, this doesn't mean that you must stop the interventions overnight if that has a high risk of overwhelming you. The point is to start valuing and moving in the opposite direction, not to immediately arrive at its end.

> I'm not sure how exactly to go about doing this.

Reflecting on the condition as objectively as you can until you see with more certainty that it is directly tied to unwholesome states of mind, and is not something you can simply accept and try to develop wholesome states on top

of. Essentially, getting to the point where intellectually at least, you see that abandoning the treatments is what is in your ultimate welfare.

Then, weaning off the treatments will still be unpleasant and doubts about the decision might still arise from time to time, but you will have grounds for sticking to it regardless.

> I am looking into getting some surgeries, which would likely put a dent in it (but not get rid of all the aversion either per se, as some things cannot be easily fixed or at all).

That could be a way of going beyond the bare minimum. It's definitely going beyond what you currently have, which will only make reversing direction more difficult.

> But I would say that it's not very manageable right now because I am in constant pain and discomfort over it and it causes significant dysfunction.

What I mean with "manageable" can still be quite unpleasant. If you can sustain it without having a mental breakdown then it's manageable.

Emergency_Win_3698

> The crucial difference is that most conditions can exist independently of craving and suffering, whereas gender dysphoria cannot.

Bhante, I am confused as to why this is. What makes gender dysphoria special in this regard?

I am willing to grant that gender dysphoria proper (i.e., the actual distress resulting from an untamed mind laden with craving and assumption) most probably cannot exist without craving being present, but could not there be a baseline of pre-cognitive disagreeableness (like the disturbance of the six sense bases) or a kind of perceptual mismatch that would persist even in an arahant with it? If that were the case, it would mean that it wasn't categorically different from other illnesses.

> What I mean with "manageable" can still be quite unpleasant. If you can sustain it without having a mental breakdown then it's manageable.

Most of the time I can bear it, yes. But I go through periods of emotional volatility–sometimes culminating in a mental breakdown–when it flares up. At least before I started making an effort to get surgeries. Since then I have not had a breakdown due to this, although as you said it is "quite unpleasant" still.

My suicidal thoughts (which normally are a regular occurrence) have also ceased for now, as they are evidently the product of a despairing mind that sees no hope of alleviating the suffering, rather than being directly related to the pain or unpleasantness of the GD itself.

The despair resulting from not making efforts toward remedying the issue is what renders the condition unmanageable (per your definition), essentially.

So, it seems like the only reason it is manageable at present is the fact that I am working toward surgeries, and ceasing those efforts would therefore increase the likelihood of having a mental breakdown and of the suicidal thoughts returning full force.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-28 04:52:15*

> What makes gender dysphoria special in this regard?

The fact that the condition itself (rather than a consequence of it) is called "dysphoria"—meaning unease/dissatisfaction/unhappiness—highlights what makes it different.

> but could not there be a baseline of pre-cognitive disagreeableness (like the disturbance of the six sense bases) or a kind of perceptual mismatch that would persist even in an arahant with it?

No, because such disagreeableness would require the mind still having concern for the body.

> So, it seems like the only reason it is manageable at present is the fact that I am working toward surgeries, and ceasing those efforts would therefore increase the likelihood of having a mental breakdown and of the suicidal thoughts returning full force.

That's possible. But you have to realize that no amount of displeasure produces those reactions by itself. In other words, you have to take full responsibility for them.

See how that goes before deciding to go for the surgeries.

Emergency_Win_3698

> In other words, you have to take full responsibility for them.

And how specifically do I do that?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-28 17:43:49*

You cease to see yourself as a victim in despair and renounce the bittersweet gratification that comes from that attitude (which is the direction every mind tends to go whenever something is highly unpleasant). You maintain the context that despairing is a choice, and that it only worsens the displeasure.

Hard_Tack4 *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Are you saying that arahants don't feel any sense of disagreability? If they had genuinely *no* concern for the body they wouldn't eat. It seems like an arahant could have some sense of disagreability that might even be something

like dysmorphia, but it wouldn't be taken in the same way, the disagreability wouldn't be felt.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-29 04:09:45*

> Are you saying that arahants don't feel any sense of disagreability?

No. A dislike for the given body's male/female features and a desire for the opposite is not just a neutral and unavoidable disagreeability on the level of hunger or physical illness. It's a symptom of mental affinity towards the body, similar to what this Sutta describes.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by account-7 *2026-05-21 16:26:43* ### Question on the nature of HH's critique of other traditions

Hello! Just a brief question to understand what the Hillside Hermitage stance is on this. I have heard - most of which I agree with - many thoughtful and useful critiques on almost every other tradition's pedagogy and presentation of the Dhamma. However, I want to better understand the scope of this critique as I, potentially intentionally, haven't heard a direct answer in all I've seen the past couple years here. Though I think it would be useful to hear if offered.

I will not name names as to put anyone answering in the awkward (and probably useless/impossible) position of naming specific individuals who do or do not teach the Dhamma, but is the HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception? Such as prominent Thai Forest teachers, Chan/Zen, or veering a bit into perennialism but even non-Buddhist contemplative traditions like Advaita? And in this case, would their "attainments" just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Or is it more just a generalized concern for the preservation of the dhamma in its most efficient, canonically accurate form. Dismissing not the potential validity of those paths to lead to fruitions, but their efficacy and the massive traps/potential pitfalls that is seen as mitigated within HH instructions; while leaving room for the possibility that individuals could make their way into right view despite a flawed framework?

Thank you for your time!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-22 04:34:40*

> HH position that alternative frameworks are structurally incapable of producing liberation because they operate on a fundamental misconception?

Yes, it's a structural issue whereby those frameworks cannot lead to *anything but* pitfalls. Becoming accomplished in them puts one in a worse position than

one started in (see below).

A less ideal or efficient framework leading the same goal would not warrant dismissal.

> And in this case, would their “attainments” just be chalked up to maintaining refined states of samadhi?

Wrong samādhi, wrong knowledge, and wrong liberation. In simple terms that means: not experiencing (perceptible) dukkha because the circumstances that trigger it have been altered, not because craving in regard to all possible circumstances has diminished. And that is what delusion, the most insidious of the three defilements, boils down to.

Of course, this need not be the stated mechanism of operation of a certain practice in order to be the actual mechanism. That mechanism can be embedded in an endless array of different narratives and descriptions.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by tejveeer *2026-05-15 02:33:15* ### Request: sequential series for beginners?

I have been in conversation with an old friend for some time about the dhamma - at least my understanding of it.

I had spent some time uncovering some views he had tacitly due to the scientific culture we were bought up in. Since they were challenged, he seems more open to consider the possibility of future birth, the weight of which he seems to be realizing to some degree now.

Because of this he showed some interest in HH’s teachings, except I had nowhere I could point for starters. The slovenian videos? The sri lankan videos?

Unfortunately, HH’s teachings now, even though they seem more targetted towards beginners, feel even more difficult to enter than they were before. It feels almost as if someone needs the context accumulated across all 500 videos and years of trying to make sense of the suttas and their pali to really begin making any sense of the new videos.

I think this is because of the following reasons:

1. The format of the videos. They are conversations between the venerables themselves, in which there is a questioner and answerer. The questioner assumes the place of an abstract viewer, rather than actual live viewers.
2. The content of the videos. The content is often a part of the whole of HH’s teachings, where how that part fits into the whole is only sometimes mentioned, or when it is, it is overriden by the multiplicity of topics covered.
3. The lack of hierarchy in the videos. The videos seem like a bunch of topics concatenated together: A B C D E F …, which is natural since IRL

> conversations flow without hierarchy; as new questions come up, the topics change. But this is extremely costly on the viewers because, in my estimate, every video has at least 15-20 topics changes. Viewers have to hold context of the discussion, see how it might be related to the multiple changes that previously occurred, process incoming discussions, remember very important bits. The same video may go from talking about sati, to yoniso manasikara, to a sutta, to sense restraint, to avijja, to another sutta, to meditation techniques, etc. This means the very important parts of the video, say topic B, F, H, are lost since the video is so linear.

This may be compared in contrast to a pre-planned video on a subject that has an explicit hierarchy.

Say there is a doctor who is giving an update on the medication plan to their patient over a 20 minute video. They plan that the starting 5 minutes are for introducing the purpose of this new plan; how it fits into the overall plan of recovery. The next 5 are for addressing existing medication. The next 10 are for new medication.

In the new medication, they will have 5 minutes for what the new medication is, why it's needed, and its sides effects. The next 5 for how to use it.

There is a clear hierarchy here. Three top-level topics: context, current medication, new medication. And the 3rd has two sub-topics: Introduction, application.

Compare this to if the doctor made a 1 hour video in conversation with another doctor. They begin by introducing the new medication, then the research paper that supports this, then the research papers that don't support this medication and the issues with them, then the context of the new medication, then some new research papers, then the application of the new medication, then the side effects, then its purpose, etc.

Of course, it is completely up to the venerables on whether this is of any benefit. But I think it would be very beneficial to existing members and to others outside the community willing to learn to have a course-like presentation of the core of the dhamma by HH, that builds from ground up.

The whole of HH's teachings can be divided into positive and negative parts. The positive is concerned with their own views, the negative with addressing views that will obstruct others from understanding/considering HH's positive views.

The positive part is concerned centrally with the HH's aim: to teach for the uprooting not management of suffering. Then this would be split off into two branches that elaborate on this distinction: on management and on uprooting.

In order for newcomers to understand why management is problematic, they must understand how HH understands the actual uprooting of suffering. So it

is possible to start off from the uprooting branch and address that as its own topic in a video.

This branch would address what the root of the problem is (craving), what the solution is (removing craving), and how that solution is implemented (i.e., it would introduce the notions of the four noble truths and the five aggregates).

Then it's possible to more easily make sense of what management is (namely, everything that is not addressing the root), and why it's problematic (it doesn't address the root).

Then one could exit the positive branch and address the negative branch. Chiefly, meditation techniques.

The course/series could be divided in 3/4th part to the positive part, and 1/4th to the negative. In the positive, 1/2 is spent on uprooting, 1/2 on management. And the same hierarchical division goes down more and more, and every video would itself be just another hierarchical division.

This would just be one among many ways of presenting HH's central views. But I personally think this would help save much time on both HH's part as well as on the viewers' part due to the clarity it can bring.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-15 14:30:31*

I'm sure we will continue to refine our approach to teaching, but the lack of a "course-like structure"—and the lack of hand-holding of the listener in general—is deliberate and will continue to be that way. It's the least we can do for an distant audience to keep them on the side of seeing (or at least trying to see) for themselves the experiential truths that our material is grounded in, rather than being distracted by intellectual connections with ideas they've heard before (including from us).

Giving in to the hunger for neatly presented information that newcomers will naturally have is a misstep rooted in yourself not understanding what the Dhamma is and how it is realized. What that actually achieves is helping people fall into the trap of thinking that they understand what they don't. They start to feel that the teachings "make sense" to them while their life and mental habits continue in the same trajectory as before, and that's a worse position than not having heard the teachings at all.

Merely making our teachings publicly available inevitably allows a number of people to fall into this trap, and we wouldn't want to increase that number.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by nubuda *2026-05-13 15:55:09* ### "Doing Nothing" Meditation

If you sit or lie down with eyes closed and just rest for long enough, eventually the thoughts begin to slow down and the mind settles on effortless awareness

of the body breathing. The clarity of the mind increases significantly if you practice it regularly. I think this is how Buddha experienced jhana when he was still a kid chilling under a tree.

Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation? In my experience it

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-14 04:21:42*

> Does Hillside Hermitage support such meditation?

No. Such practices play no role whatsoever on the path, and we have extensively explained why (as well as what samādhi actually is) in our teachings.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by bodily_heartfulness *2026-05-05 22:55:56*
the right peace before stream entry

I sometimes reflect upon the downsides of relationships, the dangers of sexuality, and so on. Sometimes, as a result of these reflections, there will be a sense of *unencumberedness*, a sense of the mind being more free and open, not weighed down by the stickiness, the weight, the insecurities, the desires, of it all.

I have a few questions regarding this.

1. Is this type of peace dangerous? Is it to be cultivated?
2. Is this “cheating”? In that, if this is practiced alongside of restraint, then restraint becomes easier because the mind, on occasions, will have a decreased level of thirst towards sensuality. Does this impact the training, because part of the goal of the precepts and virtue is to train the mind *in regards to* the pressure, not to not have pressure at all.
3. Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

(Note that this is all pre-stream-entry, when one doesn’t have the right reference.)

My own answer to some of these questions would be:

The purpose of these types of contemplations is to develop the right context, so that one does not act out in body, speech, or mind when one is pressured by sensuality. If these reflections lead to a temporary reduction in the pressure, or some temporary sense of freedom, that is fine, but that is not the point. Trying to decrease the pressure, or even trying to increase the pressure, is besides the point - the goal is not management, but the fundamental change in view, which means putting things in the right order, so that sensuality is first seen as dangerous and *never* worth engaging in.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-07 05:18:35*

> Continuing that train of thought, in general, if certain contemplations reduce the pressure, is that bad?

What is bad is to develop an association that restraint ought to be supported by peace, rather than being non-negotiable regardless of how painful it becomes.

That association will obstruct right view even if the peace you're describing is along the right lines because it means you continue to ignore the true nature of craving (which applies regardless of how you currently feel).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by True-Grape2605 *2026-05-05 13:11:26* ### I have created a free Sutta companion app - To implement Gradual training need review from hh

Bhante and friends,

I have built a free, offline sutta reading app called Sutta Companion — primarily for laypeople who want to study the Pāli Nikāyas and implement a daily practice based on the gradual training.

The app uses Bhikkhu Sujato's translations from the SuttaCentral database. It is free, ad-free, and fully offline. It is currently live on Android.

I am writing here specifically because I have recently added a practice module built around the gradual training as described in DN 2, MN 27, and MN 53 — from dāna and sīla through indriya saṃvara, sati-sampajañña, the five hindrances, paññā, brahmavihārā, samādhi, and vipassanā. Each stage in the app references the canonical source and uses short passages from Bhikkhu Sujato's translations to describe what is being tracked and why it appears at that point in the sequence.

I am a layperson and a software developer. I am not a monastic, not a scholar, and not trained in Pāli beyond basic reading. I have done my best to represent the gradual training faithfully but I am certain there are gaps, misrepresentations, or errors I am not qualified to catch myself.

Specifically I would welcome review on:

— Whether the sequence I have used (dāna → sīla → akushala kamma-patha → indriya saṃvara → sati-sampajañña → pañca nīvaraṇa → paññā → brahmavihārā → samādhi → vipassanā) accurately reflects the canonical gradual training or introduces distortions, although it is not hardcore sequence we need to follow there since lot of things can works parallel and helping each other parts .

— Whether the descriptions of each stage, which I have tried to draw from the suttas directly rather than from secondary sources, are faithful to the texts

— Whether the framing of samādhi as something that arises naturally from

the preceding stages rather than as a technique to be practised is correctly represented — I relied primarily on the stock gradual training formula in DN 2 and the rose-apple tree recollection in MN 36

— Whether anything in the practice module, particularly around the hindrances and vipassanā sections, risks misleading a practitioner or giving the wrong impression of what the practice involves

I have tried to be honest with users about the limits of what an app can track.I have also included a note in the path module saying I am a layperson, that there may be errors, and inviting corrections.

If any of you have the time and inclination to look at this and tell me what is wrong, I would be genuinely grateful. The app is available on the Play Store — I can also share screenshots of the practice module and path descriptions specifically if that is easier.

I built this for my own practice and for laypeople like me who want something grounded in the early texts rather than in modern mindfulness repackaging. If the Dhamma parts are not right, the app does not serve that purpose regardless of how well the software works.

With respect, Kapil

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-07 05:47:04*

The app looks great software-wise, although there some issues with the “Practice settings” section:

(1) In the first step of the Gradual Training, the third precept is celibacy, not just abstaining from sensual misconduct.

(2) Pinpointing the specific sense base in the sense restraint section is unnecessary and will likely lead to overthinking.

(3) In the Samādhi section, it shows the suggestion “30 min ānāpanasati, aiming for first jhāna,” clearly reflecting the common wrong view that jhāna is an absorbed state that “comes to you” after a certain period of some attentional exercise.

More generally, the act of logging per se—for anything beyond the precepts, which *are* clear-cut— is a strong indicator that a person is approaching the practice as just another technique/mechanical performance, and that means they are certainly not doing any of the right work on the mental level.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by EggplantNumerous8026 *2026-04-30 21:10:34* ### Right Restraint or Wrong Restraint?

I have trouble keeping restraint and not breaking the precepts.
For example i get a lustful/sexual thought, in the moment i comprehend that

this thought is dangerous and against the goal/virtue (Dhamma practice), not the thought itself but its implications, its leading me a certain way (pressure), and in the moment even though i know logically that this way is leading to danger and suffering and not ultimate satisfaction. I still get hooked by the prospect of pleasure and relief, which builds up more internal conflict and resistance to the idea of acting out until i completely lose perspective and become an animal/beast and act out.

and when i try to understand where i went wrong after breaking the virtue (HH and SH youtube channels) its many different answers that are correct but i feel they don't solve the problem. Such as you dont understand the danger enough, or you didn't endure on the right level, or you are not developed in the body, you chose to give in.

ive watched pretty much all the videos of HH and SH and many multiple times even up to 10 times some of them, and i've contemplated the teachings, all this over a time span of multiple years, and it all makes sense to me logically, i believe/have faith it is right. ive been long past the dunning-kruger effect, i know also logically that i dont understand truly what they are talking about because im not a sotapanna.

i feel like ive had more than enough information about how to practice the Dhamma, its just that im not restraint enough. and they say you have to purify bodily and verbal conduct before you can purify or even see the mind and start to purify that (simile of purifying gold). and i get that to a degree, but in my experience its the mind/mental states and the thought that pressure me to seek relief (yes from that greater underlying pain of suffering), so if these things originate at the mind and it presents me with the mental thoughts it want me to act out from (like Ajahn said the mind has a mind of its own) why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving, like the mind gets a sensual desire first but i am told that as a puthujhana i cant see my mind thus focus on "impeccable virtue". isnt it just better to stop the craving in its emerging domain first, before it spills out into other domains because yes in a fundamental level you cant handle the pressure or endure on the right level when you have lost your perspective (because i got careless). and somehow i have to balance this with training gradually also, so not doing to much at once? but not too little as well? How to determine what pressure to prioritize to not act out from, when all pressure shouldn't be acted out from? Just how do i get to the actual goal and understand the dhamma? any ideas? In one video on SH bhante Anigha said that "when you want to act out, just dont" (very close to this atleast), and like this is stating the obvious. and its correct but its not that helpfull, is he implaying that we have ultimate control/choice? so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides? its like yeah its his choice that frees him but that doesnt mean he wont relapse, like at the same time tha wild animal gets compared to a strong animal like a

wild bull elephant while we are the weaker animal that has to tame it smart. like we cannot just overpower it by sheer will, or can we? is the ability to consciously choose just a muscle that has to be trained as much a possible, so that when unwholesome desire arises we can stay clear from acting out? if so how to prevent burning out and relapse?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-05-03 04:04:45*

> why do i have to stop my bodily behavior, which is way down the line of giving in and acting out of craving,

Because intentional bodily actions are the coarsest mental actions you can do.

> so a fully addicted drug addict for >10 years or other type of addict can just stop when he decides?

Yes, because his body simply can’t take the drug on its own; he has to mentally choose that.

Each time he takes the drug again, he is deciding that stopping the pains of withdrawal is more important than eventually being free from the addiction. So, he must abstain from making that decision no matter what (which is very straightforward, just not easy in the beginning).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Solip123 *2026-04-26 17:26:16* ### Tendency to fixate on regret over past - what can be done about this?

I’m paying the price, constantly, for the (irreversible, life-altering, misery-inducing) decision that I made when I was a teenager. That memory of the repeated failures to act and the knowledge that I was the agent of my harm is frankly debilitating. It leads to intense self-loathing and despair because, when I look back, I see the stupidity and myopia of that entity with 20/20 vision.

However, I realized upon introspection that I can’t figure out what the self-loathing is even targeting. The past, at least phenomenologically/in the sense that matters, is dead and gone. And that entity that I hate so much is gone with it. All that remains is this, which isn’t that entity. The only thing that connects me to it, essentially, is memory traces, which are reconstructions anyway and thus representational. Am I on the right track with this, or is it the wrong way to think about it?

I want to curb this tendency because it distracts me from doing the necessary work to (at least partly) put things back together again. Not to mention that it is deeply unpleasant to think in this way.

Sister_Medhini *2026-04-28 05:11:15*

> The past, at least phenomenologically/in the sense that matters, is dead and gone. And that entity that I hate so much is gone with it. All that remains is this, which isn't that entity. The only thing that connects me to it, essentially, is memory traces, which are re-constructions anyway and thus representational. Am I on the right track with this, or is it the wrong way to think about it?

It is good to want to curb the tendency of self-loathing, but this is not the right way to go about it. The problem is that the past is perfectly real as such here and now, and what was done in the past is real here and now, and you *are* connected to it, because you are affected by it here and now. So it doesn't help to deny the reality of your past self or past actions, or your connection to it.

Fundamentally, what connects you to it are present actions rooted in greed, actions rooted in aversion, actions rooted in distraction. Whatever wrong was done in the past was because of the same greed, aversion and distraction of the mind, which you would be maintaining in the present through behaviours and choices. And it is also because of this that you would continue to feel the results of those past actions in the present.

To whatever extent you give up and do not do those actions, to that extent you will be truly disconnecting yourself from it.

On a more immediate level: the thought/phenomenon of a past wrong action is something that arises on its own as part of your reality, with its full significance and unpleasantness. And the mind will be pressuring you with directions of self-hating thought in regard to it. But the act of thinking those thoughts and giving them attention is something you unnecessarily do. It is this mental act that fuels aversion and makes you suffer.

These specific mental acts can be restrained in the same way you restrain your behaviour - but only if you have been training in restraining behaviour beforehand. If you haven't, that aspect of your responsibility on the mental level will be blurred, and attempts at restraint will usually end up becoming a form of denial.

Therefore, the precepts have to come first. If you aren't already, what will have by far the most impact is to simply train to keep the eight precepts seriously. If some of them are too difficult to maintain all the time, keep them at least one day a week and work up from there. In the meantime, try and literally just bear the self-loathing as best you can, without giving in to it too much or denying it too much. There is unfortunatly no quick or easy solution.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Hard_Tack4 *2026-04-26 17:06:42* ### Storage, items and Monks

What degree of personal items is allowable or a good idea for someone who is considering becoming a monk? The HH monks seem to have phones, maybe even laptops, cameras, audio equipment, have presumably used tickets, probably have medicines etc. What is reasonable? I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule. Ofc many monks even use money which is unambiguously bad. What should I get for myself? Can I get a tent and a nice backpack? An e-ink-tablet? A small camera? Some pens? An Mp3/4?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-27 04:49:50*

> I have read that the rules about personal possession of even medicine like frankincense is very restricted, you couldn't have 200 grams on your person it seems without breaking a rule.

There is no such rule in the Vinaya. Every monk is personally responsible for checking his motivations for possessing things.

With certain things, no matter how externally "luxurious", you can harbor no internal desire and not be significantly bothered if they are lost, whereas there can be "modest" and inexpensive things (and living beings as well) that you would passionately protect even though they are not strictly necessary to survive and to practice. That passion, not the things, is the problem, and you will be unable to address that problem if your focus is on the level of what and how much you have.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by spiffyhandle *2026-04-21 11:58:57* ### How to safely navigate increases in energy for someone with bipolar disorder?

Are there parts of the practice where energy will spike? If so, will it return to the previous level? And how am I supposed to avoid a manic episode if I'll have perpetually higher energy (and therefore less sleep)?

For context, I have bipolar disorder type 1. I take daily preventative medication for it. My bipolar manic episodes are triggered by several days of bad sleep But, I have had an episode from simply one single night of no sleep.

If I have a manic episode, I have to be hospitalized and it takes me at least 6 months to recover. My first episode took 3 years to return to my previous level of mental functioning. Given this, I am very cautious about getting enough sleep and I have extra medication (rescue medication) I can take for insomnia.

Right now, I just got back from a monastery visit that I ended early because I started having sleep problems that my rescue medicine wasn't helping with.

At the monastery, I got a stomach bug and was quarantined to my room so as not to spread it. It was near total seclusion. Practice was very challenging

but I was determined not to break the 8 precepts. And I succeeded. I even had a cellphone with internet access and I didn't touch it once. Very intense lust came up, boredom came up. All the usual stuff that I would give into but this time, I just endured everything.

On the 6th day of this my energy skyrocketed. It was a calm energy. But that night, I couldn't sleep. I took the absolute maximum dose of my rescue medications and they did nothing. By nothing, I mean not only did they fail to make me sleepy, they didn't even dull my mind. I felt totally alert and clear headed despite the rescue medication.

The next day, I was physically fatigued but my mind was still sharp and clear. I tried resting but couldn't feel sleepy. I slept some, then the day after that I had very little sleep and decided to leave the monastery.

Now, I'm back home, taking maximum sleeping pill doses and getting some sleep. I'm hoping this energy is temporary and I'll be able to sleep without pills soon.

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EDIT1 - A friend reminded me that goal directed behavior is a common mania trigger. And **what could be more goal directed than the pursuit of nibbana?**

The day of the first sleepless night, I had insights that lead to me **mistakenly** believe I had attained sotapanna. But after being home I can see the fetters are still there. I still believe the insight was genuine but not deep enough or comprehensive enough to be stream entry.

It is discouraging that I had to leave the monastery early. If I stayed, maybe things would have balanced out and I would have started sleeping normally. But maybe not and I would have gotten very ill.

If goal directed behavior is a trigger, how am I supposed to practice for nibbana and avoid full blown manic episodes?

Sister_Medhini *2026-04-21 18:24:53*

> how am I supposed to avoid a manic episode if I'll have perpetually higher energy

By doing the same thing you were doing - not breaking the precepts, not acting out of the irrational thoughts if they come up.

If lack of sleep and energy spikes come from indulgence in sensuality, then that is what would more likely lead to manic thoughts that drive you to manic behaviour, which is how the whole thing would become a manic episode. Because it's based on a starting point that is already of the same nature. The energy is just a byproduct of the whole state, not what causes it in itself.

So if energy is coming from restraint and patient endurance, you probably don't have to worry about that kind of energy. Even if the manic thoughts were to arise in that context, they would not be automatically driving you to manic behaviour, because the energy is in this case based on a genuine 'strength' of not acting out, no matter the pressure.

But either way, regardless of energy and where it comes from - if you start to lose perspective, it is because you willingly chose to give in at some point. If this were not true, freedom from suffering would not be possible.

So the main thing is to maintain the strength of mind, based on keeping the precepts, which enables you to not act out. Mad thoughts cannot make you mad, only mad actions.

spiffyhandle

Thank you for the detailed reply.

If it's relevant, I added some more context to my original post at the bottom.

It is hopeful to be reminded that there's always the choice of whether to act out or not. I do think there's a biological aspect to bipolar and that even if I don't act out of insanity, I could still become sick and need a long recovery time.

I am uncertain if I would have the strength of virtue to not act out of unwholesome thoughts for days until the energy settles down. While I was clear-headed on the first sleepless night despite extra medication, as the days add up and sleep deprivation increases, my mind would become more muddled and weaker. At least that's how it's happened in the past before I was practicing HH teachings.

Sister_Medhini *2026-04-23 15:33:04*

Regarding the question in the edits:

> If goal directed behavior is a trigger, how am I supposed to practice for nibbana and avoid full blown manic episodes?

There is indeed nothing more goal-directed than practice of Nibbana - no higher goal, and nothing that demands more commitment to it.

So if it is true that goal-directed behaviour (or energy spikes for that matter) leads to manic episodes, then you certainly can't practice for Nibbana.

In fact, for anyone who has any kind of psychiatric illness or disorder, some aspect of the practice for Nibbana will inevitably be a trigger for that illness. Practice for Nibbana is fundamentally incompatible with management of mental illness.

So, either the practice for Nibbana is only accessible to only those who don't have a psychiatric illness - or, the problem and the fuel of the illness is not

actually the trigger; but rather something that you are responsible for in between the trigger and the illness.

(This is certainly not saying the illness is not real; or that it is not biological. It's just that it is included within the mass of dukkha that can be uprooted if the necessary effort is made. If a person is able to understand the suttas and restrain his actions, he is capable of making the necessary effort. Whether one does so or not is up to a oneself.)

You can't have a guarantee about this from the start beyond the Buddha's direct words, but what is sure is that if you aren't willing to take on the genuine risk of facing the triggers sooner or later, you won't be practicing for Nibbana, and you'll never know whether you could have attained it.

Yet, again, even within the reality of such risk, it is worth remembering that no matter how bad or extreme things might become, there would still be containment as long as you do not do the few obvious things that can't happen by accident: lie to yourself, lie to others, kill, steal, take intoxicants or indulge in sensuality.

Edit -to add something that should go without saying and should give reassurance: 'goal-directed behaviour' that is rooted in manic state of mind and results in loss of perspective, is sensual goal-seeking by definition. And as such it is not the Dhamma. Same as energy that comes from calming the mind is different in nature from energy that comes from winding it up.

spiffyhandle

Thank you. Yes and I do think that whether a person with bipolar is pursuing a non-sensual goal (nibbana) or a sensual goal is an important difference.

Is decreased sleep something that naturally happens as part of the practice? If so, is it temporary or something permanent?

I am trying to figure out what pushing through this might look like. I think I could get say 6 hours of sleep a night and be fine on a long-term basis, but it's the acute drop to no sleep at all which concerns me.

Sister_Medhini *2026-04-24 09:56:16*

> Is decreased sleep something that naturally happens as part of the practice? If so, is it temporary or something permanent?

Yes, it can be like a side effect of right restraint and recollectedness. And obviously, like all side effects, it's not in itself significant in the practice, and not something to aim for in itself. Nor is it a problem if someone is still needing more sleep, as long as they are making right effort while they are awake.

> I am trying to figure out what pushing through this might look like. I think I could get say 6 hours of sleep a night and be fine on a long-

> term basis, but it's the acute drop to no sleep at all which concerns me.

I would say for now the priority should be to not be reckless, protect virtue and make the mind used to it and able to sustain it as a baseline. So rather than trying to practice very intensely in extreme seclusion for short term retreats, focus on maintain the precepts throughout your daily life, while having more frequent periods of seclusion on a regular basis.

The former kind of practice involving an extreme determination to 'go for it' is the kind of thing that *can* lead people, even without bipolar, to delude themselves into magical experiences, attainments, neuroticism and forced sleep-deprivation. Again, that's ultimately not because of the seclusion or energy, but because they are working from a desire-driven state of mind.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by nubuda *2026-04-20 09:06:42* ### How do you practice tranquility?

If I understand correctly, Ajahn N. does not consider any kind of relaxing meditation part of dhamma practice. I was listening to one of his dhamma talks and he mentioned that instead of calming meditation, people should instead practice sitting quietly and contemplating certain dhamma topics. This is of course great but it has limitations. There is a sutta (MN19) which clearly explains that there is no danger in skillful thinking but too much of even skillful thinking will tire the body and stress the mind. So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings? My definition of relaxing meditation is very flexible. I believe even sweeping floors or picking berries or laying in bed with resting awareness qualifies as relaxing meditation.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-20 13:48:06*

> So how do you practice tranquility according to Hillside Hermitage teachings?

The first, non-negotiable step is giving up sensuality. Whatever a person who hasn't done this can achieve is not tranquility—the absence of craving—but is merely shifting their substantial mass of craving onto something else (e.g., the sensual bliss obtained in a state of absorption, often mistaken for tranquility).

From then onwards, you progress in the Gradual Training up until you reach the level of purifying your mind from the hindrances, which is done by understanding them as mental activities that are harmful, not by any attentional technique or focusing effort whatsoever.

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Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-21 04:56:26*

The pleasure that comes from what is generally mistaken as samādhi today. Pleasure that comes from engagement with a sense object rather than from withdrawal.

nubuda *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Yes, no question about sensuality. But how do you spend your days after giving up sensuality? For example, have read about monks who followed 8 precepts but had no samadhi cause they were so worried about perfecting their precepts. Just like the sutta I referenced says, too much thinking of dhamma topics can cause stress despite it being skillful thoughts. So what is your practice for taking a break from thoughts or least reducing thoughts?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-21 05:15:37*

> Just like the sutta I referenced says, too much thinking of dhamma topics can cause stress despite it being skillful thoughts.

It doesn't say that you simply decide to engage in a calming practice out of a view that skillful thoughts are tiresome. You develop the skillful thoughts until those have become the mind's natural inclination and unwholesome thoughts have subsided.

If that's actually completed, you won't need a special practice to calm yourself down. You removed the greatest source of disturbance by undoing the unwholesome thoughts, and now with the wholesome thoughts, recognizing that the subtle burden they entail is no longer necessary will be enough for the mind to become internally calm (meaning it's preoccupied with neither wholesome nor unwholesome thoughts).

Whereas before that point, you only have two options apart from the wholesome thoughts: the blatant unwholesome thoughts, and distractions such as "relaxing meditation." Both are stressful compared to actual samādhi, where you don't have to do anything at all in order to be calm.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Sa_Mahe_ri *2026-04-10 13:02:08* ### Question regarding interpretation and application of Pātimokkha rules

Dear Venerables,

I am a sāmaṇerī in training to become a bhikkhunī. I would very much welcome input not only from the monks who have already undertaken higher ordination or are going to in the future, but also from nuns who have not—since I imagine that you have reflected on these questions as well.

I find myself struggling to understand how to relate properly to my future Pātimokkha rules—especially those that are not/ no longer directly connected to unwholesome behavior, and where the interpretation is not clear-cut.

The most obvious rule that is difficult for a modern bhikkhunī is Saṅghādisesa 3:

> If a nun walks to the next inhabited area by herself (Bhante Brahmali) / goes among villages alone (Ajahn Thanissaro), or crosses a river by herself, or spends the night apart by herself, or lags behind her companions by herself, then that nun has committed an immediate offense entailing formal probation and suspension.
> Yā pana bhikkhunī ekā vā gāmantaraṁ gaccheyya, ekā vā nadīpāraṁ gaccheyya, ekā vā rattiṁ vippavaseyya, ekā vā gaṇamhā ohiyeyya, ayampi bhikkhunī paṭhamāpattikaṁ dhammaṁ āpannā nissāraṇīyaṁ saṅghādisesaṁ.

This is especially challenging because it is a serious offense. Interpretations of what exactly is prohibited and what is allowed vary greatly, and when I reflect on how I might interpret this rule for myself (as I have considerable freedom in this regard in my monastery), I cannot come to a clear conclusion.

So I am not necessarily looking for a definitive answer on how to interpret this specific rule (but if you have any thoughts on that, please go ahead). Rather, I would appreciate any guidance on how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

At the same time, I would also welcome input from those familiar with Pāli regarding which translation is more accurate. One version seems to suggest that I could still spend the day in seclusion in the forest, as long as I am not intending to travel to another village (which would align with suttas depicting bhikkhunīs being alone in the forest). The other interpretation, however, sounds more like one is not allowed to leave one's village by oneself at all.

And regarding precepts that are not necessarily unwholesome in themselves, but are nowadays commonly interpreted in a different way than the literal wording suggests—does one simply go along with such established interpretations, or is there a more principled way to approach them?

> For example:
> Confession 85: traveling in a vehicle (for bhikkhunīs, in contrast to bhikkhus, in the Pātimokkha)
> If a nun who is not ill travels in a vehicle, she commits an offense entailing confession.
>
> According to Ajahn Thanissaro:
> "In modern times, 'ill' is interpreted here as meaning too weak to reach one's destination on foot within the available time."

Any further reflections on how to put the Pātimokkha rules into practice are very welcome.

With respectful regards,
Sāmaṇerī Mahesī

Sister_Medhini *2026-04-12 14:24:42*

My comments were along very similar lines with Venerable Anīgha's, so I will just add a couple further notes especially on Saṅghadisesa 3.

> I would appreciate any guidance on how to approach rules that are not entirely clear or that allow for multiple interpretations—how one might arrive at a well-grounded decision in such cases.

The right approach should be based on understanding that the principle of the whole vinaya is about prohibiting actions that are done with unwholesome intent - or that, through lack of foresight, give rise to problems for not only oneself but the whole saṅgha.

Many of the rules that are not so obviously or universally related to sensuality or ill-will come through a context (which is still relevant now but easy to overlook) where, as a bhikkhu or bhikkhuni, one's actions are never truly private, but reflect on, and carry consequences for, an entire community.

So, for example, in the case of Saṅghādisesa 3, I would say that the general point is about carelessly exposing yourself to obvious danger or risk - of rape, mainly, in the case of this rule. Which is something that, if it were to occur, would have potentially huge long-term consequences for all, and thus warrants taking very seriously. Hence it is a serious offence.

I think the list "walking to the next village alone," "crossing a river alone" "spending the night alone" are the main *examples* of such type of obviously heedless behaviour within the context in which the rule came about, not a definitive list of what counts as risky. So they need to be understood in that sense. It then doesn't make sense that, say, spending the night in a kuti near a monastery would be a problem - on the other hand, staying in an open cave near a village in Sri Lanka definitely would. So would walking alone in a city at night.

Gāmantara literally means 'between villages'. I think this can be taken to mean broadly 'walking alone on a road [where one is at risk]'.

(The part of this rule that doesn't make much sense to me is 'lagging behind companions'. At least half of the parallel versions in the different schools don't have it.)

The origin stories of the bhikkhunis' rules are, in my memory, less of a reliable guide than those of the bhikkhus. They apparently diverge greatly between traditions, often sound strange and can sometimes add more confusion than clarification. Nevertheless they can help to give context if the rule itself is very ambiguous.

In practice, interpretations need to be generally agreed upon by a community. You should of course try and come to your own understanding of the meaning of the rules for your own sake - but realising that it might not be possible or worthwhile to try and convince others around of that, especially given the lack of a unifying view of the practice within most monastic communities these days. (Also see this passage). At least in the case of the more circumstantial rules, it's fine to go along with the way the community follows them, as long as you yourself do not lose perspective through that. (It is much easier to redefine what 'ill' means and then feel absolved of anything and everything, than it is to question a preference of travelling first class as a monastic.)

I am not pursuing bhikkhuni ordination, and do not plan to. This is not because of the rules, but simply because I do not see any need or purpose for it beyond my current circumstances.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by spiffyhandle *2026-04-08 11:50:42 ###* Clarification of "no high and luxurious beds" precept?

Is the 8th precept only about what I deliberately use for sleeping at night and deliberate naps during the day? Or would it also prohibit using comfortable couches and recliners during the day? Would it prohibit laying awake on a high or luxurious bed but NOT sleeping on it?

I don't understand the intent of the precept so I can't gauge its particulars. I've looked at references to sleep in the vinaya and suttas and I'm not discerning a universal principle.

I looked in the virtue wiki and all I saw was

> "If the seven precepts are your default, then on Uposatha days you would up the ante and keep the full eight precepts. This would add not sleeping on a high and comfortable bed and not eating past noon."

In the talks to lay people the Buddha says you observe the 8 precepts because you're emulating an arahant.

> As long as they live, the perfected ones give up high and luxurious beds. They sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I, too, for this day and night will give up high and luxurious beds. I'll sleep in a low place, either a cot or a straw mat. I will observe the sabbath by doing as the perfected ones do in this respect.'

The Vinaya, which goes beyond practice and takes into account social norms and maintaining good relationships with lay people, it prohibits having beds that with legs that are too high and also stuffed benches and couches. The connection between a height of a bed and it's comfort makes no sense to me.

If you had a plain bunk bed are you automatically breaking the precept just because it's tall? What does that have to do with dhamma?

https://suttacentral.net/pli-tv-bu-vb-pc87/en/brahmali?lang=en&layout=plain&reference

https://suttacentral.net/pli-tv-bu-vb-pc88/en/brahmali?lang=en&layout=plain&reference

> 'If a monk has a bed or a bench made upholstered with cotton down,
> it is to be stripped, and he commits an offense entailing confession.'"

So perhaps there is something about not possessing comfortable furniture, in general that is problematic? I am unsure.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-11 05:27:33*

It's about not using furniture that is very likely to be misused. Namely, for indulging in the pleasure of lying down and giving in to mental laziness rather than resting the body when needed.

Secondarily, it's about avoiding ostentatiousness, which is another way of losing the context of what a bed/furniture is for.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by baubleballs *2026-04-06 19:07:09* ### Building the foundations

hello. Stated simply, this is a question about whether seclusion is counterproductive without a strong foundation in virtue.

Looking back, I'm realizing I've neglected virtue during my last several months of lay practice in a secluded environment. I periodically make and lose progress. The daily meal is very brief and the time alone feels overwhelming. After time progressing or creating tension, I will sometimes do things as coarse on the level of the precepts, like: taking allowables only when others aren't around—in a way a fourth precept breach; tracking calories out of concern for my appearance—beautification breach; and so on.

The stress came to the point a while ago where I increasingly took sensual bait to the point of giving up and breaking several precepts. They were my (series of) choices. I confessed online but didn't tell others. I have recovered and been transparent since. I was pardoned and, for the first time since I arrived, I feel calm. I'm still stressed, because my daily gratification is limited to the meal, but I am not breaking precepts. Still, I am often tempted. I am not "steady".

The progress I did make in renunciation, I think, was not pleasurable or stable because it was not based on a steady moral character. I wonder if my difficulties have been owed to not having developed much in lay life. I came here without much experience in keeping the 8 precepts. In fact, I even occasionally broke the 5 at home. As a result, it feels like practice here has been

mostly painfully giving up everything with periods of indulgence.

It strikes me that while understanding can be genuine, consistently aligning one's choices with it is not easy. Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true training in making good choices? Is the latter more important? Can I not rely on my understanding to do the work for me? Should virtue, by willpower, come first?

I have a sincere sense of urgency and desire to practice but feel disoriented by my own struggles and inauthenticity in weathering the turbulence of this new lifestyle. Right now, for example, the urgency is apparent, but this isn't the first time.

I believed my breaches were overly problematic to stay, so I planned to leave, recover, and dedicate some time at home to truly becoming a virtuous person for the first time in my life. Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, "easier" secluded environment after a while.

However, when I opened up, some monks urged me to stay. I now feel at ease rather than remorseful. I'm determined to make the best choice rather than the most appealing one. As I currently conceive my situation, I have considered: a. remaining in an austere environment, striving to perfect my virtue, while not focusing on anything beyond that—bearing the solitude, hunger, and so on, or b. going home, relaxing, and focusing on committing to the precepts in an easier environment, in preparation for eventually leaving home again. I am leaning towards b. Now that I have tasted the relief of virtue, it would seem simpler to solidify it at my own pace. But I could push, and give it my all, I suppose. The only things holding me back are my own choices. Any input is appreciated. Thank you Bhantes and fellow renunciates.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-08 06:22:15*

> Danger frequently and personally becomes apparent to me, but my actions revert to worldliness. Are these two different things—understanding and true training in making good choices? I

They are not different. If it doesn't change one's choices, it is not understanding yet. It hasn't "sunk in."

> Having tasted the pleasure of renunciation, I wanted to be a lay person for a while, living alone, working a job, and practicing aloofness in regards to worldly pleasures, before going to another, "easier" secluded environment after a while.

That's not a bad outcome if it actually turns out that way, but you want to honestly reflect on why going back is more appealing. People who return home

after living in a monastery very rarely uphold the same standards afterwards, despite convincing themselves that they would.

Perhaps the solitude and hunger are in themselves so bad that the mind is perfectly happy with abandoning just that and otherwise continuing the training unchanged. But more often than not, that choice is more appealing because although one will still be committed to the precepts on paper, accountability for breaking them will be significantly lower, and *that* is felt as relief. There could even be a concealed expectation of a quick "top up" of sensual indulgence before you take the precepts seriously again.

If the latter is the reason, then the mind is trying to seduce you into giving up the training and not just the austere environment—which you are of course free to do, but you'd better be honest to yourself about it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by No_Fishing_3019 *2026-04-06 18:12:14*
Intrusive thoughts

This is just a short practice question and probably doesn't deserve its own thread, but I didn't know where else to put it.

Say I have a desire to go on bike rides with a romantic partner, but I can't do that because I don't have a romantic partner, so that frustrated desire will present as aversion. At random times during the day, a thought like "I can't go on bike rides with a romantic partner" will come up, which is then immediately followed up by a feeling of aversion, and will soon be followed up by other related thoughts that will generate more aversion or desire, if I don't consciously intervene. My reaction may go like this:

I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Is that the right way to react?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-08 06:00:23*

> I notice that this thought is predicated on craving and will lead to further craving, so I stop myself from engaging with it. This basically amounts to forcefully cutting it off, because the citta really wants me to think that thought right now. When the thought is gone, I notice the aversion that the thought generated and make sure not to resist it. I stay peripherally aware of that aversion until it is gone.

Indeed. That's how you remove the fuel for the aversion, and it eventually subsides.

What you don't want to be "cutting off" is the underlying discomfort due to which the mind wants to think aversive thoughts (or any unwholesome thought). That's where people often go wrong, and it's essentially trying to stop Māra from presenting baits instead of holding the mind back from engaging with them.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by LessNeighborhood1257 *2026-04-06 04:21:04* ### The Ultimate Choice

Thank you in advance for your generosity in addressing this question, and forgive me for its length, but I feel it deserves special care in order to properly give you insight into the reflections of my mind. I am going to try to be as truthful as I can in my writing, so you can use your own wisdom to see any pitfalls I'm wandering into with my thinking. In this way, I hope to learn something from you and fill the glass of wisdom drop by drop.

Dear Hillside Hermitage,

You've said before that the essence of the dhamma is choice, that we have the power to shape our thoughts, speech, and actions. With this in mind, the following question naturally arises: how should we exercise the power of our autonomy for our greatest benefit? As we look into the processes of our mind, we find that we're pressured towards the sights, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and ideas of the world. But why are we pressured towards these things, and why do we find ourselves chasing after them? We wouldn't be seeking these things if, one, they didn't provide some amount of relief and, two, we weren't experiencing a fundamental lack in our experience. But do these worldly things really provide true happiness, a happiness that doesn't age, grow sick, and die? If they did, we wouldn't have to keep chasing after them; we'd already be fulfilled on account of obtaining their pleasure. I'll call upon a simile to illustrate this further. We all start out on express trains in this life. Perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal career that we think will make us fulfilled, whereupon its completion, we will be satisfied that we've made our mark on the world. Or perhaps it's the train headed towards the ideal partner that we think will fill the emotional lack we feel within ourselves. Then we get all excited and hop from train to train looking for the next big thing. Reflecting on the drawbacks of these behaviors, another question arises: is it worth it? And is there something more worthwhile to spend my time doing? These are the questions that you and the Buddha asked yourselves, and they're the very same questions I'm contemplating myself. As human beings with limited lifespans, it's impossible to not make choices in life. In fact, we make choices every second. And so, given the weight our choices have in shaping our lives, another question arises: what makes a good choice? As you've said before,

this is the question that lies at the heart of wisdom. What, when I do it, will lead to my long-term welfare and happiness? I have seen how choices motivated by greed, hatred, worry and flurry, indolence, and anxious doubt have led to negative results. And I've seen how choices motivated by generosity, virtue, renunciation, wisdom, effort, endurance, truth, determination, goodwill, and equanimity have led to positive results. Having seen this for myself, I realize that the best way to spend my time in this life is to search for a happiness that doesn't age, doesn't grow ill, and doesn't die. However, in order to completely devote myself to this goal, the householder's life won't suffice. Using your simile, it's like a flower trying to grow through the cracks in the sidewalks of New York. With two years left of my college career, I have to make a choice. I can either wait to become a monk, finish my college education, and go forth. Or, I can drop everything like the Buddha did and start now. As the suttas remind us, for who knows? Tomorrow: death. There is no bargaining with death and his mighty horde. In other words, it's not realistic to rely on the perception that I'll be alive in two years to go forth. The Buddha asks us to be heedful in our reflections on death. In AN 6.19, the Maranassati Sutta, we see this most clearly:

" … When this was said, the Blessed One addressed the monks. "Whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for a day & night… for a day… for the interval that it takes to eat a meal… for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up four morsels of food, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedlessly. They develop mindfulness of death slowly for the sake of ending the effluents.
"But whoever develops mindfulness of death, thinking, 'O, that I might live for the interval that it takes to swallow having chewed up one morsel of food… for the interval that it takes to breathe out after breathing in, or to breathe in after breathing out, that I might attend to the Blessed One's instructions. I would have accomplished a great deal' — they are said to dwell heedfully. They develop mindfulness of death acutely for the sake of ending the effluents.

If my understanding is true, from the Buddha's point of view, the best choice is renunciation. That trading a lesser happiness for a greater happiness is a noble trade. However, I feel conflicted about this choice, and after some intense probing, I realize that the difficulty in this decision lies not in giving up the pursuit of the degree, but in how my family and relatives will respond to my decision. I know I will not use this degree to get a job, for if I graduate, my job will be to seek true happiness. So, the choice here is not about renouncing the degree but about renouncing the need to be understood and renouncing the fear of disappointing others. This means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation. Am I contemplating this in the right way? That even if I do live to be ordained two years from now, I'd still have to perfect the quality of renunciation, and in making the choice to wait to be ordained, I'll have sown the seed of being

liable to what others think of me. On the other hand, I am not one who abandons pursuits lightly, and I recognize the value of education and its benefits for our understanding of the world. If I wait to be ordained, I can still practice at Metta Forest Monastery on the weekends, giving me the best of both worlds while I wait to go forth. But isn't this a heedless thought? If I were to be diagnosed with a terminal illness tomorrow and told that I had a year left to live, the choice would be clear. If my relatives and family were all gone, I'd drop everything and ordain. So it seems that the root of all of this indecision is a fear of disappointing my family and relatives. Ultimately, only I can make this decision, so my purpose in writing this letter is not to ask you to make it for me, but to gain your perspective on my mind's contemplations. Thank you once again, and may you be well.

— Alex

P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-06 13:22:52*

> This means that if I choose to delay my ordination, I'll have missed out on an opportunity to perfect renunciation.

Yes, but beyond that, the idea that finishing the degree will make a meaningful difference is false. Whenever you abandon the world, the reaction of people close to you will be the same, the displeasure will be the same, and the mind's fear in regard to it will be the same—and likely greater if you wait, since you give in to that fear and thus fuel it.

So, the real question is whether you would stick to your determination to leave the world, and use that renunciation to practice rightly no matter how unpleasant that turns out to be. And it will be at least as unpleasant as the disappointment you fear. The extent of the internal problem you carry is evidently that much at least.

If you're not entirely sure that you will stick to both of those, then it's better to wait and do your best with your current circumstances. Not because of anything related to the degree, but because it can be a major setback if you end up returning home. The mind develops a "been there, done that" attitude towards going forth that makes it much harder to take it on sincerely again.

> P.S. Does samanadipa hermitage or hillside hermitage still ordain monks?

Both places are operating at full capacity in terms of permanent residents for the foreseeable future.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by NoArm_Boss2627 *2026-04-05 23:07:47*
"Or the memory that 'feeling is there' is established…"

I have a question in regards to the Sattipatthana sutta. Particularly the line:

“Or the memory that ‘feeling is there’ is established for him just to the extent necessary for knowledge and recollectedness. He abides disengaged, not taking up anything in the world.”

I can understand how contemplating ‘feelings within feelings’ and the ‘factors of origination’ relates to yoniso manisakara, but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation. I do my best just to keep a general awareness of the feeling-tone that is underlying my experience without becoming absorbed into it, and just dwell on that.

I simply note my general state of feeling, either pleasant, unpleasant or neutral. In doing so, I notice how these feelings are (A) conditioned, since I had no choice in their making, and hence (B)impermanent and not ‘for me’ . Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keeping that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there? (For example, as I’m walking, I simply discern that there is unpleasant feeling present as a context for my experience)

Can I do the same thing with moods, just note whichever mood is present, discern it as the basis or womb for experience,and dwell on that fact alone (discern that the ‘mind is just there…’)?

Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

I understand those things to be the factors of origination.

Though I imagine there’s a good reason that final line in the sutta is included just as it is for the other three factors of mindfulness.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-08 05:51:05*

> but simply discerning that feelings are there seems like it can be conflated with the direct observation-(ayoniso) type meditation.

… If one has from the start misunderstood what feelings even are. Actual feelings structurally cannot be “observed” like that at all.

> Would that constitute a correct form of yoniso manisakara, discerning that my feeling state is just there, primordial, and conditioned, and keeping that knowledge in my background awareness as I focus directly on the feelings that are there?

Yes, but there is no need to intentionally “focus directly” on anything. When you discern feelings where they are, that perspective naturally carries over into whatever comes up on its own.

> Or must I always be contemplating the basis for feelings/moods such as contact, perception, etc?

Not always. Seeing a feeling as an arisen experience (not leaving it festering in the background unnoticed) is ideally enough for the mind to cease its engagements within it. You contemplate further only if that's not enough for disengagement to occur.

NoArm_Boss2627

> Actual feelings structurally cannot be "observed" like that at all.

Why is that the case? Can't there be the felt sense that I am the observer sitting behind feelings? Isn't it possible to view feelings with the felt sense that 'I am the one who feels', or must the correct discernment that feeling is there always be seen peripherally?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-14 05:23:19*

Whatever an act of observation applies to is an object in the world, not a feeling. Feeling endures *in regard to* such an act, and it has to be ignored in order to be with the content of the observation.

The same goes for all the aggregates. They cannot be observed because they are the background of observation (and of any action).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Sa_Mahe_ri *2026-04-03 08:32:40* ### Questions on Sleep and fine Food as Obstacles in Practice

If I understand it correctly, it is not recommended by the Venerables to set or reduce one's sleep to a fixed amount—at least not for the initial stages of the gradual training.

But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

> "But those mendicants who were junior, recently gone forth, newly come to this teaching and training slept until the sun came up, snoring. The Buddha saw them doing this, with his clairvoyance that is purified and superhuman. He went to the assembly hall, sat down on the seat spread out, and addressed the mendicants:
> "Mendicants, where is Sāriputta? Where are Mahāmoggallāna, Mahākassapa, Mahākaccāna, Mahākoṭṭhita, Mahācunda, Mahākappina, Anuruddha, Revata, and Ānanda? Where have these senior disciples gone?" "Soon after the Buddha left, those venerables each went to their own dwelling."
> "So, mendicants, when the senior mendicants left, why did you sleep until the sun came up, snoring? What do you think, mendicants? Have you ever seen or heard of an anointed aristocratic king

> who rules his whole life, dear and beloved to the country, while indulging in the pleasures of sleeping, lying down, and drowsing as much as he likes?"

I think it has something to do with the wording of the last quoted sentence, but at the same time the criticism itself doesn't seem to directly refer to sleeping without being tired, or to waking up and then deciding out of laziness to go back to sleep. But more in line of "you are wasting your time".

___

And I have another question about food and MN 7:

> When a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him. Compare this with cloth that is soiled and stained; it can be made pure and clean by pure water. Or with unrefined gold, which can be made pure and bright by a forge. In the same way, when a bhikkhu of such virtue, such qualities, and such understanding eats boiled fine rice with the dark grains removed and served with many soups and sauces, that is no obstacle for him.

I have often stumbled over this phrasing, because in my understanding it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine food. Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such? Especially in light of the fact that the daily food served at my monastery today is probably closer to what kings ate back then than to the food one would have received on alms round in those times.

I'd be grateful for guidance on how to understand this in practice.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-05 04:38:20*

> But how, in that case, should AN 6.17 be understood, where the Buddha criticizes junior monks for excessive sleeping?

Indulgence in sleep is a deliberate action that you simply abstain from, so if you feel the need to impose an external limit to prevent such indulgence, it's because you don't see what the work even is (and will most likely start indulging in however little sleep you get).

> it suggests that for someone who has not yet reached this level of virtue, it very well can more easily become an obstacle to consume such fine food.

Yes, because they could be eating such food with an indulgent *intention.* Not

because the food will accidentally obstruct them despite the lack of such intentions.

> Would it accordingly be recommended, as a precaution to not agitate the mind, to choose—whenever possible—simpler food over more delicious options, even when the latter are not sought for their taste as such?

Definitely not. Inclining towards such a precaution implies a fundamental misunderstanding of what the mind is (namely, intention). Same as with sleep, due to tackling the problem at the wrong place, your actual mind will likely start indulging in the "simple" food you limited it to.

Sa_Mahe_ri

> Indulgence in sleep is a deliberate action that you simply abstain from, so if you feel the need to impose an external limit to prevent such indulgence, it's because you don't see what the work even is (and will most likely start indulging in however little sleep you get).

So that they slept until the sun came up, snoring can be simply seen as an byproduct of their intention to indulge in sleep when they went to sleep, but

> "while indulging in the pleasures of sleeping, lying down, and drowsing ~~as much as he likes~~ -Bhante Sujato

"~~if he spends as much time as he wants~~ yielding to the pleasure of rest, the pleasure of sloth, the pleasure of sleep" -Bhikkhu Bodhi

Is the defining factor?

I've also just noticed that Ven. Nyanatilokas translation does not contain the same time factor "as much as likes" / "as much time as he wants". So there might be some translation error as well, which I can't figure out myself.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-05 07:23:37*

> So that they slept until the sun came up, snoring can be simply seen as an byproduct of their intention to indulge in sleep when they went to sleep

Yes. Neither of those things are themselves intentional.

> So there might be some translation error as well, which I can't figure out myself.

The Pāli does contain the expression *yāvadatthaṁ,* i.e., "as much as one wants." And *seyyasukhaṁ passasukhaṁ middhasukhaṁ anuyutto viharanto* means "dwelling *dedicated to* the pleasure of sleeping, lying down and drowsing."

When getting that pleasure is one's intention for sleeping, the action is indulgent no matter the duration of one's sleep. And the reverse when that is not the intention.

Intrepid_Volume_3261 *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

I have been eating a diet mostly consisting of oatmeal for the specific purpose of sense restraint. This diet has seemed to be of enormous help, as the comparative blandness of plain oatmeal to almost any other food has forced my mind to reckon with the absence of the most consistent sense-pleasure I had enjoyed before becoming serious about my practice.

> Inclining towards such a precaution implies a fundamental misunderstanding of what the mind is (namely, intention).

My understanding is that of the utmost beginner, and reading this gives me great pause because every internal cue I have received from practicing this diet has indicated to me that it was leading me down the proper path. I will attempt to explain my confusion. I do grasp (in a mundane way no doubt) that intention is the decisive factor in determining whether someone is properly practicing sense-restraint. To use sleep as an example, a puthujjana like me can find a way to delight and indulge in 5 hours of sleep, while someone of high attainment can sleep for 10 hours without indulging in the slightest.

But isn't the whole idea of sense-restraint that it is easier to develop the proper intention in regard to sensuality when things which make the untrained mind liable to indulge are restricted? In other words, I fail to see why the following would not be equivalent in terms of sense-restraint (not in degree, of course, but in kind):

sex vs. celibacy

delicious food vs. bland food

(i am supposing there is choice involved between the two food options, so this would only apply to lay life)

According to my (very puthujjana) understanding, sex is prohibited not because it is *necessarily* impossible to engage in it without grasping and delight, but because no untrained mind could accomplish this *practically*. In a similar way, no doubt as a result of my mind's lack of conditioning, I find it impossible to eat, for instance, a grilled cheese sandwich without delighting in it and craving fatty food for days, but experience a fraction of this sensual delight in my oatmeal.

In addition, a certain part of my mind would be overjoyed to learn that a bhikku gave me the go-ahead to go back to eating rich food. It feels like the same part that would search for any excuse to get high when I used to abuse drugs.

I would be grateful for any clarification you are able to provide, Bhante.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-14 07:19:23*

> But isn't the whole idea of sense-restraint that it is easier to develop the proper intention in regard to sensuality when things which make the untrained mind liable to indulge are restricted?

Not quite. It's a widespread misunderstanding that sense restraint means preventing yourself from perceiving this or that.

If you read the Suttas carefully, you see that sense restraint is always described in terms of what you don't do (on the mental level) *when* you perceive something. In this case, it's what you wouldn't do when eating even the most agreeable food so that the mind is not polluted.

Now, this obviously doesn't mean that you can eat whatever you crave for and then just practice sense restraint.

Sense restraint is preceded by establishment in virtue. Virtue in this context means that when the very act of eating something is infected with craving, you won't be eating it to begin with.

> According to my (very puthujjana) understanding, sex is prohibited not because it is necessarily impossible to engage in it without grasping and delight, but because no untrained mind could accomplish this practically

Nor would a trained mind. It is necessarily impossible to engage in sexual intercourse (to initiate it or consent to it) without grasping and delight. Hence celibacy is a fixed part of virtue.

> no doubt as a result of my mind's lack of conditioning, I find it impossible to eat, for instance, a grilled cheese sandwich without delighting in it and craving fatty food for days, but experience a fraction of this sensual delight in my oatmeal.

Right, so the problem is that craving, not the sandwiches. Conversely, the solution is to *abstain* from eating out of craving—which may or may not include abstaining from the sandwiches depending on the current state of the mind—rather than to perform the duty of only eating oatmeal.

Without a doubt, at any given time there will be foods apart from oatmeal that your mind does not crave for. By bundling it all into "oatmeal and the rest," you avoid the work of discerning what sensuality actually is, namely your *passionate intention* that is totally independent from the agreeability of things.

It's a less extreme form of the misguided practices of other ascetics mentioned in the Suttas, like eating only herbs and always being naked, so as to get around the need to see the current state of their mind and make choices based

on that. Even if lustful states are factually avoided that way, wrong view and lack of clarity are directly fueled, and that is worse.

Intrepid_Volume_3261

Thank you for the reply, Bhante.

> Without a doubt, at any given time there will be foods apart from oatmeal that your mind does not crave for.

I have certainly found this to be the case for vegetables, which I eat, but not in regard to richer foods. As an exercise, if I envision myself eating meat, cheese, anything cooked in oil, or even nuts, an uncomfortable quality immediately taints the thought which is identical to the feeling of being pulled into a fantasy based on doubt or lust. I don't know if this was the case prior to starting the diet, but I seem to be in a situation where anything richer than whole grains elicits great craving.

I also find myself unable to avoid craving and delighting in the bland foods that I do eat, but the magnitude of this craving and delight is far lesser and more manageable than what I have experienced on the occasion that I eat something richer.

> Virtue in this context means that when the very act of eating something is infected with craving, you won't be eating it to begin with.

My thought process for practicing such a restrictive diet is that if any calorically-substantial food I eat is going to elicit some degree of craving, I ought to select foods that do so to the least possible extent without depriving myself nutritionally. If I'm struggling to resolve my tendency to grasp at the perceptions of plain oatmeal or quinoa, I do not understand why it would be advisable for me to allow myself anything richer.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-15 12:31:24*

If your mind is obsessively pulling you towards certain foods—meaning you see the threat of losing perspective and not being able to stop even before you begin—then you should definitely not go along with that pull.

Still, the particulars of a given food, be it richness or anything else, are completely irrelevant. The mind craves a certain food when it craves it, not when it's rich or light, and thus the state of the mind has to be the sole criterion.

Not seeing that is enough to set the whole effort in the wrong direction internally, despite externally abstaining from the same things as you would with the right perspective.

> even nuts, an uncomfortable quality immediately taints the thought which is identical to the feeling of being pulled into a fantasy based on doubt or lust

Also, some skepticism about that reaction is warranted because indeed, it could be the result of the diet itself. I wouldn't recommend ignoring the reaction and eating the food anyway, but don't take for granted that you will always have an issue with those foods.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by tejveeer *2026-04-01 18:23:51* ### An attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy

Due to some things that happened this week, I broke restraint with respect to social media, so I thought I may as well post this and then go back to restraint.

A few weeks ago, in order to substitute coarse entertainment with finer entertainment, I thought to clarify the debates around HH's position on celibacy and sotapatti. I've written and uploaded my understanding of the debate here, in case it is of use to others.

> My aim in this post is to attempt to clarify HH's stance on the relationship between sotapatti and celibacy. In a previous article, HH posited that sotapatti requires celibacy, but were faced with multiple objections from others. I believe that the majority, if not all, of those objections were not well founded because they didn't understand the exact relationship that exists between sotapatti and (non-)celibacy for HH. As a result, the objections targetted positions that did not address their central claim. In writing this post, I wish to introduce exactness to that relationship.
>
> In order to do so, I will begin by examining goals and what kinds of acts exist in the pursuit of goals. After having developed two goal-act taxonomies, I will apply them to the relationship between celibacy and the goal of sotapatti. This will allow me to express what I take to be HH's position in three claims. I will then present an analogy in an attempt to further clarify the sense of those three claims. After doing so, I'll address common objections to HH's initial position and argue that they don't address HH's claims. Lastly, I will present a summary of the three claims by unwrapping the special terms used therein and framing them in more contemporary expressions.
>
> As a side note, it's worth mentioning that I'm currently restraining myself from using youtube, reddit, and suttacentral as part of my larger restraint from entertainment. Because of this, I will not be able to offer sources of claims and objections and will instead have to rely on memory. This does not contract much from the overall post, however, since the central objective here is just to help me make sense of HH's position.

Would be interested to hear any critiques on this.

It's worth noting that this is currently just the first draft. A lot of the wording here is quite awkward and was fixed in the Appendix. In the second objection, I also realized that to properly present it, I would've had to introduced things that I didn't have the time to introduce, as such it remains incomplete. Do note that this post is not concerned with *justifying* their position; only *clarifying it*, and in part showing that the objections I commonly saw failed to see the central point.

I had presented this to Ven. Anigha privately on discord, and bhante stated that it was correct for the most part. There was apparently an issue that existed with a noncentral part of the post, but I no longer recall what that issue was that bhante stated - I cannot currently go on discord as I've disabled my accounts for the week.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-02 16:36:17*

The point can be expressed much more concisely: if your practice does not include celibacy, then either your view of the practice is wrong (i.e., it is not geared towards purifying your mind from craving), or your commitment to practicing along the right lines is still underdeveloped (lack of a sense of urgency). Both of these are obvious obstructions to stream entry.

For a *sotāpanna* the former is not possible, but the latter will still stop them from making further progress.

tejveeer

Hello bhante, it's worth clarifying who the intended audience was for this writing. They were people like myself who require a large degree of justification of the stated claims before actually being in a position where they can be adopted.

From my investigations, it seems everyone requires some form of justification for a claim before the option to assent to the claim becomes apparent. What form of justification that is, and the extent that is required, appears to differ based on individuals. For some, simply the perception that 'this individual is confident in making this claim' is a sufficient justification for assent to become available, whereas for others that doesn't necessarily have to be the case. They might be convinced on account of empirical evidence of the claim, or that claim coming from a reputable institution, or that claim being grounded in a text they revere, etc.

So we could distinguish between two kinds of individuals: (a) one for whom assent becomes available upon the perception of confidence; (b) one for whom assent becomes available upon investigation of what is stated. For the sake of reference, a person who falls into (a) I can call *confidence-oriented*, and into (b) I can call *investigation-oriented*.

In my case, I was targetting investigation-oriented people from an anglophone background where there appears to be a lot of emphasis on dissecting minute aspects of claims, the premises from which they were deduced, and the justification of those premises themselves. For instance, someone from this background may identify the claims made in your comment as follows:

1. If your practice does not include celibacy, then your view of the practice is wrong
2. If your practice does not include celibacy, then your commitment to practicing along the right lines is still underdeveloped
3. Wrong view and underdeveloped commitment are obvious obstructions to stream-entry

Their line of reasoning may proceed as follows. What is meant by 'celibacy' exactly? What is meant by a practice being 'wrong'? What are the grounds for the implication? In response to the first and second question, they may proceed to ask: 'why does celibacy/wrongness have to mean what you take it to mean?' And to the third, if suttas are cited, they may ask (a) how that sutta is interpreted; (b) why it's interpreted that way; (c) whether you're justified in interpreting it that way; (d) whether that interpretation actually supports the claim.

This is just for the first claim. They may then proceed through all three claims and see that no such minute considerations have been taken into account and that therefore the author in question is just overconfident, dogmatic, and fundamentalist.

HH's interaction on youtube and reddit have been with investigation-oriented people likely from an anglophone background, but the way HH presents their views are actually appropriate only for confidence-oriented people. This is because HH makes no attempt at any rigorous justification.

I would distinguish between the following kinds of claims that HH makes:

1. Bare claims: no justification is provided for these
2. Justified claims: justification is provided for these; within these we have:
    1. Claims justified through suttas (sutta-justified claims)
    2. Claims justified through intuition (intuition-justified claims)

I would not be surprised if about 70% of the claims HH makes now are bare claims and the rest are justified or some other kind. Within the justified claims, when HH does make sutta-justified claims, no attempt is made to actually connect the claim (that 'the sutta means X') with the sutta cited as a justification for X; all that's presented is (a) the claim *that* 'the sutta means X' and then (b) a copy of the sutta that supposedly justifies X.

What a lot of the anglophone investigation-oriented people would be looking for, from what I see, are claims justified through suttas *deductively,* with considerations of the anatomy of the claims, and with a consideration of interpre-

tative methodology (how should a text be read such that the meaning intended by the author is actually arrived at?). All are absent in HH.

When this is combined with claims that go against the mainstream tradition and are often framed in a way that shocks the reader, it seems this subset of people simply stop taking the whole of HH seriously (see the consensus on suttacentral and this post). My aim in writing the post was in part to present the same position in a manner that would seem more plausible to this audience.

Provisionally, I may distinguish between two periods of HH: the current Slovenian period, and previous Sri Lankan period. There appear to be genuine differences between the two.

In the Sri Lankan period, Ajahn Nyanamoli put a significant emphasis on referential precision & justification. Ajahn would investigate what the references of a lot of words were, and what their characteristics were. Then claims involving words with those references were intuitively-justified often with deductive reasoning involved. Those claims were intuitied based on an aspect of experience itself.

The Slovenian period is marked instead by a pragmatic attitude which is embodied through the use of metaphors (for the citta primarily) and very little drawn-out emphasis on justification & deductive reasoning. Now the excessive use of the metaphor is leading almost to what to newcomers would appear as mysticism as the citta has become its own breathing, living, moving animal that has properties that are somehow only disclosed to special individuals.

The style in the current period appears even less equipped in my eyes to adequately present views to HH's interlocutors because of how orthogonal it is to the general style.

So to summarize, because, in my eyes, HH hasn't sufficiently distinguished between the method of presentation appropriate to confidence-oriented people and investigation-oriented people, I thought I should perhaps present the same view in a manner that may appeal to that latter subset.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-03 05:07:33*

You're essentially saying that it's necessary to cater to people who from the start are poised to not put the teachings into practice. With that I don't mean "investigation-oriented" people as a whole—using one's reasoning is not inherently wrong—but people who refuse to try to see what we are pointing at in their individual experience afflicted by suffering (which is what gives rise to faith).

That refusal is not going to end once enough justifications are given because it's an emotionally rooted habit. They will demand more rigor in some other respect, and meeting that demand will only help them procrastinate approaching the Dhamma at the level where it is (presently evident and verifiable).

It's the same principle that is described here.

tejveeer

Hello bhante, I've been unable to restrain from using internet, and rather than going on random subreddits and spilling out further I've decided I'll allow myself to remain on this subreddit only, and then restart after confession.

I was thinking about what you wrote and the sutta you presented. I'll present my thoughts in case they are useful to anyone. I'll denote p as paragraph and s as sentence (px.sy denotes paragraph x, sentence y). It seems there are the following claims here:

1. That it's necessary to cater to people who refuse to practice because of attachment to their own views (p1.s1).
2. That if a person is refusing to practice, then if they are presented satisfying justifications, they will still demand more rigor rather than practice (p1.s2, p2.s1).
    1. That satisfying that new demand will only assist them in procrastinating (p2.s2).

Claim 1 is a view attributed to me, and claim 2 appears implicitly to held by yourself. I agree with claim 2 & 2.1, but there seems to be something off in the context in which it's stated; I'll try to make this more exact. Then I'll address claim 1.

Within investigation-oriented people, we should distinguish between those whose refusal to practice is due to (a) their attachment to their own views, and (b) their inability to find sufficient justification for the practice. For reference purposes, a person who is investigation-oriented of the former kind I can call an *attached investigator*, and the latter a *constrained investigator*.

The latter is said to be constrained because they lack sufficient grounds for the claim; the grounds presented to them are not perceived as sufficient for the claim in question. They are constrained by this perception because don't know whether the cost of the practice (suffering from restraint), is worth the benefit (freedom from suffering). This is because they aren't able to perceive any appropriate initial grounds that may indicate to them that that benefit can indeed be received from the cost.

The two kinds of investigators don't have to be mutually exclusive. A constrained investigator who is very attached we can call an *attached constrained investigator* and one who's not very attached we can call an *unattached constrained investigator*.

Claim 2 can thus be made more exact, stating instead as follows:

> That if an attached investigator is refusing to practice, then if they are presented satisfying justifications, they will still demand more rigor rather than practice

In which case that is likely true. But, we can consider the other expression of claim 2 with the other kind of investigator:

> That if an unattached constrained investigator is refusing to practice, then if they are presented satisfying justifications, they will still demand more rigor rather than practice

In which case this is likely not true. A case in point would be myself. I wasn't extremely attached to a particular view of practice, but in the initial years, none of the justifications HH presented made sense to me. It was only last year when I realized that the taking up of the practice doesn't need to be rigorously justified, and that I can instead justify it practically. This opened up the possibility of setting my eyes completely on restraint, which then very quickly led to seeing a lot of other things directly that now allow me to justify pretty a lot of what HH says.

A suggestion from someone here may be that such individuals should just stop being constrained; that they should just stop looking for justifications that demand such rigor. But that's like telling someone to stop looking for justification through whatever means they look for it. The primary means others justify beliefs is through other people (are others believing this? do they think it's fine?). The fact that these individuals have unnecessarily high standards of rigor is factually a problem, and is like the sutta itself states.

It could be thought of as a disease of its own. On the one hand time is passing away, yet on the other, the individual is unable to decide because of standards that can't be met without actually undertaking the practice.

But just asserting that they have high standards doesn't actually solve the problem. The suggestion in that case is simply idealistic; a realistic suggestion would have to involve an actual proposal for how to proceed with undoing that high standard.

Now I can also clarify the sense in which I held claim 1, which is as follows:

> That if an unattached constrained investigator is presented adequate justification, then it is likely that they will accept that view

I wouldn't make the claim that it's necessary since asserting that 'X is necessary' is far stronger than asserting simply X (see the SEP article on Modal Epistemology). Now I can be even more exact regarding what my aim in the writing was: it was to present adequate justification for the HH view on celibacy for unattached constrained investigators with an anglophone background.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 07:09:59*

> They are constrained by this perception because don't know whether the cost of the practice (suffering from restraint), is worth the benefit (freedom from suffering). This is because they aren't

> able to perceive any appropriate initial grounds that may indicate to them that that benefit can indeed be received from the cost.

Yes, and my point is that they won't perceive those grounds through more rigorous argumentation, so it's a waste of time and effort for both parties.

The daunting difficulty of the practice will only be taken on if a person feels that the alternative is not only worse, but inescapable: "I am prey to suffering" is seen acutely and personally, as a necessary property of one's entire existence. Seeing that liability automatically makes theoretical justifications for the practice redundant, just as you don't need a logical proof to justify trying to remove an arrow from your chest.

If the problem does not manifest to one on that level, then one's commitment will not be sufficient to go "against the grain" of one's personal desires and obsessions. Thus, no matter how closely one follows the Suttas on paper, one will not be committed to the actual Dhamma but to something that merely sounds like it.

jareb *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

> if your practice does not include celibacy, then either your view of the practice is wrong (i.e., it is not geared towards purifying your mind from craving), or your commitment to practicing along the right lines is still underdeveloped (lack of a sense of urgency). Both of these are obvious obstructions to stream entry.

It would then follow that entering the stream is impossible for laypeople who observe the five precepts. Fortunately, the Buddha did not consider this to be the case.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-03 05:11:12*

> the Buddha did not consider this to be the case.

What is this belief based on?

jareb

It is based on facts, not believes.

For example, in MN 14, such a fact is contained in the Buddha's statement that even the understanding of the danger of sensuality at the level of a noble disciple is insufficient for the complete and final abandonment of sensuality, and that one additional factor is required; furthermore, that without these two factors together, even a noble disciple may still indulge in sensuality, and the life of a householder will not lose its significance for him.

MN14

> "Mahānāma, there is a quality that remains in you that makes you have such thoughts. For if you had given up that quality you would

> not still be living at home and enjoying sensual pleasures. But because you haven't given up that quality you are still living at home and enjoying sensual pleasures.
>
> Sensual pleasures give little gratification and much suffering and distress, and they are all the more full of drawbacks. So, Mahānāma, even though a noble disciple has clearly seen this with right wisdom, as long as they do not achieve the rapture and bliss that are apart from sensual pleasures and unskillful qualities, or something even more peaceful than that, they can return to sensual pleasures. But when they do achieve that rapture and bliss, or something more peaceful than that, they do not return to sensual pleasures.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 04:19:52*

> even a noble disciple may still indulge in sensuality, and the life of a householder will not lose its significance for him.

Yes, and as I wrote in the second alternative above, that would come from being under-committed to the training.

The Buddha went on to give a long exposition to Mahānāma on the dangers of sensuality because not giving it up is precisely what was holding him back.

jareb

The second factor for abandoning sensuality right from the same sutta:

> 'But I am capable of experiencing perfect happiness for one day and night without moving my body or speaking. I am capable of experiencing perfect happiness for two days … three days … four days … five days … six days … seven days. What do you think, reverends? This being so, who lives in greater pleasure, King Bimbisāra or I?'
>
> 'This being so, Venerable Gotama lives in greater pleasure than King Bimbisāra.'"

Could it be that both factors necessary for the complete abandonment of sensuality are accessible to an ordinary person, if they are inaccessible even to a noble disciple at the level of Mahānāma?

For from HH's views follows not only this, but also the even more absurd assertion that both of these factors are accessible and necessary for entering the stream—which, according to HH, is impossible without the final abandonment of sensuality—yet after entering the stream, they are somehow lost.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 11:54:43*

You are conflating "being unable to return to sensuality" with practicing in line with the Dhamma.

Being celibate and withdrawn (which is what we have stated as a requirement) doesn't mean you are beyond sensual desire. It means you don't *give into it,* which is how you go against the stream and make progress towards the cessation of craving.

jareb

Mahanama, a noble disciple, literally asks the Buddha in the sutta why he is still giving in to sensuality, even though he has achieved the right view as a householder and understands the dangers of sensuality.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 13:03:48*

That doesn't contradict the point at all.

Mahānāma was lacking in diligence, which as I mentioned in the first comment above, is possible for a noble disciple. Seeing that lack of diligence, the Buddha spoke about the dangers of sensuality hoping that Mahānāma would gain enough of a sense of urgency to fully give up wrong intention.

If his enjoyment of sensuality was not the cornerstone of his lack of diligence—and was instead a dismissable symptom of not developing something else—the Buddha would've given him a discourse on that other thing instead of on the dangers of sensuality.

jareb

The problem is that the Buddha is mentioning something very different to a lack of diligence: he is mentioning two factors, the first of which — an understanding of the dangers of sensuality — is already present in Mahanama.

When the Buddha *reminds* him of the dangers of sensuality, he is giving Mahanama a push to restore his mindfulness.

At the end of the sutta, the Buddha describes to him the effects of developed mindfulness: the happiness and pleasure that are superior to sensuality. Mahanama has not yet experienced this happiness and pleasure, but as a noble disciple with the right view, he understands it.

The lack of mindfulness and experience of the escape from feelings, Venerable.

For an ordinary person, this would be a lack of mindfulness, knowledge, and understanding of the existence of the escape from feelings other than sensuality. This means that the same two factors are at play for both an ordinary person and a noble disciple.

An ordinary person who follows the five precepts gives in to sensuality and still not a noble desciple himself not because they are not celibate for long enough, but because the pleasure of sensuality is the only escape from displeasure they know of, due to ignorance.

The ignorance, Venerable.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 15:11:33*

So, you're proposing that it's not a problem for a person to engage in sensuality, maintaining their reliance on that form of happiness, when they don't know a better form of happiness. They are free to continue to do so; they just need to train in "mindfulness"—an exercise that is clearly done at the expense of acknowledging that craving is the root of suffering, and that wrong intention must be abandoned.

That exercise will somehow lead to the same result as the mindfulness that the Suttas do teach—mindfulness which *is* geared towards abandoning craving, and would thus be along the lines of remembering to not give in to sensual urges whenever they arise. This "mindfulness" also bypasses the Buddha's statement that someone who still enjoys sensuality cannot abide in internal calm.

Does that not sound like magical thinking?

jareb

No, that's not what I'm suggesting. In fact, until now, I haven't suggested anything. I have merely pointed out that the claim that celibacy is necessary for entering the stream is refuted by the facts in the suttas. The idea that celibacy is a prerequisite for entering the stream does not come from the Buddha. As long as this fact is not acknowledged, HHs essentially fail to meet their own criteria, which they have articulated so beautifully and categorically on numerous occasions, and which they have recommended be applied to other teachers and their interpretations of the suttas.

As you know, Venerable, without acknowledgement, there can be no correction.

What is truly necessary is observing the five precepts and accepting right views with taints as right views with taints. On this basis, it is possible to study and investigate what truly leads to the right views of the noble ones by searching for one's own wrong views and replacing them with the right views of the noble ones. Or how about eliminating a wrong understanding of the aggregates of clinging, i.e. the first noble truth? Or dependent origination - the second and the third? In other words, what about the elimination of the ignorance?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-04 19:10:47*

> The idea that celibacy is a prerequisite for entering the stream does not come from the Buddha.

The idea that it isn't a prerequisite doesn't come from the Buddha either. Both are interpretations.

> In other words, what about the elimination of the ignorance?

Denying non-sensuality as a necessary part of the practice is undeniable ignorance of the four noble truths here and now: following the most blatant form of craving while trying to solve the problem means you ignore that craving is the origin of the problem.

jareb

The prerequisites are explicitly listed by the Buddha in many suttas as the factors for the stream-entry, and celibacy is not listed among these factors, even once.

One more point, Venerable. It seems to me that HH's position fails to take into account the difference between the situation of a layperson and that of a monk.

Pj1: > "Well then, monks, I will lay down a training rule for the following ten reasons: > > for the well-being of the Sangha, for the comfort of the Sangha, for the restraint of bad people, for the ease of good monks, for the restraint of the corruptions relating to the present life, for the restraint of the corruptions relating to future lives, to give rise to confidence in those without it, to increase the confidence of those who have it, for the longevity of the true Teaching, and for supporting the training.

A layperson who engages in sexual activity within the framework of observing the five precepts is not breaking any rules, whereas a monk who engages in a similar act commits a grave violation of the Vinaya—he commits a parajika offence.

A monk causes harm and acts against the following when he breaks even the smallest rule of the Vinaya: the well-being and comfort of the Sangha; the restraint of bad people; the ease of good monks; the restraint of corruptions relating to the present and future lives; the rising of confidence in those without it and the increasing of confidence in those who have it; the longevity of the true Teaching; and the support of the training.

The very same action performed by a layperson and a monk can have entirely different significance and consequences - it's a different kamma.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-05 13:48:19*

> The prerequisites are explicitly listed by the Buddha in many suttas as the factors for the stream-entry, and celibacy is not listed among these factors, even once.

That's because for someone who rightly views practicing in line with the Dhamma (a factor for stream-entry) as practicing towards the cessation of craving, the need for celibacy will be obvious. Just as it was to the entire Saṅgha before any rules were laid down.

> A layperson who engages in sexual activity within the framework

> of observing the five precepts is not breaking any rules, whereas a monk who engages in a similar act commits a grave violation of the Vinaya—he commits a parajika offence.

That's secondary; both are engaging in wrong intention. The Vinaya is an impermanent framework that will one day be forgotten, but wrong intention will always be wrong intention and lead to the maintenance of craving no matter who you are.

Plus, that a monk receives the same penalty as murderer for such an act is no accident. See how the Buddha tells Sudinna that what he did was the direct opposite of the spirit of the Dhamma.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by spiffyhandle *2026-04-01 11:39:31 ###* Right mindset to benefit from the confession server?

I was in the confession server for six weeks, but it didn't help me. Ironically, it made my practice worse. I wonder what I did wrong. Some people say they benefit a lot from it.

First, I found it neurotic to keep a list of every instance of breaking a precept. I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation. I cannot remember every violation unless I write them down.

Second, is there a helpful mindset to approach the confession server with? I joined the server with a vague hope that it would be helpful. At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point **and** I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people's confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

Since leaving, I've found some improvement in precepts through Uposatha. I find I can keep the precepts for one day and then that has momentum into the rest of the week. And I'm starting to experience why the precepts are important and how they relate to my mind.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-01 15:13:00*

> I'd prefer to go by memory, but the instructions say that I must report every violation.

The rule says:

> Make sure to list every transgression that you recall, and not only the ones you think are important.

The point being, *when* you recall something that is clearly a transgression, you confess it instead of giving yourself the chance to explain away the confession as not necessary in that particular instance. So the rule is “don’t intentionally cover things up” and not “don’t accidentally forget anything.”

> At first, I tried really hard to keep the precepts because I thought it was embarrassing to admit to others that I broke them. But after two weeks, I stopped being embarrassed. Then, I gradually slid into breaking precepts more and more because I started with a weak internal reference point and I lost my external reference point (embarrassment). Something about reading other people’s confessions made me feel like my own violations were more acceptable.

It’s a common misconception that confession helps by producing an external sense of embarrassment. But that embarrassment is indeed quite ephemeral and won’t take you very far.

The right shame (*hiriottappā*) comes from failing at something that you were sincerely devoted to (hence *saddhā* comes before *hiri* and *ottappā* in the list of five powers). The external act of confessing cannot by itself ensure that you are sincerely devoted to purifying your conduct, nor that the right sense of shame and the resulting effort arise.

Ulu-Mulu

Bhante, I have the question about the right shame.

I had recently some very strong feeling, the sila became of much more importance to me. Then I cheated on some online test and I felt a deep anxiety and stress due to this (due to acting against the sila). Due to this intensive state it become much clear to me how much benefit is to be gained from acting with virtue and that there’s alot of pain to be gained from acting against it (I tried to keep the sila seriously for quite a longer time before then of course).
Is this *hiriottappā* then? I mostly wonder about the the anxiety there if it should be felt this way.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-04-03 06:53:23*

> Is this hiriottappā then? I mostly wonder about the the anxiety there if it should be felt this way.

Potentially. The shame needs to come from feeling that you failed yourself by doing what unavoidably harms you, not from having failed in the eyes of someone or something external.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Ok_Watercress_4596 *2026-03-23 06:26:47*
Weakening Attachment

Hello, I am fairly new In my practice trying to put my best in the understanding of the dhamma I keep noticing how an enormous amount of time, effort and energy goes into distractions. I see this as a huge hindrance. I could be directing this energy to a way more profitable strategy long term or just do nothing for the sake of practice, but the attachment is strong. Any real effort is unpleasant, because it's not easy, it doesn't matter how difficult it is, as long as it's not easy it is very unpleasant and provokes a ton of aversion towards the things not going smoothly. I find myself stopping very often to see what is it that the mind is afraid of, same way I stop to contemplate this hindrance of constantly being distracted, it creates a strong emotional response and clearly the mind is not ready to let go, even thinking about letting go of craving is unbearable, like a full stop into a wall. It seems like an abyss in which there cannot be anything good. At least that is the picture the mind is painting.

I wonder "where do I start?", "why am I still so reluctant to restraint?". Could I be still lagging behind with the five precepts, is that a thing? I expected restraint to become easier as understanding of the dhamma deepens. What could I be doing wrong that is stopping progress?

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-24 20:11:50*

> I wonder "where do I start?", "why am I still so reluctant to restraint?"… What could I be doing wrong that is stopping progress?

1. Start with clarifying what is your own goal. And don't forget it.
2. You answered it: because restraint requires effort and the mind perceives relinquishment as an abyss.
   Therefore you need a very good reason (i.e. a goal that is more important than anything else in the world) to stick to it regardless.
3. Being impatient and wanting results without the effort.

If a goal is sufficiently important to you, then no amount of time, effort or relinquishment can be too much for the sake of reaching it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by craveminerals *2026-03-16 16:53:33* ### Arahants laughing

Would an Arahant laugh?

Ñāṇavīra Thera wrote about humor and laughter, suggesting that laughter is closely bound up with fear or experienced threat—such as that arising from contradiction—and may appear when that threat is seen as harmless or passes.

He writes:

"We laugh, then, when fear passes; we laugh as a charm to make fear pass;

and we entertain imaginary fears to make ourselves laugh.”“Laughter, then, is not so much a reaction to fear as its counterpart … He [the sekha] is already leaving behind him both laughter and tears.”

If an Arahant’s mind is free from sorrow, anxiety, and tension (see SN 22.43), it is unclear whether laughter could still arise. (If it did, it would presumably be of a different kind than we usually express, or only as a smile)

Could it occur purely as a bodily reaction—like from an illness— or would laughter imply that there is some tension in the mind?

Edit: reworded for more accuracy

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-17 15:28:57*

The Buddha said that *too much* laughter is regarded as childish in the noble one’s discipline. Besides, notice that unlike dancing and singing, he does not speak of “destroying the bridge” in regard to even this childish laughter. In other words, it’s not something you would categorically fall away because it’s not intrinsically unwholesome, but you should try to avoid it because for people whose understanding of the Dhamma is still shallow and who take you as an example, it can easily be interpreted as an allowance for laxity in regard to actually unwholesome things even when it’s not unwholesome for you internally.

The Buddha himself supposedly never laughed, and that makes perfect sense given that he had refined his outward demeanor beyond the minimum threshold of an Arahant (who is only incapable of five specific actions.

That refinement was only natural given the weight that his image had to carry as the absolute highest authority on the Dhamma.

craveminerals

Thank you Bhante Being unable to take “a course of action influenced by desire, aversion, muddledness, or fear” wouldn’t necessarily eliminate laughter, then. Edit: Though AN 3.107 say nothing of Arahants, perhaps we can assume that *too much laughter* applies to “everyone involved”.

In reading some of Ven. Ñāṇavīra’s thoughts on this, he seems to be saying something true. But there’s also a possibility that what he describes is quite removed from “real life” and how things actually work.

If I may ask another question, what do you make of the “laughing wisdom” in SN 55.24, that spiffyhandle mentioned in their comment, what does that mean?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-17 19:27:05*

> Being unable to take “a course of action influenced by desire, aversion, muddledness, or fear” wouldn’t eliminate laughter, then.

Yes, and laughter isn't even an action many times. Action requires intention, and laughter can happen despite one's intention being actively set on the opposite.

> In reading some of Ñāṇavīra's thoughts on this, he seems to be saying something true. But there's also a possibility that what he describes is quite removed from "real life" and how things actually work.

Yes, he definitely had a philosophical bent, and that's often at odds with the Dhamma. Granted, he openly admitted that he was writing all those letters to pass the time, having lost the motivation to strive further due to his sickness. He himself likely didn't see those ideas as fundamental to the training.

> If I may ask another question, what do you make of the "laughing wisdom" in SN 55.24, that spiffyhandle mentioned in their comment, what does that mean?

Hāsapaññā is used for Ven. Sāriputta in SN 2.29 and elsewhere, so it can't be connected with Sarakāni's drinking habit.

It could simply mean "endowed with wisdom that brings happiness." But that would be strange according to Pāli convention, since it would be an outlier in a list of terms that all have very similar meanings.

Perhaps *hāsa* is derived from (or is a corruption of) *haṁsa,* which means swan. In the Suttas, the swan is sometimes used to convey swiftness, which fits with the other qualifiers in the SN 2.29 list.

spiffyhandle

Assuming "laughing wisdom" is a good translation, I wonder if that's the skill to bring about laughter and joy in others when giving dhamma talks. If so, an example of that could be Ajahn Chah.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-18 18:01:03*

> I wonder if that's the skill to bring about laughter and joy in others when giving dhamma talks.

No, it couldn't be a "skill" in a Dhamma context. It would at best remain as a habit built up from before, and a mostly counterproductive one at that. Hence the Buddha's own example.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Solip123 *2026-03-15 15:47:35* ### How do you practice despite constant (emotional) pain and misery?

Advice sorely needed, especially from people in similar positions who understand the feeling of being trapped with no exit in sight.

I am falling apart right now, acting out of aversion almost constantly. I think about death frequently because the pain is so unrelenting. It doesn't matter what I do because the background feeling is *always* one of unpleasantness, and it has been this way for several years (i.e., this has nothing to do with the practice itself). The only reason I'm holding off on that decision is because I'm afraid of dying without having gotten the right view, thereby forfeiting the chance to (possibly ever) make an end to suffering. And at least for now that frightens me more than the thought of remaining alive. But this has the consequence of worsening the suffering because I feel even more trapped since I now see death as a risky gamble.

For context I am currently keeping five precepts + celibacy and *some* of the other eight precepts.

Edit: I realized the title is a bit misleading as the pain is actually part "mental" (i.e., not necessarily related to emotions) and part "emotional" (e.g., hopelessness, sorrow, regret, shame, anxiety, feeling of being trapped). And "misery" connotes the omnipresent background feeling of unpleasantness and dread.

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-17 09:09:01*

> How do you practice despite constant (emotional) pain and misery?

The very short answer would be: by not trying to get rid of the pain and misery, because it is not the problem. The whole burden is trying to stop yourself feeling the unpleasant feeling.

Obviously you can't change that overnight, but you do need to change the expectation, if it is there, that the dhamma practice is supposed to make the pain go away. It is supposed to make the resistance in regard to that pain go away.

If this sounds completely inapplicable and and abstract, you might need to first learn, or ask more specific questions, about how to practice in regard to some of the particular types of emotional pain you mentioned. (Remorse, shame, suicidal thoughts etc).

It will come down to recognising that certain thoughts are irrational and not acting out of them, but this is difficult if you are not able yourself to recognise them as irrational and distance yourself from them.

Hard_Tack4

But don't you think if someone is suicidal and isn't even fully committed to the 8 precepts some temporary relief wouldn't be a good idea so that they can build up from their already good foundation? It seems somewhat unrealistic to expect full determination from the post author. I'm obviously not talking about taking steps back, I mean more like just whatever mundane psychotherapy or even diet changes that can make things a little easier so they can move on. It's not like they have a deficiency in neuroticism.

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-18 04:14:14*

Of course, I am not saying that the OP should not seek any kind of temporary relief. Plenty of other good suggestions were already made in regard to this, and he should by all means follow such advice if it makes things more bearable.

But he did not ask about temporary relief; he asked how to practice the dhamma in regard to constant pain and misery. The answer to that is as I said: by first learning that the pain and misery is not the probem, it's the symptom of the problem. The assumption that the pain has to go away first in order to be able to practice is what hinders the actual cure.

Edit: also, it is worth noting things that immediately relieve the unpleasant feeling can also be part of the right practice. The most obvious example is that if someone is miserable on account of shame and remorse for something they have done, the right practice is to confess it, openly and truthfully. This will be a relief, and that's completely fine.

It makes all the difference whether the relief comes from hiding from the source of the pain or from admitting it. The first one is what I am saying will hinder the practice. How something feels is not a reference for its rightness or wrongness.

Solip123

Thank you. This was helpful. I had the belief that any kind of relief of the mental/emotional distress should (ideally) be avoided as it's an action done out of aversion (to the unpleasant feeling).

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-24 17:50:11*

> I had the belief that any kind of relief of the mental/emotional distress should (ideally) be avoided as it's an action done out of aversion (to the unpleasant feeling).

That is understandable, because it is very easy to hear instructions such as what I repeated above: 'do not try to get rid of the unpleasant feeling', and think it means 'do not do anything that relieves the unpleasant feeling'.

That's essentially what self-mortification is, whereby you conflate 'not acting out of aversion' with 'making the pain worse'. It is something I also had to unlearn.

It's not any relief of the pain that should be avoided; it's the **attitude and action** of resisting, avoiding and hiding from the pain; OR that of actively maintaining it in self-punishment.

It's also possible to have unwholesome resistance in regard to things that are neutral or pleasant when they aren't on your terms, or if they require you to give up a strong habit or comfort zone.

So either way it is the unwholesome actions that are to be avoided, not feeling of relief or feeling of pain.

(I am adding this just in case it helps clarify the point further, even though it was already stated in brief. It was hard to be sure exactly what you were asking at first, as the initial question was quite broad, so this helps me be more specific.)

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by LotusOfUpekkha *2026-03-14 12:14:39* ### Concussive contemplations

I write this while having a concussion (it involved vomiting as well) - I already got checked out by a doctor. Maybe what I write here doesn't make much sense, maybe it does, but if it doesn't please let me know. I'll try to keep it short and get back to resting in a darkened room instead of posting on Reddit after trying to write down some things that have been in my mind since getting the concussion in an attempt to share it and possibly receive feedback from others.

Brain is like a puree, like a warm butter, it is liable to get mashed (like with a fork). It will get mashed for sure in some way or another when old age, sickness and death set in. No intellectual capability, no 'bright thinking', no 'clear headed reasoning', memory, interpreting of language, motor skills etc. can stay as it is right now. Every human being, no matter how 'quick of wits' they are, no matter how great their reasoning capabilities, their "IQ" or intellectual performances is liable to this. No one can escape from their brain turning to dust, to mush, to food for maggots, to being blown away with the wind, eaten by all kinds of insects, no one can escape losing all their memories, all their faculties, all their "rationale".

I am in my early twenties, and for my entire life I've always taken my intellect, my capability to reason or philosophize with these 'bright faculties' entirely for granted - I've always taken them to be 'my safe space' - it resembled a means of managing the unpleasantness that is inevitable. In fact for me (and probably for many) it has been THE way of management, the over analyzing situations, ideas and circumstances, the psychologizing, the theorizing about this and that, the philosophizing - trying to make sense of things in order to 'give it a place internally', to form views and opinions about this and that in an attempt to make it it all a bit less confusing and overwhelming.

Some thoughts after getting pretty badly concussed have been along the lines of: "this time, it really could cause ***permanent damage -*** this time I might not get off with merely a scratch", "this time my precious reasoning capabilities that have always been so dear to me, might be affected in ways I cannot even imagine as of right now". These thoughts are not even the problem, they are merely Mara knocking on the door. Opening that door is what all the trouble is

about. Trying to look for answers, trying to find safety in thoughts about how it all will get better soon, how this brain fog, these altered perceptions and the diminished "brightness of mano and reasoning capabilities" will probably improve as time passes *is a very, very big mistake*, *it's a* ***deadly*** *trap* - Because there's no such guarantee - I'm still hanging by a thread regardless, it's not my property after all: I borrowed it, Mara's the owner who'll decide what happens to it. To flee into such thoughts, is to take the bait, and on the other hand, to wave away the possibility that these circumstantial conditions (such as whatever physiological process it might be that 'restores' these mental reasoning capabilities again) could actually improve is yet another assumption rooted in aversion probably (doom thinking).

I was thinking about this from AN 5.121:

> "Bhikkhus, whatever weak and sick bhikkhu is not abandoned by five phenomena, this is to be expected for him: 'Before long, with the destruction of the influxes, he will abide having entered upon the liberation by mind and liberation by wisdom that is devoid of influxes, having for himself comprehended and realized it right in the present experience.'
>
> "Which five?
>
> "Here, bhikkhus, a bhikkhu abides maintaining perspective of non-beauty concurrently with the body, perceiving the repulsiveness of food, perceiving non-delight in the entire world, maintaining perspective of impermanence in all activities, and the perception of death is well-established internally for him.
>
> "Bhikkhus, whatever weak and sick bhikkhu is not abandoned by these five phenomena, this is to be expected for him: 'Before long, with the destruction of the influxes …etc.… having comprehended and realized it, he will abide having entered upon it.' "

Something about using the weakness & sickness stuck with me from this sutta. Maybe someone can go deeper in on this?

EDIT: What's also anxiety inducing is coming from the assumption that I am entitled to a well-functioning mano, a well performing reasoning faculty (at least to the point of being able to contemplate the Dhamma) - and that this could simply be taken away whenever, to the point of not being able to practice the Dhamma anymore, or be on my way of practicing the Dhamma, so that all progress is basically impossible or halted - by any random event like hitting one's head, falling etc.

EDIT 2: For this one I would appreciate some feedback as well: Suppose your brain is actually permanently damaged to a lesser or greater extent. **All** of the activities (saṅkhārās) - especially the most fundamental sankharas of lust, aversion and distraction - are only possible as an attitude *because* that brain

(however much damaged) is still somehow functional & still sustains life (nāmarūpa & viññāṇa are still “leaning on each other like two sheaves of reed”). This is why *all activities are impermanent* (sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā) - precisely because any attitude, any leaning of citta, any upādāna is only possible because this brain that’s liable to get turned to mush and is completely inaccessible to my *relative sense of control,* my intentions/my willpower is still there enduring without me doing anything about it, without me being able to ‘prevent damage’ from occurring, or ‘repairing’ any damage that might’ve already occurred. Any damage whatsoever that there might be - I am buried alive in, no intention can reach below the threshold of the brain that makes any of this possible and is in this or that neurological condition. Why is this liberating? Because there’s nothing *I* can do about it & any activity is seen to be absurd when it is employed as an attempt to change anything about the fundamental situation of utter confinement. There’s nothing to be concerned about as it’s all going straight to the graveyard either way - what does it matter in which order, manner, severity etc. it breaks apart?: (careful to not make *this* into some averse doom and gloom attitude).

EDIT 4: **Broken pots**:

“As clay pots made by a potter all end up being broken, so is the life of mortals.” Snp 3.8

“It’s like the vessels made by potters. Whatever kind they are, whether baked or unbaked, all of them are liable to break apart.” SN 3.22

“Realizing that this body is as fragile as a clay pot, and fortifying this mind like a well-fortified city, fight out Mara with the sword of wisdom.” Dhp 40

Thank you for reading.

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-15 06:56:20*

A good post which reminds me of this:

> A dying man can only rely upon his wisdom, if he developed it. Wisdom is not dependent upon any phenomenon originated upon six senses. It is developed on the basis of the discernment of the same. That’s why when one’s senses start to wither and die, the knowledge of their nature remains unaffected. When there is no wisdom, there will be despair, in the face of death. Breathing Towards Death.

Regarding the ‘edit 2’ part: The sankhāras are there in ignorance. Not understanding that one’s actions and cares have not even the possibility of access over their own foundation, they *do* reach over and access it by mistake, although they cannot. This ignorant appropriation (and consequently being affected in return) is real and exists as such, to greater or lesser degree in everyone who is not an arahant. The task is to wear it away by sufficiently and repeatedly recognising the mistake, and stopping the actions and habits

that uphold it.

Therefore the only thing I would mention about this part (as a precaution more than a correction) is that it can definitely be the right way to think, **as long as that thinking does not become abstract.**

I.e., it is one thing to have the idea 'even every upādāna is impermanent'; it is another thing to become actually aware of that very phenomenon of 'taking up' what cannot be taken up, finding it in concrete standpoints and paths of thought. (You mentioned some examples.) The former does nothing to free you from that upādāna; the latter is the direct way to undo it. Avoid abstract thinking like the plague.

LotusOfUpekkha

Thank you Ayye.

> it can definitely be the right way to think, **as long as that thinking does not become abstract**.… Avoid abstract thinking like the plague.

A thought about this: Why are the Divine Messengers said to be "Divine"? Might one 'aspect' of their divine nature be that they serve to make **concrete** that which we otherwise keep comfortably **abstract**?

When the Divine Messengers come knocking (or *hammering*), as it seems to be the case in my life now (and has been for a while even before this concussion) - they seem to send their message in *layers that can merge* into one ENORMOUS banner of your existential vulnerability that you cannot look away from without *severely burning* yourself the moment you think it's fine to distract yourself from it, even for a little while. This looking away, or perhaps more precisely: *the fundamental assumption that looking away is an effective strategy to 'deal with' the nature of the message*, is an activity (sankhāra) that can only exist because one is ignorant to greater or lesser degree about the impossibility of one's ability to alter their nature.

In the passage of AN 5.121 I quoted, it is mentioned that one "abides maintaining perspective of non-beauty concurrently with the body". - Never in my life have I been so let down, disappointed and disgusted with that which I previously found a sense of safety and comfort in (this body, these faculties). And I think that if one abides with this peripheral recognition of how utterly *disgusting* this situation as a whole is - how disgusting it is to *rely on* a body for comfort or safety and how revolting it is that *anything at all* that is experienced via these senses *has* to come through this unreliable, mushy, deteriorating, stinking thing - being in Mara's control is the most disgusting thing there is. It seems like 'not being abandoned' by even just this first of the 5 phenomena mentioned in that sutta, is enough to 'not be abandoned' by them all. They seem to be inclusive of one another - pointing to the same truth.

Another question: What is concrete thinking? I try to describe it as “thinking *concurrently with* the pressure” - thinking about what is pressuring one *while* one is pressured without looking away from that pressure at any point. How would one concretely think about/contemplate death rather than in abstraction?

EDIT: (apologies for it becoming quite long, but I wanted to add some thoughts about this part:)

> they *do* reach over and access it by mistake, although they cannot. This ignorant appropriation (and consequently being affected in return) is real and exists as such, to greater or lesser degree in everyone who is not an arahant

This is basically what bhava is, right? By conceiving direct access to that which cannot ever be accessed, one maintains/increases/fuels their (sense of) being - an existence/being - that is real as such- is conceived due to one’s assumption of ‘the external’ to that which is its source/foundation/origin? And so something that doesn’t need “life” (is gratuitous) is given a life that it doesn’t actually have - it only exists as such due to one’s conceiving which contradicts the nature of things?

So practically speaking (in an attempt to make it more concrete): if one’s head feels like a strong man is tightening a tough leather strap around it, and there’s an unpleasant feeling simultaneously enduring - if there’s still *any leaning whatsoever* of citta (which would be an activity - a sankhāra) there would simultaneously also always be bhava there - one cannot ‘exist’ without the other - an existence of some kind HAS to be there always as long as leaning is not fully uprooted. Does that make sense?

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-15 21:14:50*

> What is concrete thinking?

In the briefest terms, it is thinking that is truthful to the practical reality of a thing.

> I try to describe it as “thinking *concurrently with* the pressure” - thinking about what is pressuring one *while* one is pressured

Broadly that’s correct, certainly much better than theory that is completely divorced from anything you are experiencing.

But it depends: if you are thinking *about* what is pressuring you through a theoretical lens that you have learned or reasoned, that would still not be quite concrete (enough).

If you are letting what is pressuring you endure for what it is; not trying to explain it, nor actively distracting yourself from it - then the thought of that pressuring thing that endures there on its own is a concrete thought.

So when you said:

> without looking away from that pressure at any point.

And:

> you cannot look away from [it] without *severely burning* yourself the moment you think it's fine to distract yourself from it, even for a little while.

If by 'looking away from it' you mean purposefully engaging in distractions and sense objects in order to not think about it, then yes, absolutely.

But if you mean letting yourself lose sight of it, think about other things, and not have it sharply in front of you nor feel the pressure on account of it - you can indeed forget about it in that sense, and that's fine. In fact it's not optional, unless you were to make a fabricated effort to constantly keep it in mind. (Which you will not be able to maintain.) Letting yourself forget about it is how you don't make it into something else you have to *do*. To use the example you asked about:

> How would one concretely think about/contemplate death rather than in abstraction?

As above. When the knowledge that you will die comes up on its own (which it will sooner or later), simply not panicking, running away or turning a blind eye to it. And when the memory of it fades, train yourself to not equate its absence with deluding yourself that you will live forever and can afford to delight in sensuality.

It doesn't require more active effort than that, and you don't need to keep it in front of you all the time. Doing so would be already coming out of craving, so any 'training' you try and do on such basis cannot extinguish craving.

> Why are the Divine Messengers said to be "Divine"? Might one 'aspect' of their divine nature be that they serve to make **concrete** that which we otherwise keep comfortably **abstract**?

Definitely. But in line with the above, 'concrete' does not have to mean 'actual', as in actual sickness for example. You can have a very concrete reminder of the unreliability of your own body through just hearing about or seeing a sick person. The divine messengers are literally everywhere, and people don't see them as such only because they are too intoxicated.

One should find the **concrete** reminders of the body's fallability without waiting for **actual** failing of the body.

(Of course, actual damage or illness can also be a divine messenger, which is fine - but one should aim to get out of the range of such messengers before they become too much and it is too late.)

> And I think that if one abides with this peripheral recognition of how utterly *disgusting* this situation as a whole is - how disgusting it is to *rely on* a body for comfort or safety and how revolting it is that *anything at all* that is experienced via these senses *has* to come through this unreliable, mushy, deteriorating, stinking thing - being in Mara's control is the most disgusting thing there is.

Yes, that's how it is. But it's only a problem to the extent that one still depends on it and expects it to be somehow pleasant and safe.

> It seems like 'not being abandoned' by even just this first of the 5 phenomena mentioned in that sutta, is enough to 'not be abandoned' by them all. They seem to be inclusive of one another - pointing to the same truth.

Exactly. Same goes for most similar lists you find in the suttas - they tend to be different aspects or ways of indicating one dhamma, and to understand/establish one means understanding all.

The last question I will put aside for now because it is in a slightly different topic that is not as practically relevant, and this is already quite a lot.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Financial-Wallaby316 *2026-03-06 16:11:58*
Wrong meditation as an aid for establishing virtue and sense restraint?

so a non stream enterer can't practice meditation in an actually correct way, but can one use a technically wrong practice as a tool to help establish the foundations of a right practice if they understand that that meditation technique isn't what will lead to right view? For example, if a meditation practice gives you a level of mundane mental clarity that helps you keep the 8 precepts, or it helps you stay recollected of the dhamma for the rest of the day after your practice which also aids in practicing virtue, or even just as a less destructive form of sensuality, that you can give in to before you know how to endure things at the right level, instead of giving in to things at the coarser levels of body and speech. Or if it helps you become more aware of your intentions and reasons for acting at least on the level someone without right view is capable of, and more peripherally aware of things like feelings and intentions and the body as peripherally enduring things that are the basis for anything you could ever conceive of doing, to the extent a non stream enterer can understand. Can a meditation technique be a sort of "last thing" that is abstained from, after coarser ways of acting out are abstained from?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-07 04:25:33*

What this common argument fails to see is that replacing lust and aversion with delusion is not progress at all. Delusion is the worst of the three defilements.

In other words, it's far better if you try and you fail to restrain your actions in the ordinary self-aware state than if you succeed in restraint thanks to a hypnotic state (which is not what *samādhi is).

Financial-Wallaby316

Is it ok to use these meditation techniques in ways that don't have to do with buddhist practice while still doing proper buddhist practice? I have ADHD and it interferes with my livelihood, and some of these exercises I've learned help with staying focused at work. Can I treat them the same way I might treat mundane physical exercise? Something that helps with staying healthy and functional but doesn't directly pertain to the Buddhist practice, just a totally worldly thing with worldly goals that helps with functioning in the world. It has been a less destructive solution for managing this condition than stimulant medications, so it would be great if it could stay in my life in some form without interfering with proper practice.

When I honestly reflect, it is pretty clear that these practices haven't actually done anything to attenuate or decrease greed or hatred in my mind, as I know I'd still act out on them if these techniques failed me. This makes me think that maybe if I simply stopped deluding myself about these practices and their relationship to buddhist practice, they could remain in my life the same way as any other activity, as another thing I do whose intentions I need to interrogate and reflect on and avoid doing for the wrong reasons as best I can.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-09 04:16:30*

> This makes me think that maybe if I simply stopped deluding myself about these practices and their relationship to buddhist practice, they could remain in my life the same way as any other activity, as another thing I do whose intentions I need to interrogate and reflect on and avoid doing for the wrong reasons as best I can.

Yes, that's reasonable. Even if you already don't see them as part of the training though, keep in mind that the more you succeed in the actual training, the less you will resort to *anything* for the sake of managing dukkha.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Global_Ad_7891 *2026-03-04 22:55:25* ### Question about virtue, entertainment, and understanding the emphasis on celibacy

Hello everyone,

I apologize in advance for the long winded post. Thank you to whoever reads the whole thing and provides feedback.

I've been reflecting recently on the precepts and my own conduct over the past several years, and I wanted to ask a question both about virtue and about the

role of certain precepts.

I first came across Buddhism when I was around 19 or 20 (I am now 26). At that time I read the five precepts and essentially just agreed with them. But I didn't really understand them deeply or consciously "undertake" them in any formal sense. Looking back, I think I simply encountered them, thought they made sense, and continued living in accordance with them.

In many ways I was already following most of them before I even encountered Buddhism. I had a fairly sheltered life growing up and generally wasn't inclined toward things like stealing, lying, or harming others. I'd argue that my virtue was perfectly in line with the 5 precepts except for a 2-3 year bout of smoking a lot of weed in high school. That period ended when I was 19 years old, which was influenced by encountering Buddhist teachings. Since then — about 6–7 years — I haven't used drugs or alcohol at all despite many attempts to coerce me into taking them.

I was also already living fairly simply. I never cared much about appearance or beautification, and started becoming a loner in high school, so frivolous speech and socializing were never really a big part of my life. Also I dropped out of college at 19 years old, around the time I discovered Buddhism, and I started working in a warehouse and had no friends.

For work I mostly drive a truck and manage a few properties, which means my days are spent doing fairly simple tasks — driving, cleaning, fixing things, scheduling service calls, picking up supplies, etc. So I'm alone a large portion of the day. I also talk to myself in my head a lot.

About three years ago, I lost around 70 pounds and changed my relationship with food. I started eating once per day and have maintained that pattern since then. This is mainly due to reading about OMAD and its benefits in regards to eating a keto/carnivore diet, which is what I am currently on. The diet change also relieved a lot of my food addictions to various unhealthy foods and snacks.

In regards to celibacy, in the past I would abstain for long periods and then occasionally lapse, but over the past year I've been 100% celibate and find it extremely easy to maintain.

The one area where I clearly see weakness is **entertainment**. For many years I relied heavily on distractions like video games, movies, YouTube, and sports watching. Only in the past few months have I started reducing those things, and just recently I've decided to seriously try abandoning entertainment altogether.

This leads to two questions.

First, I'm curious about the **strong emphasis placed on celibacy** in many teachings. I understand that sexual desire is very coarse and powerful, but

in my experience once abstinence becomes established the pull weakens dramatically. Even when encountering sexual imagery online or seeing attractive people in public, there's very little reaction compared to how things used to be.

By contrast, **entertainment feels much subtler but harder to deal with**. It doesn't feel like a strong addictive pull the way sex can, but there's a persistent tendency to fill boredom or discomfort with distraction. It seems easier to overlook and justify.

So I'm curious why celibacy is often emphasized as being "more important" than entertainment, when it seems possible that things like entertainment and distraction could themselves be a major obstacle to insight into the Four Noble Truths or stream entry.

My second question concerns virtue and progress on the path. Although I didn't consciously "undertake" most of the precepts with a clear understanding of their purpose at the time, I've ended up living in accordance with many of them for years. In most cases this happened simply because the opposite behavior felt unpleasant or emotionally disturbing. For example, lying tends to feel painful and emotionally driven, even if only subtly. The same goes for things like harsh speech, stealing, or acting out of strong craving. In that sense I feel that a certain degree of restraint developed somewhat naturally even before I understood the framework of Buddhist virtue.

Because of that, I sometimes wonder whether it's reasonable to think that a **fairly stable foundation of virtue** might already be present, even if my understanding of it was initially incomplete. In my day-to-day life the only thing that still seems to exert a consistent pull is distraction through entertainment or the tendency to avoid boredom. Aside from that, the inclination to break the other precepts feels almost nonexistent. So I'm wondering whether this kind of situation would generally be considered a meaningful foundation of virtue, or whether without properly understanding the precepts from the start one would still need to essentially begin again from a more basic level.

Part of why I ask this is because it seems that in the Buddha's time many people were already living quite virtuous lives before encountering the Dhamma, and some attained stream entry upon hearing relatively brief teachings. So I'm curious whether virtue established in this kind of indirect or intuitive way could play a similar role, or whether proper understanding of why you are building virtue has to come, and THEN you start training in the 8 precepts, and THEN you can use that virtue as a basis for insight.

My other question concerns **understanding the mind more deeply**. Sometimes I find it difficult to imagine how seeing the "signs of the mind" could appear fundamentally different from how experience already presents itself now, aside from removing distractions like entertainment. At times I even feel unsure what further shift in understanding would actually look like. I've occa-

sionally experienced states of seclusion from sensuality when abstaining from entertainment for extended periods, accompanied by a kind of steady and collected thinking, secluded from sensuality, which sometimes seems similar to how the suttas describe jhāna. But even with experiences like that, I'm not sure how they relate to genuine progress on the path.

So I suppose my underlying question is simply whether my perspective here is missing something important about the nature of virtue or about what insight into the Four Noble Truths actually involves.

I would very much appreciate any clarification or correction if my understanding here is mistaken.

Global_Ad_7891

I guess in a way I'm asking, could I conceivably be close to stream entry? Kind of a cringey question to ask such a serious community, but I want to understand more about why Bhikkhu Anigha stresses becoming first established in celibacy as a priority in the wiki.

edit: Also, I find eating enjoyable still, is that a hindrance to stream entry?

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-05 20:52:07*

One of the reasons that celibacy is said to be a priority is that many people's deeply-held views about the world, life, happiness and their own existence are, unbeknownst to themselves, bound up with non-celibacy - as a "normal and good part of life and who I am." There is a sense of safety in it. This creates, in many, a visceral resistance when it comes to giving it up that is on a different level to the mere sensual addiction.

Not everyone carries this particular view in regards to celibacy to the same degree. But pretty much everyone will have a personal sense of safety in something or other that they are by default refusing to undermine or question. This is the reason they are not overcoming the first three fetters.

Basically, not actually trying to follow the *whole* of the instruction to the best of one's ability, leaving out aspects you don't like or don't want to do, equates to the attitude that the Dhamma is a sort of semi-optional side-project. It implies lack of faith.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by spiffyhandle *2026-03-04 16:24:27* ### Some thoughts and reflections on my difficulties with keeping the precepts

I see a few ways to learn to keep them. My goal is living by seven precepts plus watching intentions to see danger in the slightest fault.

The first way is jumping straight to keeping seven precepts all the time and watching intentions. A person is expected to fail a lot but this is the most

ambitious standard. This is what I started with. I broke the precepts over and over and eventually it felt like I was lying to myself when I told myself that I will keep them.

The second is taking one's current level of precepts, which for me is the five, and adding on it incrementally. Take the smallest change one can do and let that stick. When that is solid, add the next smallest change. Then, when one is keeping all seven precepts, add in virtue (danger in the slightest fault).

That approach is what I am trying now. And I am not sure it is easier than doing it all at once. The problem with doing it all at once, is I feel like I'm lying to myself because I'm breaking the precepts all the time. But, the advantage of the all at once approach is the system is self-reinforcing. Keeping celibacy, no entertainments, no beautification, time restricted eating, and watching intentions all support each other. If you can get it going.

When a person only keeps celibacy, misconduct increases in entertainments. When a person keeps celibacy and entertainments, misconduct increases in food. IME. So there is a natural benefit to keeping all the precepts at once, from the start.

One problem with with doing precepts little by little is there are large gaps in my conduct and I rely on willpower. When I don't practice seeing danger in the slightest fault and just work on obeying the rules, I am undermining my practice to a degree. I tried watching my intentions only in regards to the spirit of the rule I was keeping and that was not good. I was training myself to see craving but deliberately allow myself to act out if it. For example, I might gorge on ice cream because it's not against the rules I'd taken while at the same time noticing that I was choosing to act on greed. But then in a different situation I might tell myself with *this* precept, I need to not act of of greed, but it made things confusing and ambiguous.

Overall, it's quite discouraging by how difficult it is to take up the renunciant precepts. I've added in journaling and self-reflection (https://youtu.be/7gx5kArzdVI)..) And I'm making my environment more suitable by reducing electronics consumption. I think this second approach of just keeping one extra precept at a time, in my case, celibacy, and building gradually has potential. However, it is so slow. It's really quite surprising how difficult this is. If you had asked me, I wouldn't have thought of myself as a particularly horny person. I never did hookup apps, and was genuinely celibate for two years. But there is such a massive difference between being celibate while knowing there's an end date and doing it for life.

In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

EDIT:

One thing that helped was this video by a former addict and former MMA fighter Bas Rutten - https://youtu.be/VFyN-2MW2FI

Any comments, observations, judgements, on my practice, or reflections on your own practice are welcome.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-03-05 06:33:19*

> In the past, I was pretty successful with the no entertainment precept. I gave up video games, music, movies, TV, books, and so on. But, I did it in the wrong order as I wasn't celibate. So I am hopeful that if I can finally figure out celibacy, the rest of the precepts will be easier.

An approach that might work is seeing the danger in the slightest fault, but specifically within five precepts + celibacy. So for now, you wouldn't regard it as a fault to consume entertainment as long as it doesn't arouse any sexual intentions. But you have to remain watchful of your mental state and be ready to stop despite the pressure if those intentions ever come up from the content you are consuming (or from any activity in general).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by RazzmatazzFit6906 *2026-03-02 23:47:35*
How could Devadatta have achieved jhāna and psychic powers if he wasn't even a sotāpanna?

How is that possible?

Sister_Medhini *2026-03-04 10:21:43*

There is no mention in the suttas of Devadatta achieving jhāna. I think this belief comes from commentarial stories added on to the suttas. This is not to say he had no knowledge of the Dhamma (he clearly possessed enough theoretical grasp of of it to be a good talker and convince some monks to follow him.)

But if somebody who had attained jhāna within the context of the Buddha's instruction, he would have the right view. And the suttas are clear that it is impossible for one with right view to create a schism in the sangha, or purposely try to harm the Buddha.

As for psychic powers, the main source for this seems to be a few passages in the vinaya, which occur in a rather embellished and somewhat mythologised context.

And even, there are suttas (e.g. DN 11) that state that the demonstration of pychic powers or 'magic tricks' is not in itself a sign of wisdom - rather the absence of it (emphasis on the wrong things).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-02-27 23:25:44*
Chinese Parallel to Kālāma Sutta

Has anyone mentioned this Chinese parallel to the Kālāma Sutta before? The first part of the sutta mentions how greed, aversion, and delusion cause one to break the 5 precepts, similar to the Pāli version. But in the section directly preceding the brahmavihāras, it mentions abandoning abrahmacariya (□□□) alongside the standard grouping of killing, stealing, lying, and various other kinds of wrong speech. It also mentions purifying the mind of abrahmacariya, lust, and longing for the possessions of others. This passage is not in the Pāli, which goes straight to cultivating the brahmavihāras after greed, aversion, delusion and the 5 precepts. Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-28 05:51:42*

> Perhaps an interesting basis for further research? I wonder if there are other Chinese suttas in which the Buddha talks about celibacy to lay-people, or in which celibacy is a standard pre-requisite for brahmavihāras.

Yes, I've come across many similar instances. For instance the parallel of MN 97 (MĀ 27) mentions not only that brahmavihāra involves abandoning desire and sensual thoughts, but that the brahmin Dhanañjāni succeeded in it as part of a change of direction that began with renouncing his wife.

Another one is the parallel of MN 41 (SĀ 1042) which specifies "pure precepts" and "a mind free from desire" as requirements not only for all samādhi attainments but also all noble attainments.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by MajesticPurpose5622 *2026-02-27 19:56:37*
How to clearly see the first noble truth?

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Hello, it has been a few months since i started my practice. It has become, by far, the most important thing in my life and stays at least in the back of my mind at all times.

Im currently stablishing myself in virtue and practicing sense restraint, using my free time to contemplate on the nature of my existence and the teachings.

However, my mind constantly harasses me with questions and doubts about why am i doing this in the first place, i feel as if i constantly have to explain to it the purpose i have found on the practice.

I have seen the video talking exactly about how to deal with a doubtful mind and im currently taking those steps, but one thing keeps me confused.

When i question myself about my intentions with this practice, i dont see “freedom from suffering” as the first reason. Instead i think that i wish to find the best possible way to live my life, and that has happened to be in the buddhist practice.

Im beggining to understand the unsatisfactory nature of sense desires, hence i do not wish to rely on them for my satisfaction/hapinnes, and this has been the primary reason why im doing what im doing.

When i think of my main goal with this, i think about findind unconditioned and true satisfaction with my life, wich cannot be obtained through craving and satisfying my craving, but i have to make an repetitive effort to think about Dukkha.

I wonder if my practice is rooted in the right reasons. If not, how can i see things more clearly?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-28 05:19:28*

Whether you focus on wanting better satisfaction or not wanting dissatisfaction doesn’t really matter, since either way the need for striving is recognized.

What’s more important is to remain transparent about what is taking you away from the right satisfaction and toward suffering (i.e., your own actions), so that you don’t start thinking that you can get to the right satisfaction through some kind of shortcut.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by account-7 *2026-02-27 18:26:45* ### How can one understand various fruitions through Ahjan’s analogy?

I found the video Don’t open Mara’s doors incredibly helpful and clarifying. Namely, the analogy of “opening the door” when there are people knocking outside in relation to acting out of pressure was incredibly useful to me.

I’m only wondering how one would define various levels of attainment relative to that image.

Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant’s relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

Thank you for your time.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-28 05:37:34*

> Would an arhat not even have the conception of a door anymore? Or is it more that the knocking on the door (avoiding or opening it) has absolutely no pull on them anymore?

The latter. Avoidance is its own door, so you could simply say that an Arahant has no inclination to open any door that is knocked on, having fully understood that *because* there is knocking, whatever is on the other side can only be a further nuisance.

Their citta has understood that all the way, so they don't need to make any effort to remember it.

> Would a stream entrant never open the door and just feel intensely pressured to open it, or would they still occasionally open it if what was on the other side was particularly seductive? In the latter case, what would differentiate a stream entrant's relationship to the door from a puthujjanas?

A sotāpanna has the same understanding, but it hasn't sunk in to the same degree. They cannot open the worst doors again, since that requires full-on delusion, but they still need to make effort to maintain what for the Arahant is effortless.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by thereof_be_silent *2026-02-26 02:58:44* ### Two Questions on Paticcasamuppada

1. Does discerning the structure happen in a gradual way or in a sudden way?

It seems like it should be gradual because through the gradual training and restraint, i.e. as a basis is developed, one can see "more" of their craving, or rather see more of its scope. And thus one can see more of the dependency/simultaneity between the craving and the feeling it has as its basis.

But on the other hand, I suspect that **seeing** even a little of the dependence/simultaneity necessarily entails seeing the entire structure concretely.

Relatedly:

2. After being settled in the precepts at the bodily and verbal level, should one try to discern the simultaneity on each "instance" of craving, while also generally aiming for mental purity?

Or should one hold off until one is settled at the mental level, where the mind is dry enough that a single sentence single is sufficient?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-28 04:38:26*

1. Gradually (AN 8.19).
2. If you're keeping tabs on the mental states driving your actions (which implies not performing unwholesome ones) then you are already discerning the "structure" where it actually is.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-02-21 17:59:59*
practice question

Sometimes recently my mind has been trying to convince me that things which I have ascertained (to the best of my ability) are not motivated by an unwholesome intention are actually unwholesome, maybe by pointing to some surface-level grey area in which they may correspond to the boundaries set by the precepts. The problem here is not that the thought that accuses me of doing something unwholesome is unpleasant, which I know I just have to endure, but the fact that the thought appears is what makes me doubt whether I'm actually lying to myself or misjudging whether the action is unwholesome. Sort of like I feel if my actions were truly blameless, I wouldn't have these thoughts blaming me in the first place. It disturbs my clarity about my intentions, because the doubt and anxiety upsets my composure, and then I worry that that loss of composure points to the action itself actually being unwholesome. Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome? The thing is that, when I first started practicing virtue, I feel like I actually had these doubtful thoughts less, and that they have actually ramped up since my virtue has improved and become more consistent. Like, since I have actually become less capable of lying to myself, my mind accuses me of lying to myself more, if that makes sense? I am not sure if the fact that my mind is still moved by doubt and fear about somehow 'accidentally' doing something unwholesome points to a lack of internal clarity about never breaking the precepts that still needs to be developed, or if it is just a separate stage of fear/doubt that needs to be overcome on its own. Is this over-questioning your own virtue just another way that Māra ramps up the difficulty of the practice? (only half-joking here). I hope this makes sense

Sister_Medhini *2026-02-22 12:44:24*

Couple additional points to what Bhante Anīgha wrote:

> Is there any good way to know for certain that I'm not deceiving myself about whether something is unwholesome?

Yes, but not by clarifying and analysing it. Instead, by putting the non-acting out of pressuring mental state first, no exceptions. Everything else is secondary. Regardless of whether the past action was unwholesome or not, acting of of the current pressure in regard to it is never good.

Even if the past action was rooted in a degree of unwholesome that you over-

looked at the time, revolving around worry or doubt in regard to it cannot help prevent it or clarify it in future. It adds fuel to the very reason you would have acted unwholesomely to begin with.

In other words, by sufficiently including the pressure of doubt and worry, and not acting out of it *in the present*, you can know for certain that you are *currently* not deceiving yourself about what you are doing, and there is no other 'hidden' way to commit unwholesome actions, apart from giving in to this very same pressure. That is all you need to know.

> The doubt and anxiety upsets my composure, and then I worry that that loss of composure points to the action itself actually being unwholesome.

The loss of composure points to the present mental act of giving in, to at least some degree, to the doubt and the pressure to clarify. That these things arise as such just points to Māra being Māra, which is not your problem.

By the way - if you have read *Meanings*, there are also a couple of letters at the very end of the correspondance with Matthias that specifically address this type of issue.

Formal_Breath_2026

Thank you Ayye! I wrote this in response to Bhante Anīgha, but please feel free to share feedback on it if you wish as well: > I have been spending large chunks of my day making sure that my intention does not ever lean towards actually verbally lying or deceiving someone, so that what I do within that does not go against the spirit of the precept. But I have still been getting pressuring thoughts to make my behaviour conform more to *external* purity of virtue, even when I don't think it would make sense to do so, and my reluctance to do that makes me more anxious about the thoughts which tell me I could be breaking the precept — otherwise why would I have reluctance to conform to that external purity? But I think in this case, doing something to conform to that external purity and relieve the doubt and the pressure would be a form of giving in, so what I need to do is maintain the intention to never break the *actual* precept, and allow that to shed clarity on the wholesomeness of whatever intention I have within that boundary. Does that sound correct?

Is this the sort of thing you meant? I also had another thought, which is that given it seems the direction is pointing towards doubt, anxiety, and overclarification, that suggests that I am not *actually* trying to hide an unwholesome intention from myself, otherwise I feel like the pressure would rather go towards covering it up. I feel like one does not normally lie to themselves about an unwholesome intention while simultaneously having a lot of fear and apprehension about doing that unwholesome intention, although I suppose maybe that's theoretically possible if someone had enough muddledness at the time. Is this a useful train of thought?

Edit: Or perhaps this line of thought: > I also had another thought, which is that given it seems the direction is pointing towards doubt, anxiety, and over-clarification, that suggests that I am not *actually* trying to hide an unwholesome intention from myself, otherwise I feel like the pressure would rather go towards covering it up.

is just another way of giving into the doubt and worry. I suppose that if I do what you said, which is making sure that I don't ever *currently* act out of any pressure even on the level of thought (e.g. one driven by doubt), it will be impossible to 'accidentally' do something unwholesome. The losing my composure in regard to mental doubt is what would actually risk muddling my intentions

Edit 2: I have been applying what you said in regards to not giving into the mental pressure of doubt and it seems to have restored more clarity in regards to my intentions. The tendency is to try and clarify what I will do *in the future* which obscures whatever intention (i.e. doubt or anxiety) is present there *now*, so then I have to do what feels unnatural and ignore the desire to clarify what I will do in the future and restore the clarity in regards to the present intention. Maintaining that mental clarity in the present is what will help me act with more clarity when the future comes

Sister_Medhini *2026-02-23 06:47:17*

> The tendency is to try and clarify what I will do *in the future* which obscures whatever intention (i.e. doubt or anxiety) is present there *now*, so then I have to do what feels unnatural and ignore the desire to clarify what I will do in the future and restore the clarity in regards to the present intention. Maintaining that mental clarity in the present is what will help me act with more clarity when the future comes.

Exactly. Bhante Anīgha will probably reply as well, but I would say that this, and both the 'edit 1' and 'edit 2' parts above, are correct and what I was referring to. That it feels unnatural is precisely the point.

Without getting into the details, the first part before the edits sounded overall more leaning towards psychologisation which is, as you said, another way of giving in to the doubt.

It's not possible to overcome that tendency overnight by just determining 'I won't ever do this again'. When you catch yourself doing it, then you have the choice to keep going along with the grain of it, or not, as you described above. So the point is, as always, to become self-aware of what you are thinking and why you're thinking that way, not to try and stop thinking.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by upasakatrainee *2026-02-11 08:49:07 ###*

MN 43's Parato Ghoso Usage of right view,

Bhante u/Bhikkhu_Anigha, may I request some clarification on MN 43's reference to two conditions for the arising of right view: parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra.

My current understanding (which may be mistaken) is that this refers to the arising of right view as a conditionally dependent factor, not yet the irreversible Dhamma-eye associated with stream entry. My observations are as follows:

MN 43 presents parato ghoso and yoniso manasikāra as *conditions* (paccayā) for the arising (uppādāya) of right view. This suggests something dependent and contingent (arisen), rather than something already structurally irreversible — which is what the opening of the Dhamma eye (i.e capitalized Right View is). I also noticed that in your translation you have used the uncapitalized 'right view', so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry "then and there." But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND yoniso manasikāra is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Although verbs of "arising" (e.g., *cakkhum udapādi* in SN 56.11) are used for awakening itself, that alone doesn't seem to settle the issue. The decisive factor seems to be what is being described and how it functions structurally, rather than the morphology of the verb.

The suttas often speak of right view arising in a conditional sense prior to noble entry, whereas the Dhamma-eye or irreversible vision is described with additional language such as "fixed in destiny," "no longer liable," etc. MN 43 lacks that irreversible framing.

Based on these, it seems to me that MN 43 is pointing to the necessary conditions for right view to arise in a still-dependent sense, rather than directly describing the decisive and irreversible breakthrough. So in that sense, they are necessary but not sufficient conditions (sufficiency coming with the removal of what obstructs)

Is this distinction valid? Or should MN 43 instead be understood as referring directly to the irreversible establishment of Right View that marks entry into the noble individuals?

I would be grateful for correction if this framing is misguided. Thank you!

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-11 16:41:58*

> I also noticed that in your translation you have used the uncapitalized ‘right view’, so perhaps this was intentional to refer to something apart from the supramundane attainment?

No, that wasn’t intentional. I wouldn’t make such a distinction on my own, nor try to find a justification for it the Suttas.

I don’t see why right view having conditions implies that it is reversible. Arahantship depends on plenty of conditions, yet it is irreversible.

> If these two were sufficient for the decisive and irreversible vision, then hearing correct Dhamma and attending appropriately would seem to guarantee noble entry “then and there.”

Yes, it would. The catch is that one has no stable internal reference point to distinguish *yoniso* from *ayoniso*, nor the accuracy of an utterance, until after right view. At the same time, what needs to be done is clear: establishing the mind in virtue and abandoning passion for sensuality is what makes one’s attention *yoniso*. Hence the stock passage preceding the attainment of stream-entry.

> But the suttas elsewhere imply that right view can fail to arise even when the right Dhamma is heard AND yoniso manasikāra is present, due to resistance or remaining obstruction (e.g. The Buddha declaring that King Ajātasattu, had it not been for his patricide, would have in fact entered the stream)

Having killed his father meant that King Ajātasattu couldn’t have *yoniso manasikāra*, at least not sufficiently. Extending the right utterance of another—that all actions based on defilements are unwholesome and unjustifiable—to the right level (where nothing is excluded) will evoke in such a person a level of remorse that is impossible to bear. He had to continue regarding what he did was to some extent excusable (wrong view) in order to maintain his sanity.

It’s for the same reason that the mind needs to lose its passion for sensuality for right view to arise. While still being passionate for something, let alone pursuing it, the fact that one’s passion is actually the very source of one’s suffering cannot sink in. The mind will reject the right view because it has something against it that it needs to protect.

upasakatrainee

Very clear. Thank you, Bhante !

I had the following reflections based your clarification:

> establishing the mind in virtue and abandoning passion for sensuality is what makes one’s attention yoniso

I can extrapolate that this applies not only to sensuality (sensual passion) but to aversion as well — insofar as both are forms of *passion toward feeling*.

As long as something is still being protected (pleasant or unpleasant), yoniso cannot be complete. That makes yoniso far more existential and less technical than I had been subtly treating it.

> will evoke in such a person a level of remorse that is impossible to bear. He had to continue regarding what he did was to some extent excusable (wrong view) in order to maintain his sanity

This indicates that there was a wilful self-deception that was ongoing; which lies at the root of what prevents yoniso. It provides a good perspective on the importance of non-deception as an overarching guiding principle for any degree of progress; and consequently underscores the importance of the 4th precept — taking it all the way to its subtlest expression

> Having killed his father meant that King Ajātasattu couldn't have yoniso manasikāra, at least not sufficiently

Comparing this with the case of Angulimāla, who *was able* to establish yoniso manasikāra, despite his horrific acts, reinforces that patricide/matricide contradicts a much more foundational layer of mundane right view ("there is mother, there is father"), and therefore would require self-deception at a deeper structural level in order to preserve psychological coherence. That is why yoniso was a structural impossibility for Ajātasattu but not for Angulimāla, despite the greater gruesomeness of the latter's acts from a worldly lens.

Overall, this gives me added perspective on the subtlely of yoniso manasikāra. It clarifies that yoniso is not something one "approximates" or orbits around, but something that either fully extends or does not.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-12 07:57:02*

> I can extrapolate that this applies not only to sensuality (sensual passion) but to aversion as well — insofar as both are forms of passion toward feeling.

Yes, but not as a separate aspect. If you're truly undermining all your passions, aversion has no foothold whatsoever. Hence the Buddha often using the word "passion" (or "delight") to encompass every potential defilement.

> That makes yoniso far more existential and less technical than I had been subtly treating it.

Absolutely. Yoniso manasikāra is a result of the citta being tamed and pliable, not something anyone can do by following a protocol. Passion structurally carries ignorance.

Embarrassed-Box6857 *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Dear Bhante, once the preconditions for the right view have been in place for a long enough time(precepts, sense restraint, enduring cravings and the neutral feeling, context of ones situation as a whole and the peril of sensuality) one

wouldn’t specifically have to be enduring craving or be hearing/contemplating the dhamma the moment right view arises? Or am I mistaken?

Since the “utterance of another”, i.e the right instructions have basically been heard countless times by this point I assume that one wouldn’t necessarily be actively “trying” to get the right view.

Im asking this because I assume the preconditions I listed is the development of yoniso manasikara

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-12 08:02:14*

> Since the “utterance of another”, i.e the right instructions have basically been heard countless times by this point I assume that one wouldn’t necessarily be actively “trying” to get the right view.

In the sense of reflecting on what one has heard, no, not always. But it’s also not something you can preemptively decide.

When clarity about the practice is fading, you have to revisit the right instructions (mentally at least).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Seekfinderin *2026-02-09 23:38:53* ### Beauty, Ugliness, Danger in the Body

In the last weeks I was reading more and more Suttas and articles and listened to many talks and almost everything I read or listened to, and the more I did so, seemed to make sense and be very logical and convincing to me. But I have a very hard time to understand the way how you seem to look at the human body and why. I remember this Sutta, that is also quoted often in your talks, where apparently Buddha said about a princess or some girl that he would not touch her even with his feet, because, apparently that was so disgusting in his view, even though in the eyes of most others she was probably beautiful.

Then I hear you, when talking about the body, about it being that sack of flesh and blood and excrements and urine. I don’t understand that. It makes some sense to me and I am trying to reflect about it, that some things, actions, thoughts etc., that I consider desireable may not be so desireable from a more complete, neutral, clarified point of view. But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me. Because in fact and according to what I see this body is not that ugly, dirty, filthy thing. Yes, there is something like that within it, within its organs, but all that is quite in order, functions well, is surrounded by smooth skin, held together in that form, can move very elegantly and softly. When you talk about it, it sounds as if you are seeing a body when it is exploded on the floor like in a crime scene. When I reflect on this I don’t see why I should imagine something like

that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

Of course, if I would have such a negative view of the body, it would be much easier to restrain the senses and not desire to touch other bodies etc. But right now, to be honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

To get to the point: Maybe someone can explain to me how such a disgust for the body evolves and why? And why that may be necessary or a natural occurence on that path. I don't get it. While so many explanations convince me and help me withdrawing more and more, this particular area is very confusing to me.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-10 05:59:28*

> But in regard to this description of the body this feels to me as if you just try to look at it in this disgusted way for some reason by choice, and it seems to be very abstract to me.

Emphasizing ugliness is certainly a choice, yet no less so than emphasizing beauty is. It's just because in the beginning one is so used to (and pressured towards making) the latter choice that it feels like it happens on its own.

> When I reflect on this I don't see why I should imagine something like that as it is so far away from how the body of a living human being is usually appearing?

You don't need to, and that's not what the Buddha described. He said you reflect on the organs of "this very body" as you would be reviewing a sack containing different types of grains and beans. So rather than an abstract "bodies can become like that", it's "*my* body *already is* like this." And that is undeniable. It may feel *unnecessary* to think about it, but that's something else (and it's the pull towards delusion).

> But right now, to be honest, and please correct me, if I am wrong, it seems to me as if you just consciously cultivate such a disgust for the body in order to get rid of sensuality/sexual urges, without this having a basis in regular experience of human bodies?

If you reflect properly as above (rather than taking asubha as a mechanical "meditation object") it does have a basis in your own experience all the time. And that is why it would *uproot* sensuality, not just push it aside.

Though you may not realize it, you (*choose to*) relate to your own body as an instrument for pleasure all the time. Particular sensual desires are just the byproduct of that. Asubha is meant to change that deeper relationship with

the body. Replacing sensual thoughts with shock reactions changes nothing fundamental.

Seekfinderin

I will reflect on that, thank you.

I can see that of course, that there is also ugliness and that there are many not so nice and pleasant aspects about the body. * During birth, which is very bloody. * The body gets dirty fast and then stinks etc. * It is completely dependent on constant feeding and otherwise breaks down and dies. * It will break down sooner or later anyway, will loose all beauty to it no matter what you do at some point and will die. * It may get sick and all the potential for pain that comes with it etc. * Everyone has to defecate and urinate, sure.

But all of these things are things that were in one short moment or will happen at some point in the future etc. And yet factually what my sensuality actually delights in, assume some body of another being, while my senses delight in it, doesn't have all of that. It is far beyond this stage of being born, it is regularly cleaned and smells pleasant mostly, it does not defecate at that moment and does rarely so compared to all the time where it does not. It is not currently sick and broken down or in the process of dying.

It is true, in that moment I have no desire towards it. When the skin would be full of open wounds and the body has a unpleasant smell etc., yes, then there would be no desire towards it in me. But it hasn't currently.

It is also clear to me that every body will eventually fall apart and get sick and non-attractive etc., and that is also a reason why I cannot really fall in love with someone anymore, as I already see in them not only as what they now appear, but also what they once were and what or how they will become and sometimes this makes me sad, but more so it seems to make me more detached from them on an emotional level. So I think that I no longer crave for a relationship for instance, because I see the suffering in it and pretty much feel unable for such a thing now.

But it does not seem to diminish my passion/lust towards it on the physical level (I speak of thoughts, of the mental engagement with lust mostly) because only what is currently there matters then to my senses. I know in that moment that this will not last, this form will not remain to be so beautiful for me, but it does not bother me in that moment because I also know that even if this particular form, this particular body will not stay like that, there always will be others, there always will be a new, healthy body with that same heavenly smell and smooth skin and so on that my senses will find so attractive.

It also does not diminish my passion in that moment thinking about my own body and how it becomes more and more unattractive and old and falls apart, because it doesn't diminish or change the appearance of that other form in that moment that I could theoretically engage with, touch, smell etc.

I do try to live celibate, partially as an experiment to see what is to your teaching, because I want to see that pressure and if I can train to endure it, partially because I have no opportunity to have any sexuality with another person I find attractive anyway and because I do not want to masturbate. And at the moment I seem to have made some progress as the pressure is not as big as it was and it seems to be easier for me to interject before I act out of such a momentarily impuls, I feel it coming and can just say: "No, I do something else." But there are dreams and still that idea in the back of my head, that maybe someday I can engage in it deeply again with another person when this opportunity arises, even if the chances for this to happen, in my personal situation, is very small.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-10 16:42:36*

> But all of these things are things that were in one short moment or will happen at some point in the future etc.

The point is that asubha is not about future possibilities. The body can reach such levels of "shocking" unattractiveness in the first place because of the unattractive aspects (blood, flesh, waste-producing glands) that it already has *now,* while it is factually young, healthy, good-smelling, etc.

You need to recognize the unattractiveness *within* the beauty; otherwise you'll indeed just be covering up the good parts in order to fabricate a "dispassion" that is not even genuine and will not last.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by ConditionOwn3429 *2026-02-08 12:04:19*
Questions on Contemplating

Could you clarify what contemplating the danger in sensuality really means? I hear this flying around alot, but I have yet to fully grasp what it means. Does it require a prerequisite, like virtue and sense-restraint? And how do you actually, practically do it? It would be really helpful if you could also provide an example.

For context, I've been reading a section of The only way to jhana, chapter 8: The pleasure of boredom in this chapter, Ajahn says "Practically speaking, boredom is a good way to practise. People don't see boredom as an indicator, and certainly don't see delusion as an attitude that they cultivate, despite commitment to precepts, sutta study, and contemplation. " (p. 88) and "For example, if you decide to allow yourself to get bored: switch off your phone, close the doors and curtains, put away your books, switch off the television, don't do your meditation technique—then, it doesn't matter whether you sit, walk, stand or lay down—just abide in that non-activity. The mind will certainly be presenting you with something to do, which is fine—you don't need to try to get rid of those thoughts, you just don't act upon them" (p. 89). This is what I'm doing, and something that I've encountered along the way was

that I impulsively daydream, and I can’t control it. It’s not that I can’t resist the desire to daydream, the daydream in it of itself just appears without my consent.

Now how is this related to what I’m talking about? I’ve heard from one of the Hillside Hermitage videos that one should contemplate when pressured by “unwholesome states”. So how I see it is that:

- My daydreams are to entertain me when I’m bored

- Daydreaming is an unwholesome act (it contains unwholesome thoughts of desire and pleasure)

- You should contemplate when you’re pressured by unwholesome states

- You should contemplate on your daydreams.

So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream, but how do I do that? In the same chapter, I read “all you need to do is to not entertain it (the mind) and establish the context of the danger, if what it offers is unwholesome and sensual.” (p. 87) yes, but what does that mean? I don’t understand. “You can develop the perception of danger or the perception of abandoning in regard to those thoughts (of sensuality, ill-will) so that while the mind is presenting those thoughts of sensuality, you are not wanting them, and are abandoning them because they are dangerous” (p. 87) I’m not sure where to go from here.

I would appreciate it if you could clarify my question, or debunk some of my thinking. Thanks in advance.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-02-09 06:02:36*

> So I understand now that I should contemplate when I unwillingly daydream

If your bodily and verbal actions are contained by the precepts and not partaking in sensuality and ill-will anymore, then yes.

What you contemplate is the danger in any behaviors of sensual or hateful nature that your mind still delights in even though you have thoroughly given them up outwardly.

You don’t try to deny the potential gratification of those actions; you’re simply highlighting the drawbacks that the mind wants to look away from even though they are far greater in magnitude than the gratification.

The effect of that is not necessarily immediate. The momentum towards ignoring the danger (built up by careless behavior from before) has to wear away before the recognition of the danger feels palpable and the mind genuinely “accepts” it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Representative-Age18 *2026-01-27 19:10:50*
Questioning Hillside Hermitage based on the Suttas: “All the Defilements”, Sutta MN2

Foreword: I felt semi convinced after watching 20+ hours of HH videos, and I think they do have a lot of good points that deserve attention. There’s obviously a lot of intelligence, dedication and knowledge to be found here. Therefore I decided to take a deep dive into the Suttas to clearify my position. Here’s something I’d love to hear discussed:

In MN2: *All the defilements*, the buddha says: “Some defilements should be given up by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing.”

It does not say “All defilements should be given up by restraint and endurance”.

Now, here is the sentence that I would assume HH followers would really stick to:

“Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees, not for one who does not know or see”.

HH states that this means you have to be a Sottapanna.

The Buddha always, in the rest of the suttas, describe Sottapannas with words such as: “for one who has entered the stream”, “for a noble disciple”, “for one with the noble right view”. When clearly describing a sottapanna, he is never vague about it. There is not one example about this. The Buddha, as the AMAZING teacher he was, NEVER clearly described a sottapanna without using EXPLICIT words. I repeat, there is not ONE example of this. He is either totally explicit, or using diagnostic criteria. The Buddha is always very clear and upright in the Suttas, so it confuses me as to why he would describe a Sottapanna with vague terms like “for one who knows and sees”, which is so much more vague than simply “for one with the noble right view” or “for one who was entered the stream”. In the video on this Sutta by HH, he justifies it using his logic, but never once questions why the Buddha in this exact sutta is using vague wording, while every other time he speaks of Sottapanna, he uses clear, exclusive wording. Nyanamoli Thero makes the exact mistake that he warns about himself: he gets into the details of the logic that pertains to what he think is mentioned, but he forgets the peripheral context: that the Buddha is always clear and straightforward in his speech, not cryptic.

Secondly, he says “Mendicants, I say that the ending of defilements is for one who knows and sees(…)”. He does not say “The continuation of the ending of defilements is for the one who knows and sees”. It is also kind of paradoxical - why would he exclude the removal of defilements to Sottapannas only. It’s a general statement. So a person who is not a Sottapanna cannot start to end their defilements? The way I would interpret it is that the startingpoint in

the journey to begin ending your defilements begins with a rational mind, not swayed by emotions such as “I don’t want this to be true because of x,y,z”.

The common interpretation about “for one who knows and sees” (…) that application of irrational thoughts give rise to defilements (hope, prayer, not using logic, or just plain non-rational thinking), however, one who sees is someone who looks at reality rationally, logically and applying their mind in such a way. Ie. you are open to look at reality unbiased and logically. Not that you need to have supramundane insight into reality.

But let’s give HH the benefit of the doubt, and assume that what he really meant was that the prerequisite for removal of defilements using these 7 methods are only to be attempted by Sottapannas. Or we can give them the benefit of the doubt, however to a slightly smaller degree and say that “one who knows and sees” does mean sottapanna, without that actually making this a clear prerequisite in the sutta. It could definitely still mean “the total destruction of defilement is only attained after sottapanna”, that does not read the same as “these following methods will only work for sottapannas”.

Problem 1. Assumption by HH: “You have to be a Sottapanna to practice”some by seeing, some by restraint, some by using, some by enduring, some by avoiding, some by dispelling, and some by developing” (MN2) ” So you already have to be a Sottapanna to practice restrain and endurance, the exact methods that HH teach is the way to Sottapanna itself? How do you become a Sottapanna if you cannot apply senserestraint until after you have become a Sottapanna? HH clearly state that a prerequisite for using these 7 methods as means to lessen defilements, is already being a Sottapanna - so how do you become a Sottapanna then, without restrain, seeing, or endurance?

Problem 2. At the end of the first method proposed by the Buddha to remove defilements (Seeing) we have this statement: And as they do so, they give up three fetters: substantialist view, doubt, and misapprehension of precepts and observance of rites and rituals. These are called the defilements that should be given up by seeing.

So a sutta aimed at only Sottapannas is an instruction of how you can become a Sottapanna? Ehm, what?

Now, you can discuss “wise attention” and what it really means all you want, but that doesn’t take away from the context that this whole sutta doesn’t make sense at all if it is only aimed at Sottapannas. That’s the first argument. The second one is that the Buddha was always abundantly clear when he talked about a Sottapanna, never vague.

Just to make sure; the sutta also is not a linear progression, like you should have use seeing first, then restraint, then using etc. This is obvious, as you can’t do one without the other. You can’t get rid of the defilements using the method of seeing very well, while not restraining yourself at least a little bit

for example.

What MN 2 actually recommends (if we give the benefit of the doubt and call “knowing and seeing”=sottapanna)

MN 2 teaches:

- **All practitioners** must learn:
  - what to attend to
  - what not to attend to
  - which method fits which defilement
- **Without right understanding**, practice is often misapplied
- **(With supramundane right view**, practice becomes fully effective and irreversible So the sutta is:

—not a gated manual usable only after awakening.

Please enlighten me

Edit: you guys keep saying there’s right restraint (after sottapanna) and wrong restraint (befoe). However, it doesn’t change the fact that the Buddha, in this very sutta, also recommends the methods of abandoning and developing alongside restraint and endurance, not seperating them. He doesn’t say: do only restraint and endurance until you become sottapanna, then do the rest of the methods. He says: you use all the 7 methods here (including restraint and endurance, and including abandoning and dev), and you try your best, but none of them will work FULLY until you have right view. He DOES NOT tell you to only use restraint and endurance and that development can only be done after sottapanna.

Another good point:

By user: Edit: also, this part doesn’t make sense to me: “And what are the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding? Take a bhikkhu who, reflecting in light of the origin, avoids a wild elephant, a wild horse, a wild ox, a wild dog, a snake, a stump, thorny ground, a pit, a cliff, a swamp, and a sewer. Re-

flecting in light of the origin, he avoids sitting on inappropriate seats, walking in inappropriate neighborhoods, and mixing with bad friends—whatever wise fellow renunciates would take to be an unsuitable setting. For the influxes, trouble, and affliction that would arise in someone who abides without avoiding these things do not arise when they are avoided. These are called the influxes that should be abandoned by avoiding."

Why is either grasping of the sign of the mind or right view needed to avoid dangerous things? This seems like a part where yoniso as "rational" actually fits.

My view on this is that again, anything you do after yoniso will actually and effectively rid defilements - doesn't mean you should not practice before yoniso. So similar to how the buddha wants you to avoid a wild elephant, you should on the same level practice abandoning and developing. There's no prerequisite to avoid getting killed by elephant, and there's no prerequisite to practice abandonment and developing.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-28 05:09:15*

The distinction is between practicing restraint and endurance, which anyone can do in theory, and successfully *abandoning defilements* by doing so. A puthujjana can and has to practice restraint, but that restraint will itself be tainted by defilements as long as they're a puthujjana, so cultivating it further will not lead to Nibbāna. Hence it's not what is being described in the Sutta.

So, rather than taking restraint as a "method" that is already correct, a puthujjana would keep continually questioning their ideas about what restraint is (and you can only meaningfully upgrade your understanding of something if you're also doing it). That's how they would move closer to *yoniso manasikāra*.

The same point is found in AN 2.11:

> "There are, bhikkhus, these two powers. What two? The power of reflection and the power of development. And what, bhikkhus, is the power of reflection? It's when someone reflects: 'Misconduct of body, speech, or mind has a bad, painful result in both the present and the future.' Reflecting like this, they give up misconduct of body, speech, and mind, and develop good conduct of body, speech, and mind, keeping themselves pure. This is called the power of reflection.
>
> And what, bhikkhus, is the power of development? In this context, the power of development is the power of the trainees. **For relying on the power of a trainee, one gives up passion, aversion, and delusion.** Having given up passion, aversion, and delusion, one doesn't do anything unwholesome, or engage in anything harmful. This is called the power of development. These are the two powers."

Representative-Age18

Yes, that restraint will be tainted by defilements, just like abandoning and developing. The Buddha still encouraged this method for “puthujjana” in this sutta, as there is not preliminary for anyone to practice the 7 methods; only a distinction about whether it will lead to progress towards sottapanna OR full distruction of defilements.

This sutta makes it abundantly clear that abandoning and developing is also recommended for puthujjana’s. As far as I can see, there’s no logical way around it unless maybe you did some serious mental gymnastics, but the Buddha’s teaching don’t require you to do serious mental gymnastics, it’s always straight forward.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-28 06:00:23*

> This sutta makes it abundantly clear that abandoning and developing is also recommended for puthujjana’s.

It explicitly says that a puthujjana fails at practicing yoniso manasikāra.

Representative-Age18

Yoniso m, also applies to restraint/ endurance. It applies to all 4 right effort modes: restraint, abandonment, development and endurance

So yes it says you’ll fail at abandoning and development, it also says you will fail at restraint and endurance, it doesn’t say you don’t do any of them. But they will all lead to right view first, not directly destroy defilements - that, they’ll do after right view

Edit: regardless, yoniso m does not equal sottapanna really. It’s largely what leads to it, but not commonly seen as the same thing

Regardless, you don’t have a strong enough position here to tell me or anyone to stop practicing meditation (partly abandoning and developing) and that it’s worse than not practicing at all, like you said in my other post. Your method is nice, I like it, but it’s not for everyone. You guys have a lot of good stuff, and your view is beautifully contributing to todays buddhism!! I don’t understand why you got to be to harsh and discarding of things the buddha obviously taught. So please stop telling people straight up to stop meditating. Have some humility, please. It’s very dangerous what you’re doing.

Also, regarding avoiding: does avoiding a wild elephant to not get killed also ONLY work and is it only supposed to be applies after right view? Haha

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-28 07:00:11*

> it also says you will fail at restraint and endurance, it doesn’t say you don’t do any of them.

We’re not saying that either, as you have yourself noted.

> Regardless, you don't have a strong enough position here to tell me or anyone to stop practicing meditation (partly abandoning and developing)

You're misunderstanding the point. What you're describing as "meditation" is not abandoning and developing to begin with, neither before nor after right view. It's simply distraction. So the need to give up of meditation techniques has nothing to do with enforcing right view as a prerequisite. It's to do with at least *trying* to practice abandoning and developing, which is how you could eventually attain right view.

> Also, regarding avoiding: does avoiding a wild elephant to not get killed also ONLY work and is it only supposed to be applies after right view?

As a means of abandoning defilements, it does.

Representative-Age18

Me abandoning aversion with mindfulness and cultivating metta is abandoning and developing. Based on all of this discussion, I don't really think I've misunderstood anything. My view is in line with every other teacher I watched sutta study by, and the commentaries.

Abandoning unwholseome states and cultivating wholesome states is the essence of those two, it's abundantly clear

My point: none of these methods will rid defilements completely unless done with yoniso, but that doesnMt mean you shouldnt do it. The elephant example makes that clear. Before and after yoniso, you should do all 7, not only restraint and endurance, not only avoiding getting killed by an elephant, not excluding abandoning and dev.

Anyways, I've said all my points and I've said more than enough on this. It's taking too much time away from my life now, and I gotta put the computer away, so I'll leave it at this: thank you engaging in discussion with the lay community. I highly appreciate and regard the effort to actually speak to us directly. And thank you for the discussion. May you all be well, peaceful and attain true happiness, with metta - Erik

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-28 07:33:36*

> Anyways, I've said all my points and I've said more than enough on this. It's taking too much time away from my life now, and I gotta put the computer away, so I'll leave it at this: thank you engaging in discussion with the lay community. I highly appreciate and regard the effort to actually speak to us directly. And thank you for the discussion. May you all be well, peaceful and attain true happiness, with metta - Erik

Sure, I also don't think this is going anywhere.

> none of these methods will rid defilements completely unless done with yoniso, but that doesnMt mean you shouldnt do it.

For the record, our point is that you are describing as "wholesome" *is* ayoniso in its very nature, whether one is a puthujjana or not. So "doing it with yoniso" is an inherent contradiction.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by ghfph *2026-01-25 06:21:28* ### Essays in book format?

I read awhile ago that Bhikkhu Anigha's essays may be published in a paper book format.

Is there any news on this? I'm planning to rid myself of unnecessary technology (laptop and ereader), for kusala reasons, but would still like to re-read Venerable Anigha's essays.

Can I provide any help in proofreading or editing while I still have a laptop?

Thanks,

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-26 05:17:13*

I'm working on the book currently.

As for getting rid of technology, it's worth questioning your reasons for doing that. If it's because you can't control yourself and keep breaking the precepts when you have access to it, then it's fine to get rid of it until that's no longer the case. But if it's not that, it might be rooted in trying to avoid the practice in the name of "peace" (not having to face doubt regarding your intentions for using technology).

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by CutnSkratch317 *2026-01-22 21:28:22* ### Question on "Definitive Guide to Seeing Your Mind" Dhamma Talk

Venerables and HH community,

Thank you for sharing this video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hd9WZzxqAkE). I found it extremely informative and clarifying for my practice.

I have a question regarding Ajahn's point that one must first understand the signs of the mind by enduring, and that only once the mind is understood can "the King be fed" — otherwise, one is simply acting out of aversion or greed for a different mind state.

Here is how I currently understand this, and I would appreciate correction if I am mistaken:

Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (as an example) to counterbalance the anger based on that understanding - rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still be considered a subtle form of aversion?

I can see how, through understanding the mind and its inclinations, abandoning it becomes easier on its own. At the same time, it seems that knowing how an angry mind operates and inclines might make it skillful to cultivate a counter-state, if such cultivation is appropriate.

Thank you very much for your time and for all that you offer to the community.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-24 09:01:03*

> Suppose an angry mind has arisen. I recognize that anger is present, and through practice I understand the dangers and consequences of an angry mind. In that case, is it appropriate to intentionally cultivate mettā (for example) to counterbalance the anger on the basis of that understanding, rather than out of a desire to get rid of the anger? Or would this still amount to a subtle form of aversion?

The implication that cultivating mettā is a separate undertaking from recognizing the presence of anger, etc., suggests that it remains a form of aversion or management. Even if you do not think of it as trying to get rid of the anger, you are still just “turning the page” on it rather than addressing its causes, much like distracting yourself with a worldly unrelated activity. That does nothing to alter the underlying tendency toward aversion when attention is *not* being closely managed, which is precisely the only time that counts as a criterion for development (AN 5.200).

Mettā is the natural result of the absence of aversion. It is no more contrived than the friendliness you already experience towards people for whom you have no ill-will (which are the majority) By contrast, the common, misguided fabrication of mettā requires ignoring certain unpleasant aspects and selectively focusing on pleasant ones, and for as long as that’s at all required, you’re still just continuing to take ill-will for granted.

Hence, the ordinary friendliness of an undeveloped puthujjana toward *some* people is actually far closer to genuine *mettā* than what many Buddhists today take it to be. The difference between ordinary friendliness and the liberation of mind through *mettā* is simply that the latter is boundless/infinite. That’s the same as saying that it involves no effort or even anchor, since anything conditioned by an activity implies the possibility of its absence under certain circumstances, hence it’s not boundless. Mettā depends only on the absence of something, namely ill-will, and that absence is universal when the mind has been well cultivated.

Representative-Age18

This sutta 5.200 contains the exact method that HH argues against, without listing any criterias or prerequisites for practicing for example loving kindness. Obviously the first factor of the noble eightfold path is Right View, but it seems like the only prerequisite to progressing on the path is a mundane right view, not Sottapanna. I'm wondering how you interpret AN 5.200 as containing or listing a criteria or warning to not do the method listed in the sutta before sottapanna is attained.

Another question: HH sees metta/ compassionas non-ill will and non-cruelty, instead of friendliness and compassion. Then why did the buddha decide to teach anyways? Wouldn't the decision to teach come out of the positive feeling of compassion, not non-cruelty?

edit: I'm being devils advocate here. I mostly agree with you guys on an intellectual level, although I haven't seen clear evidence in the suttas myself. Perhaps you could point me in the correct direction.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-24 16:50:27*

> This sutta 5.200 contains the exact method that HH argues against,

Where? It talks about mettā, sure, but it doesn't vindicate the modern interpretations of what that means, which is what we criticize.

What I intended to highlight with that Sutta is that the actual escape from ill-will is when the mind doesn't want to go there even if you tried to send it there. Whereas the modern practices revolve around holding back the mind from what it still prefers by fabricating the opposite, without ever addressing the causes for why it in principle *could* want to go towards ill-will (or sensuality).

Representative-Age18

Now, reading it very carefully, I see that it's not actually; there's ill will, thus the monk attends to non-ill will and the mind leaps forth into it.

It more like, when there's ill will, the mind naturally puts it down, but if there's good will, the mind leaps forth.

I agree that trying to use wholesome as a means of controlling the unwholesome, is just clinging.

I do have another concern about your method on a technical level, not overall philosophy, as I think it is sound.

This is what I believe can quickly happen with non-resistance, non-doing, endurance methods: We understand that aversion to discomfort is the problem, but that we are supposed to not resist it. We end up mindlessly "thinking" and never really get objective perspective, it's just a perpetual thinking "Aversion", "I'm supposed to not let this aversion take over" "Now I'm controlling" "oh no I

shouldn't control" "ok stop controlling" "ok allow even that to be", and maybe it stops. Also aversion becomes the center of gravity, like we know aversion is the problem, so we automatically start 1. subconsciously looking for aversion 2. We start identifying (clinging) to aversion. We end up kinda chasing displeasure to solve our aversion, but we are now identified to some extent to aversion.

I'm not arguing for a meditation object that we should cling to, but I do believe that in order to not drift off into identification with phenomena (aversion), like the mind usually does when not watched, we need a point of reference from which we watch all arising phemomena. For example: I can feel peaceful while feeling quite a lot of pain IF I stay mindful, ardent and fully aware, fully comprehending what is going on. However, if I just drift into the pain/aversion, I feel like I quickly identify with it and sink into more aversion. My wholesome qualities quickly reduce if I just "let go" into the abyss, hoping that my aversion will go away if I let it be and do nothing. I'm not saying I should "change" or run away from aversion, just watch it from a reference perspective.

This is my biggest caviat with HH. Please let me know if I misunderstood something. This is what I got from watching about 10 hours of HH talks.

I agree that going to exclusive attention on the breath early is just a means to escape; however, the Buddha did teach Kāyānupassanā (mindfulness of the body) early, and I think this may be the reason. Kaya means body and anupassana means persistent seeing. The buddha tought anapanasati like at least several weeks, but probably several months before he tought anapanasati, but he usually always tought mindfulness of the body very early on, then the rest of the 4 foundations.

The way I see it is that you use the clear comprehension of the body, and then from that you proceed onto the other 3, which culminates in clear comprehension of citta (sottapanna), then after that you watch the summation of the 4: the breath.

Edit: Just one more example, if, when walking for example, can I intentionally keep the body in the peripheral field of awareness *while* discerning the feelings, mind, dhammas.

It just seems so helpful to have a point of reference to allow the mind to return to

So in my mind it would be, for formal meditation as an example:

1. I sit down, ardent and fully aware I know that I'm breathing
2. Whenever a feeling or thought arises, I discern that, without being too absorbed into the thoughts that I fully lose peripheral awareness of the breath, without trying to remove that state, allowing it to stay for as long as it has to. So really, it's about not "forgetting" the breath, not clinging

> onto it, thinking that some type of trance will lead me to understanding, that's obviously kind of ridiculous

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-24 18:11:21*

> I agree that trying to use wholesome as a means of controlling the unwholesome, is just clinging.

That's not quite the point. The modern interpretation of mettā is just a cover-up, and cover-ups are themselves unwholesome. It's replacing ill-will with delusion, which is like switching the side of a cube you're facing while the cube remains equally close to your face.

> This is what I believe can quickly happen with non-resistance, non-doing, endurance methods: We understand that aversion to discomfort is the problem, but that we are supposed to not resist it. We end up mindlessly "thinking" and never really get objective perspective, it's just a perpetual thinking "Aversion", "I'm supposed to not let this aversion take over" "Now I'm controlling" "oh no I shouldn't control" "ok stop controlling" "ok allow even that to be", and maybe it stops. Also aversion becomes the center of gravity, like we know aversion is the problem, so we automatically start 1. subconsciously looking for aversion 2. We start identifying (clinging) to aversion. We end up kinda chasing displeasure to solve our aversion, but we are now identified to some extent to aversion.

That's what happens when even what we're describing is still being implemented as a mechanical technique. That tendency might take time to calm down, and those considerations aren't of much value anyway unless you're already fully steadied in the eight precepts. If you're not, you're not going to clearly see what any defilement is no matter how hard you try.

> For example: I can feel peaceful while feeling quite a lot of pain IF I stay mindful, ardent and fully aware, fully comprehending what is going on. However, if I just drift into the pain/aversion, I feel like I quickly identify with it and sink into more aversion.

Right, and the fact that the latter can still happen means that the mind is not being developed. No amount of time of cultivating such "mindfulness" will remove the need for itself. It's just learning how to cope, however successfully and skillfully, and never removing the causes for disturbance. In fact it makes the problem worse; if after getting used to that you have to face discomfort without crutches, you will be even less able to do so than before. Hence the Buddha said that a person who attains wrong liberation through wrong view … wrong samādhi is *worse* off on that account. It's not a "transitional stage" or a "skillful means." It's a complete deviation that requires you to unlearn everything you learned.

Representative-Age18

So you're straight up telling me (a layperson who is more or less completely forced to not be able to keep all 8 precepts) that there literally just isn't any way for me to practice Dhamma? I hope you're extremely confident in this view, because if you're mistaken, you're demotivating thousands of laypeople from practicing meditation / Dhamma practice.

Meditation practice has been insanely liberating for me, and I've made meaningful progress and have become a more peaceful person, who's kinder and with way more wholesome qualities then before, and I've been following 5 precepts, ocassionally 8 on retreats.

I have a job that prevents me from avoiding entertainement, although I never indulge in it on my own, I work with people who have disabilities, and a part of my job is taking them to do meaningful acitivites such as going to the movies etc. That's their choice, not mine. I could eat before noon, but it would be incredibly impractical, instead I have a small eating window because I'd like to eat with my family/ people I work with. I also have a girlfriend, and although I never self-pleasure, and rarely have sexual intercourse, I do do that because I feel obligated due to having a significant other.

You're essentially telling me that on account of that, I cannot even attain Sottapanna, and even that is contradicting the Buddha, as thousands of laypeople who indulged in sex, entertainement etc etc, did attain stream entry.

In your view, from what I interpret, I'm better off just giving up meditation practice, unless I can follow all 8 precepts and probably also live in calm environment.

You also imply that unless 8 precepts are kept, doing kind acts (metta) etc is only delusion because you're just covering up your discomfort. Therefore you're also implying that a layperson wouldn't even gain anything real from doing nice acts, smiling to people, being a kind person in general. All you need to do is NOT be bad, indulgent etc.

Are you telling me that laypeople essentially just can't do anything at all to progress in Dhamma, or am I way off here?

I'm gonna admit, I'm a bit upset by this. Yes, my ego is under threat here, for sure, and I'm reacting. But I have so much respect for Hillside Hermitage that I want to understand fully

This is what happens to me:

- "Non-doing" becomes looping thought
- Aversion becomes the center of gravity
- Discernment collapses into self-monitoring
- The mind *does* identify with aversion

Your response is completely without compromise for laypeople.

So please, what would you suggest for someone who only follows 5 precepts, one some days 7, a few days 8? Because now it just sounds like: 8 precepts or nothing.

I would argue that it's more wholesome to view and not act on feelings from the safety/ clarity of an object, although it may not lead to full arahantship, then just completely give up

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-24 18:56:23*

> You're essentially telling me that on account of that, I cannot even attain Sottapanna, and even that is contradicting the Buddha, as thousands of laypeople who indulged in sex, entertainement etc etc, did attain stream entry.

The Buddha did say that such activities are an obstruction to both right view and right *samādhi*. He also listed things that need to be given up in order to practice *satipaṭṭhāna*, and the things you mention are covered by the items in that list (AN 6.118). Elsewhere he said one can't progress in the Dhamma while maintaining delight in sensuality.

> In your view, from what I interpret, I'm better off just giving up meditation practice, unless I can follow all 8 precepts and probably also live in calm environment.

Yes, you should give up the meditation you've been doing so far and anything that resembles it because it's actively taking you even further away from the right samādhi and peace. Giving it up will show you how your mind actually isn't tamed; how it still resists and craves for things just as strongly, if not worse, when you stop managing the scenery internally.

As for the eight precepts, it's not all or nothing.

First of all it's about being honest to yourself regarding what the goal is, i.e., freedom from craving, and the fact that you can't claim to be practicing towards that goal while you still engage in obvious acts of craving. That's probably not going to be all that obvious if you've been following contemporary teachings, and the precepts need to be supported by that simple but important recognition to be effective.

With that perspective, even though you might not be formally committed to the eight precepts all the time, there will be a lingering sense of shame each time you intentionally break them and remember your desire to train your mind, and that will allow you to grow in the precepts as quickly as you can handle. For some people that's overnight, for others it takes longer.

If you're not choosing entertainment yourself then that's not really a concern.

YakshaUK *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

> That's not quite the point. The modern interpretation of mettā is just a cover-up, and cover-ups are themselves unwholesome. It's replacing ill-will with delusion, which is like switching the side of a cube you're facing while the cube remains equally close to your face.

Isn't this the difference between cetovimutti and paññavimutti, insofar as the latter involves coming to a deep understanding of why clinging to something (in this case, ill-will) is unproductive, leading to one relinquishing the habitual clinging to it; while the former involves fabricating a habitual non-clinging to that ill-will, in order to come to the experiential understanding that clinging to ill-will is unproductive?

i.e. tranquility preceding clarity, and clarity preceding tranquility as two noted different trajectories to the same end.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-26 05:32:46*

That's a widespread misunderstanding.

If you have to shield and control your mind to prevent unwholesome reactions, it is not even temporarily liberated or composed. The need for suppression or redirection is itself a product of the hindrances. If that feels calming, it will be the same kind of "calm" produced by sensuality, which also depends on averting attention from what is unpleasant. Thus, it's wrong calm.

The notion that *samatha* can be developed independently of understanding is refuted by Suttas like AN 6.73 and AN 9.41.

> in order to come to the experiential understanding that clinging to ill-will is unproductive?

This supposed "experiential understanding" never actually comes. Anyone who relies on these practices neither has nor will reach a point where defilements cannot arise without them. That's because they are not just tangential; they actively manifest the same problem.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by ToLazyToPickName *2026-01-22 17:33:18*
Why is business/trading in meat & living beings Wrong Livelihood?

If buying & eating meat is not wrong action, why is trading in meat & living beings wrong livelihood?

A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets, why is that wrong livelihood but consuming the cooked meat or buying/having the pet is not wrong action?

I don't see how there is wrong intention in the livelihood of being a meat cooker or pet supplier. Maybe the meat cooker is encouraging more people

to kill animals and the pet supplier is encouraging crueling towards animals? But then why isn't the end consumer also doing that?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-24 04:49:33*

> A cook who make a living off of cooking meat, a grocery store cashier, or a pet store owner who makes a living off of selling pets

Only the last one is wrong livelihood. Cooking meat and being a cashier at a general grocery store are too far removed from the act of killing to matter.

The issue is how gaining a living from these things carries a welcoming attitude towards the acts of killing and, with pets, undesired imprisonment. Even when you're not the one physically perpetrating either, internally your intentions are pointing in that direction to a degree simply by working in those industries.

With weapons and intoxicants, you'd be condoning the intended usage of those things by selling them (though not if you're a cashier where those are among many of the items sold and customers take them without your involvement).

Some people think that in buying meat you are also condoning killing, but that's a fabricated connection and not true in any sense that's relevant for the training of the mind. You can totally maintain the attitude that you would never intentionally kill a living being or encourage another to do so, even to save your own life, despite buying and consuming meat. That attitude is what you have to cultivate, and abstaining from meat as a rule contributes nothing to that per se. It usually takes away from it by distracting you.

The Buddha could've easily made at least monks vegetarian and thereby prevented a lot of meat purchasing. But not only did he not have that initiative; he explicitly refused when asked by Devadatta. It would've cemented a wrong view about what virtue is.

ToLazyToPickName

I'm still having trouble understanding why a job of a cook who cooks meat or a cashier who sells meat is too far removed from killing to matter. To me, it seems like by relying on the death of animals to continue for their livelihood of selling or helping to sell meat, their intentions point in the direction of killing or wishing killing to continue.

Which jobs in the meat industry would be included in wrong livelihood besides the job of doing/commanding the killing? Would the cooked meat shop owner or the grocery store owner that sells meat be included in wrong livelihood?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-26 04:34:51*

> To me, it seems like by relying on the death of animals to continue for their livelihood of selling or helping to sell meat

Because unless they're working directly with a butcher, the connection is abstract. They wouldn't have to be open to killing or encouraging another to kill in order to do it.

> Which jobs in the meat industry would be included in wrong livelihood besides the job of doing/commanding the killing?

It depends on the closeness of the association. If the job involves any dealings with the people who do the killing, it would be wrong livelihood. Not because you're explicitly telling them to kill, but because there is automatically going to be a sense of cooperation.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Formal_Breath_2026 *2026-01-16 18:22:33*
Beautiful and Ugly

I have heard Ajahn Ñānamoli say several times about how the ugly is a more fundamental context than the beautiful, and I was thinking about how to understand this concretely. What I have arrived at is that the ugly is more fundamental because that is exactly how sensuality is there at all — if things were more beautiful than ugly, it would just be a matter of avoiding the ugly; there would be no drive to go towards the beautiful. But it is the interplay between the signs/features of the beautiful and the broader context of the ugly — and the resulting *pressure* to engage with the beautiful — that makes sensual being (kāmabhava) what it is as opposed to a mere pleasant abiding (rūpabhava). This is why sensuality, being driven by that pressure to get away from the ugly, is always unwholesome, whereas material states (Jhānas) can be experienced wholesomely. This is also why sensuality is insatiable and unsatisfactory, as the ugly is always there 'waiting' as the broader context whenever the less fundamental beauty runs out. Similarly, if you were put in harsh enough conditions, you would start finding sensual appeal in less and less pleasant things, like an animal that enjoys eating filth. But when you develop the theme that whatever beauty in sensuality there is is only there because the broader context of the ugly gives it its appeal, it all becomes ugly and loses its pressure, and ironically that is what ultimately brings peace. The ugly is only a problem relative to the value you place in beauty, but when it's all ugly, it becomes basically neutral. The more I think about it, the more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

nanassaka

There is no experience without the experience of this body. And this body is inherently repulsive/ugly, so anything else that follows from it cannot be less so. It is by thinking that the things you perceive through the body are more fundamental than the body itself that you delude yourself into believing

you can experience “beautiful objects” outside this body. Beautiful exists as beautiful, but as fundamentally inseparable from ugly. So taking up ownership of beautiful means taking up ownership of ugly simultaneous with it. The ugly is not “in” the beautiful, but rather, its the other side of it. And you will never see this for as long as your attention is focused on the “particulars” of your experience, while not seeing the fact that the “source” of your attention is where asubha is. A-subha is a negation of subha - it is more “general” than it (for me to negate theism, theism first needs to be; for there to then be atheism, as a negation of the present theism). So perception of foul-ness is the perception which “encapsulates” the perception of beautiful, and stands for it’s significance as a whole. It “includes” it as it’s larger context. Thus it “changes direction” and becomes “less foul” instead of beautiful. So you need to see the “larger context” to things you can attend to particularly through your attention

The mere presence of a feeling—a mood, its significance, its context—is extremely disgusting and repulsive in and of itself, because there is nothing more “rotten” and skewed than taking ownership of that which you cannot own; tying your existence to that which is factually impermanent. The mere presence of perceptions, of feelings, of intentions in general—of your own mind—is already utterly disgusting and repulsive. This is why the Buddha said that “even an ounce of existence is more foul than excrement”: the mere implications of any kind of ownership are *a*lready asubha because of that The presence of any thing whatsoever is already asubha, then what to say of this body, of food, of filth, of this table, bed, chair, and so on?

The “ugliness” of things is not in particular things, but in the fact that they have arisen, and that’s full stop (you do not need to see how they have arisen, why they have arisen, in what way or in what matter they are manifested; the fact that they have arisen, means that they must be automatically seen as asubha to that extent). 8th jhana is equally as disgusting as experience of sensuality, to the extent that ownership of the experience is present (but jhana is wholesome to the extent it provides “relief” from a coarser form of sensuality)

So seeing a very beautiful countryside view (or a very beautiful sight of the sky in the morning) should already be seen as asubha to that extent. I found that matter is usually disgusting in and of itself and that having sense-experiences generally is, they somehow “resist” you and “harass” you merely by being there, by having arisen before-hand; you already know that you cannot “access” that matter or make it yours in any way (matter is not liable to you, but you are liable to matter; kama bhava, likewise, it must be said, will always come within “rupa” bhava. This simply refers to the phenomenological nature of your experience, and not necessarily to some cosmological realms. Your experience of sensuality is always inseparable from the experience of matter, but somehow “endowed” with an “aspect of eternity” to it. Every act of sen-

sual enjoyment provides “permanent” and “infinite” pleasure, the experience of time is “relative” in this sense; but it is enough to find something more general than the experience of sensuality (i.e of matter being there) to see how fleeting it actually is from that new relative viewpoint of things)

Likewise, you are not seeing that any experience whatsoever is asubha to that extent. The experience of “peace” is disgusting because it is already felt. Even the experience of “jhana” is “harassing”; but it does provide a factual liberation to the extent it provides relief from coarse forms of sensuality. Feeling my body touch this chair, feeling my hands, feeling the cold breeze outside (hearing sounds, seeing sights, etc) are generally very much so “harassing” and “asubha” experiences due to the way in which they are “material”, in the way they “resist” you. Sartre seems to have had a similar experience in Nausea too

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-17 16:59:29*

The implication here that “jhāna is a subtler form of sensuality” is wrong. Jhāna definitionally is the complete cessation of sensuality (through dispassion, not replacement of objects).

There’s no good reason to extend the word “sensuality” to everything.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-17 17:15:00*

> The more I think about it, the more it seems to me that this interplay between the signs of the beautiful, and the broader context of the ugly, are what make up the entirety of human existence, and developing that context is also how one can surmount it.

Yes, exactly—granted one has stopped acting on desire for the beautiful no matter how invisible its more fundamental ugliness is.

The disgusting nature of your own body (the contemplation of organs often given in the Suttas) is the most acute and inescapable type of ugliness, but the principle extends to everything that you wouldn’t want to look at because it would ruin your enjoyment/anticipation of something pleasant. Anything of that nature is by default more fundamental, since it’s what stands out when desire isn’t there to obscure it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Embarrassed-Box6857 *2026-01-15 11:04:55* ### Practice advice

Hi everyone,

Looking for some guidance and correction regarding my practice. I have been living a semi-monastic life for the past year (seclusion, simplicity, minimal stimulation) and on the 8 precepts.

I’ve been practicing seriously for about a year overall(used to meditate earlier from mantra to open awareness or “do nothing” meditation), but the last 1-2 months have been much more endurance based, basically dropping my meditation completely .

Current practice:

I have been at a monastery for about 50 days now and my main practice is avoiding acting out of cravings, aversion etc as much as possible. The days are often neutral/flat, I am fairly calm and used to living a restrained life without seeking much relief or stimulation.

What I notice changing after endurance :

• Cravings are weaker and less convincing

• Much greater tolerance of boredom, neutrality and less emotional reactivity overall

• Less interest in pleasure, anticipation, or planning

• Can be awake and inactive for long periods without panic

At the same time, there’s dryness, grief for the past, and uncertainty. Relief feels largely unavailable, because i am not seeking it(yet at some level i still want it)but not in an urgent way, just a constant “ahh that would be nice”. You could say a continuous dissatisfaction throughout.

I know endurance is not sufficient for right view/stream entry, and I’m unsure how to integrate contemplation correctly. So here are some questions to things I am trying to discern.

- How do I know whether I’m truly “letting things endure” versus just spacing out or passively waiting?

Im currently “aware” of my experience in a general sense without getting too absorbed in things. Its hard to discern whether I intentionally feed thoughts or fantasise(though my fantasies and interest in them has greatly reduced)its more like I let them do thier thing while I just “watch them”. I still get fooled with the content from time to time and I can feel the confinement Ajahn talks about- everywhere my attention goes the thoughts etc follow and there is no “escape”. I am not trying to move my attention to avoid them or anything. This would be enduring on the right level?

- Ajahn often emphasizes understanding the context (body sitting, feelings enduring) rather than content.

When I set the context to be mindful of my posture for example, i am supposed to bring up the knowledge that “ I am sitting”- which i am aware of in the moment- however this knowledge is just a thought which im attending to, which wouldn’t be the actual “body”. And same with when i “recognise” i lost

the context of the body, i will automatically think “oh i forgot about sitting”. But thats also just a thought. As I understand this way I fail to even set the context in the first place and am just playing around with sense objects. How do i work with this?

- Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc? At times mind does takes on these topics(not to avoid anything specifically) and it’s not just on an intellectual level, I am definitely able to feel the implications of my contemplation. But im still trying to discern when its appropriate, how often to do so etc.

For sense pleasures , ex- longing for something, how do i reflect on the danger in that? The danger must be independent of the content and of sense pleasures as a whole, or specifically relating to the thought? I am still at the stage where I am just enduring and not steering the mind in the right direction towards dispassion with sense pleasures and making it learn for itself. Sometimes thoughts like “this is impermanent” or other stock phrases will arise, not to push the longing away(or it could be and im mistaken) but as I understand these are still surface level and aren’t actually talking directly to the citta. Any advice for this?

Thank you for any guidance you’re willing to offer.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-16 05:11:52*

> Should I reflect on danger/drawbacks, impermanence, etc?

Yes, that should be the main effort. It sounds like you’ve become habituated to the precepts and restraint externally, but without the certainty that your mind wouldn’t return to those things even if you wanted it to. The only relief that’s not unwholesome comes from that certainty, and it’s cultivated by clarifying the danger of what you’re already disengaged from.

Don’t try to contemplate the danger in sensuality in some abstract sense; just clarify the danger in returning specifically to breaking the precepts. By not doing so the mind still remains open to that possibility even if it never comes up, and that’s why it wouldn’t be at ease. Unease doesn’t require explicit confirmation that enemies are coming; it’s enough not to know with full certainty that they’re *not* coming. Factually, they might all be defeated, but unless you *know* that, you will still be subtly anxious.

To be clear, you’re not looking for some positive announcement from your mind that the precepts will never be broken. You simply see that when you bring up the intention never to engage in misconduct again, resistance and reservations no longer arise. That means the citta is obedient to that extent (the internal enemies are defeated).

Embarrassed-Box6857

Thank you for your reply Bhante, I will reflect on the danger of breaking the

precepts. The only things I still occasionally give in to or have not 100% said no to in terms of never giving in for the rest of my life are using Dhamma as a soothing tool(especially for doubt) and to relax/enjoy, likewise with food.

About my other questions, about endurance on the “right level” and the body posture context, am I on the right track? And likewise for finding the line with proliferation of thoughts and mere observation.

Thank you once again Bhante. Your help is greatly appreciated

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-16 11:11:10*

> The only things I still occasionally give in to or have not 100% said no to in terms of never giving in for the rest of my life are using Dhamma as a soothing tool(especially for doubt) and to relax/enjoy, likewise with food.

Sure, but what I’m saying is beyond merely not breaking them. A lot of people haven’t broken any precepts for decades and they’re nowhere near the right practice. What I’m describing is the factual joy that will be felt when having not broken the precepts and become accustomed to them, you mentally establish them as an immovable context that permeates everything you do, say, or think. You actively highlight to yourself the benefit of staying within those boundaries, and the unassailable freedom from danger that it entails. “Unassailable” because nothing and no one could force you to break the precepts. It’s always been your decision, and that decision has become unthinkable because the danger in it is clear.

> About my other questions, about endurance on the “right level” and the body posture context, am I on the right track? And likewise for finding the line with proliferation of thoughts and mere observation.

You can forget about that for now.

The right level is not something you do or create; it’s when what you will *not* do (because it’s unwholesome) is crystal clear, and abstaining from it is effortless because the mind has been trained to that degree.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Puthujjana381 *2026-01-13 10:51:20* ### Possibility and eventuality

Dhamma eye

The insight of the dhamma eye is usually phrased as “whatever has the nature to manifest also has the nature to cease” [yaṁ kiñci samudayadhammaṁ sabbaṁ taṁ nirodhadhammaṁ].

Stronger statement

However, I think a few times now I've encountered (for example in Right Way of Striving) the seemingly stronger statement that "whatever has the nature of arising, because of that it *will* have to cease".

I don't think the stronger statement that something *will* cease follows from the fact that it *might*. It's possible for something to be perpetually liable to cessation, yet for it never to actually cease.

So I'm trying to understand in what sense the stronger statement is true and how to see it. I'll write down my current thoughts on it, and would like to invite anyone with better clarity to respond and help me understand.

- First of all, I'm not sure if the stronger statement in such a from form appears in the suttas, the closest things I can think of are:
  - It could have not been, and it wouldn't be for me, it won't be, it won't be for me [no cassa no ca me siyā, na bhavissati na me bhavissati] (little hard to translate to English I think, since English mixes up tenses with optative)
  - Impermanent indeed are constituents, of a nature to appear and vanish; having appeared they cease, their settling is happiness [Aniccā vata saṅkhārā, uppādavayadhammino; Uppajjitvā nirujjhanti, tesaṁ vūpasamo sukho]
- I believe Ñāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities…) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.
- In fact, in some Dhamma talks, in order to counter the common aversive thought of "oh, this is impermanent, it will cease" to try to soothe one's discomfort, it's recommended to think "no, this is permanent, it will last forever". I see how both of these are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.
- I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true *for a sotāpanna*?

> Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity. Until that eternity ceases?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-16 04:55:34*

> I believe Ñāṇavīra Thero addresses this question to some extent in Fundamental Structure II.5. My current takeaway would be that something arisen can endure for only so many eternities (of eternities of eternities…) before it will finally have to cease. This seems feasible, but I only see it to some extent and quite abstractly, and not sure how to make it more directly felt and concrete.

Yes, I wouldn't recommend going that route.

> I see how both of these are aimed at dispassion: seeing the impermanence undermines attachment to the dear, while seeing that something might endure forever undermines the aversion to the disliked. Yet the truth should somehow reconcile the two without contradiction.

And it does. Impermanence means that things both could end next moment or last "forever," as in far longer than however long you expect them to last. So whether you hope for novelty or permanence, your hopes are undercut by *anicca.*

> I wonder if the stronger statement is actually only true for a sotāpanna? Since they are said to know a phenomenon (e.g. feeling), its condition, its cessation and the path leading to its cessation. The puthujjana, not knowing the way leading to its cessation, is subject to the possibility of feeling for eternity.

No, no quite. That would assume that there is some overall situation of being subject to feeling independent of what is currently being felt, and that's not how it works. A puthujjana remains subject to one of the three specific feelings (MN 74), and there is no stability to be found there. Even if they wanted to experience nothing but displeasure and dismay (e.g. at being puthujjana), pleasure or neutrality would take over sooner or later.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Solip123 *2026-01-12 21:27:36* ### Mittasutta: satipaṭṭhāna practice for puthujjanas?

In the Mittasutta (SN 47.48) the Buddha tells the monks to teach "friends and colleagues, relatives and family" the four satipaṭṭhānas.

What do you make of this?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-13 05:08:41*

It doesn’t negate the prerequisites for *satipatthāna* established by a multitude of other Suttas, such as the one right before.

Try as you may, you will not be able to get someone who still looks for pleasure in the world to subdue longing and aversion in regard to the world. It’s like asking them to jump off a cliff.

At best, they will be able to shift their longing to a new thing in the world, and that, though very common today, is not *satipaṭṭhāna.*

zurvivl

Bhante, isn’t the root of Satipatthana Yoniso Manasikara, which is also the root of sense restraint. Wouldn’t teaching laypeople yoniso manasikara, only result in benefit? Wouldn’t it at least make them aware of their sensuality addiction, longing and suffering? If they have yoniso manasikara then they’ll know they won’t be able to satisfy their longing with objects. They’ll still be addicts at first, but at least they’ll be addicts aware of their problem.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-13 08:09:15*

That would only be possible if yoniso manasikāra was a quality independent of one’s choices, but it isn’t. Engaging and intending to engage in sensuality *is* ayoniso manasikāra.

zurvivl

But what comes first, the unwholesome intention, or the improper attending (ayoniso manasikara)?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-13 08:17:59*

Neither. They’re identical.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Silatigi1 *2026-01-12 00:41:45* ### Yoniso Manasikara in practice

Dear @Bhante Anigha

I have a very practical question about yoniso manasikara.

Let’s say a pressure comes and I have trained to let it be, to let it exists, aka not acting out of body (grab food, look at things to buy) and speech (swearing at the pain of sustaining the unpleasant pressure, crying at the difficulty of sustaining it), but not yet by mind (not sure yet about the signs and features, at the moment more trying to survive the wave of the screaming pressure, but with the cigarette that I stop smoking many many years ago I kind of get an inkling of what this could feel like).

Now the question is how do you practically apply yoniso manasikara, what is it that you discern from a first person perspective?

So the pressure is there, say a restlessness, and you let it be without acting, then thanks to that pressure being here and remaining here there is something that I can discern that I could not discern if it was not there, if I (seemingly) got rid of it by acting.

So in the metaphor it would be suddenly I feel the lead of the dog pulling me when I stand my ground. I can also relate to the dog differently for the first time, I experience the dog and the lead whereas before both were invisible together to me as a pair.

Or the current of the river, and the pole I hold on to. Without the pole, no current is felt. Or the spoiled child putting on a tantrum and my resolution not to give in.

So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

Anything concrete you could point to would be very helpful e.g ideally several different practical examples of pressure and what one could discern while enduring patiently the pressure.

Because unfortunately when I hear “with this, this” I don’t need necessarily concretely understand what the second “this” is when the first “this” is the pressure…

Thanks in advance for your help

Sil

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-13 04:56:19*

> So my question is what is it that you discern from a first person perspective when the pressure is present? What is that thing that could not be seen without that pressure?

The fact that all satisfaction of the pressure is actually still within suffering. You get to see first-hand that the presence of craving, not the lack of its fulfillment, is what suffering is.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Additional_Fix8417 *2026-01-09 15:24:05*
How Should Buddhist Cosmology be Interpreted?

Currently reading AN and noticed how characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” inflict pain on the man who in the past performed “bad kamma”.

Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine

the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

Should these stories be regarded metaphorically and that these characters are in a way manifestations of one’s own kamma? Mere lores largely inherited by preceding cultures and traditions?

Sutta reference: AN 3:36

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-11 10:29:29*

> Assuming the former two characters were true, would they have the choice (of action; kamma) to punish or not to punish the “evil doer,” thereby abandoning kamma for themselves? As such stories if taken literally may just undermine the legitimacy of the law of kamma in relation to re-becoming, since characters such as “King Yama” and “wardens of hell” may not have the choice not to act in a way that inflicts pain on another, whether or not that other individual “deserves” it).

No, that doesn’t follow at all. A soldier may have an extreme pressure on him to kill for his country, potentially facing severe consequences for refusing to do so. That doesn’t in any way diminish his accountability for killing.

Additional_Fix8417

Hi Bhante, thank you for your reply. But by “they” I’m referring to “King Yama” and “wardens of hell”

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-11 11:56:23*

Yes, that’s what I’m referring to as well. Them being born to perform those roles doesn’t mean they’re not responsible for actually performing them. So the principle of kamma still applies.

It’s no different than how human existence is made for sensuality and reproduction. If you want liberation, you don’t do what your birth is meant for.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by Solip123 *2026-01-07 06:06:35* ### What should I do if I struggle to discern intentions of greed, aversion, or delusion?

Will this become easier to do as I become established in the precepts?

I’ve been trying to keep the precepts and gradually add more of them, but I find myself largely unable to tell when my intentions are rooted in craving. I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to ‘triangulate’ it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it. This is also often doesn’t

work. I will often ask myself “why do I want to do this?” or “why am I doing this / why did I do that?” and in response there will be nothing, just a blank mind.

Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-10 20:17:07*

> I can sort of look at the amount of pressure, the overall hedonic tone, and question the content of the intentions in an attempt to ‘triangulate’ it, but I sense that this is not the right way of going about it.

Yes, that’s going to be abstract.

What you have to do is (1) not be breaking the eight precepts currently, (2) not forget that you will not do so no matter what happens (this means avoiding anything that obfuscates that conscious commitment even when it aids external restraint, chiefly meditation techniques). That’s it. The mind will certainly try to sneak out of that confinement in the beginning, but there will be no opening if those two things are maintained. Eventually it will calm down and start to genuinely prefer staying within the boundaries.

> Also, I have an additional (and somewhat related) question: what am I supposed to do when I am trying to keep the eight precepts (or something near that)? The boredom kicks in very quickly.

As part of the effort to keep the precepts, you *can’t* do anything besides not forgetting that you won’t intentionally break them under any circumstances. Finding something additional to do in the name of practice would compromise point #2 above. As for things unrelated to the practice that you might do, you can’t decide that in advance. It’s whatever comes up despite the deliberate commitment to the precepts remaining ironclad.

Solip123

Thanks, Bhante.

I’m working toward keeping the full eight or nine precepts (not counting the one about not eating after a certain time, because I can’t get enough calories if I limit myself to one meal a day, but I would still like to reduce the tendency to eat for pleasure), including the mental side of the equation, but I’m not there just yet.

Regarding this:

> As part of the effort to keep the precepts, you *can’t* do anything besides not forgetting that you won’t intentionally break them under

> any circumstances. Finding something additional to do in the name of practice would compromise point #2 above.

I'm guessing that consuming content about the Dhamma for hours each day would count? I guess I don't know what to do with myself if I'm not distracting myself in some form, and since I got rid of deliberate engagement in coarse entertainment like TV, movies, video games, certain forms of social media, this seems to be how I do so now, at least some of the time. But I still have difficulty discerning when, exactly, I am doing so out of distraction.

I'm also very bad at restraining intentions rooted in aversion. Even when I notice it, it's usually after I've already done so, or I sometimes rationalize that I will just do that thing later even though there's no reason why it couldn't be done right now. This mostly manifests as procrastination and feeds into the tendency to distract/entertain myself in subtler ways than before.

Further, what would you suggest in terms of contemplations for trying to discern the peril of sensuality (for those times where I am abiding free of sensuality, distraction, and company)? I'm not sure how I'm supposed to go about this. Apologies if this question has an obvious answer.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-12 05:49:15*

The problem is that you're still thinking in terms of what to do. That's inevitably going to leave you susceptible to doubt. If you know what you're not going to do, you will completely stop caring about what you will do. And what you're not going to do is break any of the precepts.

If the intention never to pursue unwholesome content like TV, movies, etc. is crystal clear, then whatever intention there is to consume Dhamma content will not be problematic because it won't be leaning towards entertainment. It's because the boundary is unclear, not because of any neutral actions, that there is still pressure towards the full breach (if you were to abstain from consuming Dhamma content and just stare at the wall, the same pressure towards entertainment would be felt because you're still not clear about what you won't do).

As for the peril of sensuality, breaking the precepts is what sensuality is, so the peril is discerned in regard to those specific actions. When their danger is evident, there is no way to maintain even the most fleeting intentions towards them. Instead of hunting for those fleeting intentions, which will be an endless and ultimately unsuccessful task, you ruin the appeal of what all of them point towards, so they all wither away.

Solip123

> It's because the boundary is unclear, not because of any neutral actions, that there is still pressure towards the full breach (if you were to abstain from consuming Dhamma content and just stare at

> the wall, the same pressure towards entertainment would be felt because you're still not clear about what you won't do).

So, I should stop indulging in less coarse forms of entertainment/distraction first and then consuming the Dhamma content shouldn't be an issue anymore?

> As for the peril of sensuality, breaking the precepts is what sensuality is, so the peril is discerned in regard to those specific actions. When their danger is evident, there is no way to maintain even the most fleeting intentions towards them. Instead of hunting for those fleeting intentions, which will be an endless and ultimately unsuccessful task, you ruin the appeal of what all of them point towards, so they all wither away.

So, if I understand correctly, the mental withdrawal from (read: devaluing of) sensuality will occur naturally as a result of abstaining from sensuality for a long enough period of time?

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-14 05:16:00*

> So, I should stop indulging in less coarse forms of entertainment/distraction first and then consuming the Dhamma content shouldn't be an issue anymore?

No, you don't take for granted that you will consume Dhamma content. You maintain the context that you won't be pursuing the obvious forms of entertainment, and if the pursuit of Dhamma content had an intention leaning in the direction of those coarser things then it will be clear and you won't be engaging with Dhamma at that time. Intention is the leaning towards the obvious action even if it never ends up being done.

> So, if I understand correctly, the mental withdrawal from (read: devaluing of) sensuality will occur naturally as a result of abstaining from sensuality for a long enough period of time?

No, physically abstaining from it won't do much by itself. Within the physical withdrawal, you have to contemplate the peril and communicate to your mind that it should under no circumstances go there. The point is that that contemplation is in relation to the specific actions and situations outlined by the precepts, not in regard to some abstract idea of sensuality that extends to everything and nothing.

BhikkhuSubhara

> breaking the precepts is what sensuality is, so the peril is discerned in regard to those specific actions.
>
> Intention is the leaning towards the obvious action even if it never ends up being done.

> contemplation is in relation to the specific actions and situations outlined by the precepts, not in regard to some abstract idea of sensuality that extends to everything and nothing.

This was very practically clarifying, bhante, especially the idea that the unwholesome is anything that leans towards the obvious actions. There is still, though, a certain sense that sensuality has to be something more than merely the leaning towards breaking the precepts. The confinement within suffering feels too general, not wanting to be in pain feels too fundamental to disappear on the sufficient condition that I would never kill or steal or lie in order to put an end to my pain. But I have faith that that feeling is just a symptom of my own insufficient discernment.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-16 05:29:49*

> There is still, though, a certain sense that sensuality has to be something more than merely the leaning towards breaking the precepts.

It is. The root of sensuality is the lack of internal clarity that sensuality will not be returned to. If there's unclarity (muddledness/delusion), then sensuality still looms even if no explicit intentions towards it are present now. By itself, the latter is just the state of an infant (MN 78).

See also this comment.

Solip123 *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Thanks, Bhante.

> The point is that that contemplation is in relation to the specific actions and situations outlined by the precepts, not in regard to some abstract idea of sensuality that extends to everything and nothing.

This is helpful, but I'm still not sure if I'm doing it rightly.

I recently spent some time in seclusion trying to apply this and I started out by trying to actively reflect on my current restraint, past indulgences, etc., but it didn't really seem to have any effect. And at a certain point it dawned on me that I genuinely had no clue what I was doing, and as such I began to worry that I would never figure it out.

I then made use of the angst that this provoked by applying this frame of mind to not acting out with regard to the precepts, by reflecting on the fact that I am entirely clueless about the way out of suffering and that every time I give into craving, I am digging myself deeper without knowing how to get out. And I tried to apply this line of reasoning to each of the things I struggle with (in terms of precepts/not acting out) and to my sometimes-borderline lackadaisical attitude.

Is this a reasonable way of going about it, or is this style of contemplation faulty? It felt a bit contrived, but I'm not sure how else I should be doing this.

It occurred to me that maybe the issue is that I'm not been restrained enough / am not vigilant enough about my restraint yet. It has after all only been a couple of weeks since I committed to this undertaking.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-16 05:39:29*

> Is this a reasonable way of going about it, or is this style of contemplation faulty?

Yes, because it's edging towards an undefined result. What you have to do is simply reflect on your intention to keep the precepts unconditionally, and if the mind's reaction to that is at least neutral, your work is done for now, and you just have to make sure that you don't obfuscate that intention (which is how the opposite intentions begin to take root). If there is internal push-back against that intention of restraint (including in the form of doubt, not just coarse desire), *then* you make the effort to clarify the danger in breaking the precepts.

like_a_raft *(in reply to Bhikkhu_Anigha)*

Regarding this line: "As part of the effort to keep the precepts, you can't do anything besides not forgetting that you won't intentionally break them under any circumstances."

I think I know what you mean, but I can't understand the wording (either that or there's a word missing.)

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-13 08:15:39*

There's no word missing. I meant that keeping the precepts is done by choosing to keep the precepts. Any other choice has to be done with that primary choice enduring as background, not in place of it.

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r/HillsideHermitage | Posted by rs_87_78 *2026-01-06 07:27:37* ### After Recognizing Sensuality as Bait for Hindrances : Right Effort to protect one from that sinking feeling.

Hello fellow practitioners,

Through first hand experience, I understand that Gross Sensuality is a trap. It is the gateway to craving which leaves one vulnerable to the other 4 hindrances.

However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

Are there any interesting hobbies you guys have inculcated that reinforce wholesome states of mind ? Something that mitigates dependent behavior tendencies while also reinforcing a sense of meaning.

Which brings me to another query : If one is through conduct, abandon the aggregates, with the intention of abandoning ownership of a self, is there no room for Self-Worth ? Wouldn't this line of thinking create a void that exacerbates vulnerability to the hindrances ?

Warm regards.

Bhikkhu_Anigha *2026-01-06 17:04:29*

> However, I now find myself overly vigilant, guilty and a little helpless and restless. If conditional experiences are unsatisfactory and impermanent, what am I to extract a subtler more refined form of peace (Joy) from ?

That's normal, and the solution is not to find something to relieve that confinement; it's to get used to it, which requires not going outside of it, i.e., breaking the precepts. When it gets used to it the mind will stop resisting it, and it will cease to be unpleasant. That cessation of resistance to restraint, without anything added on top, is the only type of joy that is in line with the Dhamma, since it comes craving falling away, not from fulfilling the same need in a more refined way.

The latter keeps the mind from protesting in the immediate present, but it also means no internal training will occur even if the precepts are kept externally.
